

REIDAR DALE

# EVALUATING DEVELOPMENT PROGRAMMES AND PROJECTS

SECOND EDITION

# EVALUATING DEVELOPMENT PROGRAMMES AND PROJECTS

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Development Programmes and Projects*

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*Asian Studies Review*

# EVALUATING DEVELOPMENT PROGRAMMES AND PROJECTS

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SECOND EDITION

Reidar Dale



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## FOREWORD

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Evaluation is *à la mode* today. In public health policy, education, research and technology, criminal justice and, of course, development work, including international development cooperation, etc., evaluation is playing an increasingly important role. Issues of evaluation methodology, execution and use have come under review by a growing number of evaluation societies that have sprung up in recent decades all over the world, especially in the USA, Canada and Europe.

Evaluation has, indeed, come a long way since its timid beginnings.

Let me cast a short look at my own 'evaluation history'. In the late sixties I joined, as a recently appointed young official of the European Commission, the staff of the Directorate General for Development of what was then the European Economic Community (EEC) composed of the six founding nations (today, the European Union [EU] composed of 25 member states). I was responsible for agricultural development projects in Western Africa. It was shortly after my appointment that we launched, as I still vividly recall, our very first 'evaluation mission'. A colleague of mine, a professional architect, was sent to one of the countries of that region to ascertain 'what had become' of a school building project the European Development Fund had financed there a couple of years previously. I must have been much impressed—otherwise I would have forgotten the whole story long ago—by the main conclusion of my colleague's 'evaluation report': that the size of the ventilation openings under the roofs of the school buildings in question should have been of smaller dimensions, as the prevailing winds at the beginning of the rainy season were liable to drive the rain into the schoolrooms.

As I have said, evaluation of development cooperation has made some progress since then: it went beyond the 'technical' dimension when discovering the economic one as well; it went on to include

socio-cultural considerations; and finally, it included the evaluation function into 'project cycle management' (PCM) as a whole, a methodological approach that the Evaluation Division of the Directorate General for Development of the European Commission, of which I had become the head, conceived and introduced into operational practice in the mid-eighties.

There seems to remain, however, one important (unresolved), problem area that has persisted into the twenty-first century: the pernicious tendency of evaluators of any school of thought, whatever may be the subject matter of their research, in industrialised as well as in developing countries, to keep themselves to themselves, that is, above all, out of the way of planners and implementers. Evaluators seem to be jealous of their particular field of competence and reluctant to recognise the almost inextricable links and relationships that (in fact) bind them almost automatically to other disciplines. True, 'positivism' and the concern for 'objectivity' have made ample room for 'constructivist', 'post modern' tendencies admitting to the obvious fact that the evaluator will necessarily be influenced by the 'evaluated' as well as by the 'evaluating', and will thus be deprived of the virginity of independent judgement. There is even a school of thought that has striven to imbue with realism their approach to real-world problems to such an extent that they call their method 'Realistic Evaluation'. Yet, instead of concentrating on the projects and programmes as planned by those in charge, they prefer 're-inventing' the programme theory so as to find out 'what works for whom in what circumstances'. Small wonder that evaluations have so often failed 'to make a difference' in real-world situations!

I suspect, then, that my own view will not entirely coincide with that of the majority of my fellow evaluators (I shall nonetheless dare to formulate it): *the objective of evaluators should be identical with that of planners and implementers: create sustainable benefits for the target groups of projects, programmes and policies.*

This does not necessarily mean that evaluators should always go along with the objectives pursued by planners, implementers and beneficiaries, although, in the majority of projects and programmes that will be the case. If not, then there should be a dialogue among all of these parties in order to correct the objectives and as a consequence to adapt the measures to obtain it. But whatever may be the circumstances of each individual case, the evaluator should always be one of a *team of actors* working together in pursuit of a

common purpose. Planning, implementation and evaluation should be part and parcel of one and the same project/programme cycle. It is true that evaluators have long ago decided to leave Olympus. It is now time for them to join the fray.

I am not entirely sure whether or not Reidar Dale, the author of the book introduced by this foreword, shares in every respect the opinion voiced above. I am sure, however, that he would not even dream of separating planning from evaluation or evaluation from planning (as many evaluators tend to do).

I have good reasons to believe that Dale favours such close amalgamation: I was privileged to write the foreword not only for his present work on evaluation but also for his recently published book *Development Planning: Concepts and Tools for Planners, Managers and Facilitators*. I consider these two works twins, true companion volumes, and so, I am convinced, does he. I have yet to spot another author on evaluation who breaks more radically with the 'stand-alone' stance on evaluation than Dale. And therefore I think that his book on the evaluation of development programmes and projects is the most modern, the most up-to-date, that exists today. It appears to me to be advancing—in a unique way closely linked to the author's solid professional background—the practical science of evaluating societal development work through its comprehensive coverage, holistic approach, and by mirroring the 'hands-on' wisdom that goes with years of practical experience.

Let us have a rapid look at the contents of that book to substantiate this view:

Right from the start, in Part One of the book, when setting out the general conceptual and analytical framework, Dale presents underlying concepts of rationality that stick closely to real-life situations, echoing the resolutely action-oriented approach he follows in his book on planning. Linking evaluation to modes of planning and to the concepts of 'programme' and 'project', Dale goes on to discuss the nature of evaluation as distinct from 'appraisal' and 'monitoring' and then turns to the dynamic aspects of means-ends analysis, showing how planning and evaluation are just different ways of looking at the same issues. The first part of the book ends with an analysis of the societal context, and I am convinced that even the stoutest 'realists' among evaluators will admit that the author is thoroughly aware of the fact that benefit creation for intended beneficiaries will only 'materialise' when closely moulding applied mechanisms to

the specific external, or contextual, project/programme environment being analysed, which will, of course, be found to be different in each specific case.

In Part Two of the book, Dale sets out the general framework made up of the classical categories of relevance, impact, efficiency, effectiveness, sustainability and replicability, and then turns to organisational questions and issues of capacity-building. I have noted with particular interest an aspect that struck me also at the time of reading the draft of Dale's book on planning: the importance he places on people, and the way they can best cooperate for development through adequate organisation. 'Capacity-building' is a key to achieving this, being true for the individual *and* the organisation s/he belongs to. Again, one is struck by the way Dale is able to amalgamate, on the basis of his ample practical experience, theory and practice, especially, when he highlights the enormous complexity, and therefore the bewildering uncertainty, that besets all societal processes. The author is modest enough to admit his own limitations, and those that any professional approach to planning or to evaluation will encounter when faced with the unfathomable intricacies and inevitable surprises, both good and bad, that real life always has in store.

In Part Three, Dale turns to the nitty-gritties of the evaluator's craftsmanship. True, the limitations just mentioned exist, but there is so much one can do in spite of these limitations if one has learned to apply the numerous instruments at the evaluator's disposal that will, when correctly handled, lead to worthwhile results in terms of improved development results. Correct timing of evaluations, methods of data gathering, the optimal mix between quantitative and qualitative design according to each concrete case, economic tools, the choice of indicators of achievement, are all considered. The author's resolute orientation towards the solution of real-life problems seems to make him almost automatically wary of an exaggerated faith in quantitative or quantifiable judgements and much more open to qualitative inquiry and modes of evaluation. He insists on the advantages of managing the evaluation process bottom-up with and for the people concerned, while not ruling out entirely the conventional top-down donor approach, and he emphasises the need for practical feedback of evaluation results allowing for 'empowering' learning for all stakeholders and creating that 'we-can-do-it' feeling so vital for lasting success. This is the 'philosophy' that the reader

will have absorbed, or so I hope, after reading Reidar Dale's book on evaluation of development programmes and projects.

What more is there to say? That this book will 'grow' on the reader as s/he follows Dale's voyage from thought to action in a convincingly structured presentation? That Dale avoids jargon and sticks to a comprehensive, unpretentious, clear and reader-friendly style? That the reader will feel more and more involved, as each argument unfolds and gives rise to the following one, in what comes close to a dialogue with the author on each of the issues addressed? I have, however, already said all of this when writing the foreword to the 'twin' of the present publication: Dale's recently published book on planning. These statements are certainly true for this book as well (and so it is worthwhile repeating them). I have also appreciated the comprehensive use of case material and various other illustrations Dale uses to connect the issues discussed to real-life contexts.

I would be happy to see this book in the hands of:

- teachers and students of development-focused academic courses in universities;
- trainers and participants in other courses on development planning and evaluation;
- development cooperation policy makers, planners and evaluators in governmental and non-governmental organisations, in both less developed and highly developed countries;
- international and national agencies involved in development cooperation, including UN agencies and the World Bank, national governmental development agencies and NGOs.

As my concluding remark, I think the best I can do is to repeat what I had concluded in my foreword to Dale's book on planning:

I have read the draft of Reidar Dale's book on evaluation with growing interest. I have been privileged to be of assistance by providing him with a certain number of observations, which my own practical experience during four decades in the area of international development cooperation has led me to formulate. I warmly recommend this work to all those who, like myself, believe that the integration of planning, implementation and evaluation into a consistent approach to project/programme cycle management holds the promise to lead to lasting improvements in the quality of organised

development work, public and private, including international development cooperation.

Brussels  
2004

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## PREFACE TO THE SECOND EDITION

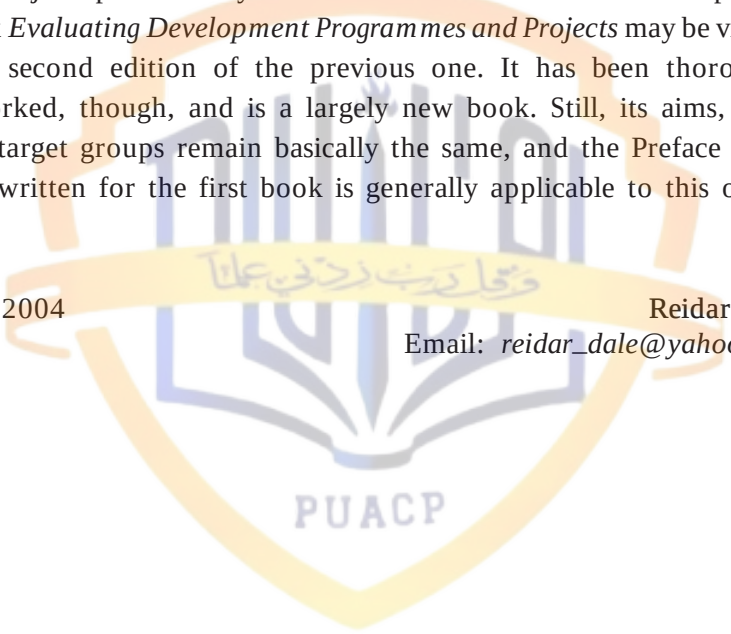
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In 1998 I wrote *Evaluation Frameworks for Development Programmes and Projects* published by SAGE. That book has sold well. The present book *Evaluating Development Programmes and Projects* may be viewed as a second edition of the previous one. It has been thoroughly reworked, though, and is a largely new book. Still, its aims, focus and target groups remain basically the same, and the Preface that I had written for the first book is generally applicable to this one as well.

July 2004

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## PREFACE TO THE FIRST EDITION

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‘Evaluation’ is a broad and many-faceted concept. The literature on evaluation is equally diverse. It ranges from presentations of general ideas and perspectives, via prescriptive frameworks for practitioners, to advanced texts on methodology.

This book deals with evaluation of *organised development work*, referred to as development programmes and projects. Its frame of reference is such work in developing countries; however, the conceptual and methodological framework and most of the more specific ideas and arguments are relevant more widely.

The book covers the major topics of *context, perspectives, methods and management* of evaluations, and I have endeavoured to connect these in a systematic, stepwise argument. To this end, I start out with a brief account of main perspectives and types of planning (constituting the basis of any organised development work); connect planning, implementation and monitoring to evaluation; seek to clarify purposes and aims of evaluations; incorporate and discuss factors of organisation and management; present a range of methods which may be used in evaluations; and briefly address presentation and use of evaluation results.

This *interconnected analysis* of the main facets of evaluation distinguishes the book from most other evaluation literature.

The book also differs from most literature on evaluation of development work in that the scope of analysis is extended from *projects* to encompass different kinds of *programmes* as well. In doing so, I build on the conventional project matrix (the ‘logical framework’), but break its limitations by taking cognisance of the complex and processual nature of societal development and corresponding perspectives on development work.

I have conscientiously tried to make the book easy to comprehend for a diverse group of potential readers. To this end, a highly scientific terminology has been avoided; terms that require clarification are

explained in simple language; issues are exemplified in the text; and the text is supplemented with numerous diagrams and textboxes, the latter mainly containing more detailed examples.

In order to facilitate a broad presentation and to maintain focus on interconnections between topics and factors, I do not explore specific issues in great detail. The reader is, instead guided to more specialised literature in various fields, through references in the main text and in footnotes and through the Bibliography presented at the end of the book. This limitation also keeps the size of the book down to a number of pages that most readers should find appealing.

While I hope that the book will attract a broad *readership*, the primary target group is practitioners in development work. These include, of course, people who conduct evaluations, but in addition a range of planners, managers and administrators who ought to be familiar with concepts and tools of evaluation. By directly linking evaluation with planning and organisation, I hope to promote evaluation as a more integral part of development work than it has tended to be seen and, consequently, as a concern for whole development organisations.

The book should also be of interest to teaching institutions and students in development planning and management as well as in other fields of organisation and social science. Students may also find it useful for its overview of concepts and perspectives of development work and for its discussion of methods of study, which have relevance well beyond the field of evaluation.



## PART ONE



# EVALUATION IN CONTEXT

وَقُلْ رَبِّ زِدْنِي عِلْمًا

PUACP

# Chapter 1

## GENERAL CONCEPTUAL AND ANALYTICAL FRAMEWORK

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### CONCEPTUALISING DEVELOPMENT AND DEVELOPMENT WORK

The word ‘development’ may be used in numerous contexts. In all these contexts, it denotes some kind of change. It may also express a state that has been attained through some noticeable change, for instance, in the construct ‘level of development’. Beyond that, the term carries a variety of more specific meanings. It may be utilised normatively (expressing a desirable process or state) or empirically (expressing a substantiated process or state without any explicit value connotation).

In the present book, the concept is used *normatively* in the context of *human societies*. In this sense, development—which we may also refer to as ‘societal development’—is conceived by people with reference to something that they perceive as valuable. The underlying values may be more or less overt or hidden, and they may reflect different kinds of rationality (see later in this chapter). Thus, most briefly stated, development is viewed as a process of societal change that generates some perceived benefits for people, or as a state of perceived quality of life attained through such a process (see also Eggers, 2000a; 2000b; 2002; Dale, 2000).

Moreover, when analysing development, we should normally be able to clarify who benefits from societal changes and, in cases of diverging opinions about benefits, who considers changes to be beneficial and who does not.

Development being a people-focused concept, its contents in specific situations must be clarified in relation to people-related *problems*.

We may broadly refer to human problems as 'poverty' and 'deprivation' (Chambers, 1983; 1995; Dale, 2000). Poverty is the more overt and specific concept of the two. It is usually taken to mean few and simple assets, low income and low consumption, and sometimes also an unreliable supply of cash and food. Deprivation frequently includes poverty (in the mentioned sense), but may encompass several other features of human misery or suffering. Thus, Chambers (1983) considers deprived households as having the following typical features, in varying combinations: poverty, physical weakness (in terms of the structure of the households and abilities of household members), isolation (physically and information-wise), vulnerability (little resistance to unexpected or occasionally occurring events), and powerlessness. According to Chambers, many such features tend to be interrelated, locking households into what he calls a deprivation trap. Dale (2000) presents a somewhat more detailed typology of deprivation, in which individual-related problems (such as mental suffering, poor health and illiteracy) are also more explicitly emphasised.

Normally, deprivations beyond overt manifestations of poverty are difficult or even impossible to express by any objective measure; they will, therefore, largely have to be assessed through subjective judgement. Of course, this also applies to changes on the respected dimensions.

Connecting to such diverse manifestations of human deprivation, Dale (2000) suggests a general typology of dimensions of development. The dimensions briefly summarised, are:

- *economic features:*  
income and income-related characteristics, expressed through phenomena such as Gross Domestic Product (GDP) per capita, income distribution, rate of employment, etc., at the macro or group level; and income, consumer assets, production assets, etc., at the level of the household or, less frequently, the individual;
- *social features:*  
various aspects of social well-being, expressed through phenomena such as life-expectancy at birth, child mortality, school enrolment, etc., at the macro or group level; and health, level of literacy, social security, etc., at the level of the household or the individual;
- *dependent versus independent position:*  
degree of bondage or, oppositely, freedom in making one's own

choices about aspects of one's life or lives, expressed through features such as degree and terms of indebtedness, degree of competition for scarce resources, degree of inequality or equality of gender relations, etc.;

- *marginalised versus integrated position:*  
degree and terms of participation in markets, politics and social life, and type and strength of economic and social security networks;
- *degree of freedom from violence:*  
the extent to which individuals and groups may lead their lives without deliberate mental or physical maltreatment or fear of such maltreatment, within the family and in the wider society;
- *degree of mental satisfaction:*  
degree of mental peace, and the ability to enrich one's life through intangible stimuli;
- *survival versus development-oriented attitude:*  
perception of one's position, abilities and opportunities in the society, at the level of the social group, household or individual.

Obviously, these dimensions or indicators may be expressed or used more or less normatively or empirically.<sup>1</sup>

All the mentioned dimensions of development may be addressed in planned development work of various kinds, referred to as development programmes and projects (to be better clarified in Chapter 2).

The presented framework should also have substantiated that development is characterised by unique features in specific settings, great diversity and high complexity. Additionally, processes of development are often little predictable and may be changing, for a variety of reasons. This pulls in the direction of primarily qualitative means of analysing development, and poses strict limitations to the possibility of directly replicating development interventions.

In addition to features under the above-mentioned categories, many aspects of institutions and infrastructure may be viewed as development variables of a causal kind. Examples of the former may be the possibility for people to form their own organisations and the effectiveness of public administration. Examples of the latter may be road density and physical standards of various facilities. Of course, development programmes and projects commonly address such aspects.

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<sup>1</sup> See Dale, 2004 (Chapter 1) for a further elaboration of this point.



The above has direct implications for the evaluation of development programmes and projects, in terms of the evaluations' overall purpose, focus, scope and methodology.

## EVALUATION IN THE CONTEXT OF DEVELOPMENT WORK

Literally, evaluation means 'assessing the value of'. Evaluations are undertaken in all spheres of life, informally or more formally, whenever one wants to know and understand the consequences of some event or action. Sometimes, one may want to better know how and why things have happened or are happening, or how and why things have been done or are being done. These general purposes are often more or less related. Also, one usually uses the knowledge and understanding acquired from an evaluation to perform a similar activity better, or to plan some related action, in the future. In other instances, the emphasis may be more on generating effective responses to events or changes that are beyond one's control. In either case, one tries to learn from one's assessment in order to improve one's performance.

Our concern is evaluation of planned and organised development work.

With *planned* work we mean activities that have been premeditated and for which some guide has been worked out in advance. In programmes and projects, this usually also means that one or more plan documents have been worked out. As we shall clarify later, there may be various kinds of plans, and they may have been prepared initially or during the course of the programme or project period.

In systematically premeditated (i.e., *planned*) development work, it is common to distinguish between the main activity categories of planning, implementation and monitoring. Very briefly stated, 'planning' is a process of problem analysis, assessment of possible measures to address clarified problems, and decision-making for problem-focused action. 'Implementation' is the process of transforming allocated resources into outputs, considered necessary to attain the objectives of the particular development thrust. 'Monitoring' is a continuous or frequent (usually regular) assessment of implementation and its outcomes. These basic activities of problem- and solution-focused analysis, decision-taking, action and reflection are undertaken in all sensible development endeavours—even if they may at times be done too informally for the thrusts to be called programmes or projects.

‘Evaluation’ is closely related to monitoring. Sometimes, it may even be difficult to distinguish between them and to decide which of the two terms one should use in particular cases of performance assessment. In other cases, the distinction is clearer. In other words, these work categories may be partly overlapping, but are not identical. We shall soon discuss this matter more comprehensively and clarify differences better. For now, let us just say that an evaluation tends to be a less frequent, more time-bound and more comprehensive effort than monitoring, commonly also focusing more explicitly on benefits to people and fulfilment of objectives of the evaluated scheme.

A more specific activity category may be ‘appraisal’, and development work may also involve ‘operation’ and ‘maintenance’ of created facilities. We shall soon distinguish appraisal from evaluation, and we shall later see how evaluations may connect to operation and maintenance.

Development programmes and projects are also *organised* thrusts. That is, the activities are undertaken by some organisation or organisations—which may be more or less formalised—and are intended to be performed in accordance with certain organisation-based principles, rules and systems. This has two main implications for evaluations: these will then also be organised thrusts, and aspects of organisation of the evaluated scheme will (or should) normally be subjected to assessment.

As already stated, development programmes and projects are (or should be) unambiguously *people-focused*, in the sense of promoting improvements in some aspects of some people’s quality of life. Evaluations tend to be seen as the main tool for ascertaining such improvements for intended beneficiaries. We shall, in fact, consider consequences of work that is done for people (intended beneficiaries and sometimes others) to be the overriding concern of evaluations in the development realm. Simultaneously, this may be linked to assessment of more specific and even additional aspects of programmes and projects, as shall be duly clarified later in the book.

For analysing changes relating to people, one needs to view the programme or project under study in a broad *societal context*. That is, one cannot limit oneself to aspects internal to the development scheme, but must also address relations between the programme or project and numerous aspects of its surroundings (environment). Commonly, the interface between the scheme and its environment may not be any clear-cut dividing line, but a porous and often changing

boundary—a fact that may make such contextual analysis highly challenging.

In consequence of the above, thorough evaluations tend to be relatively *comprehensive*, in the sense that they cover many topics and issues. This may not allow for deep analysis of single factors. However, for explanation of findings, specific economic, technical, cultural, institutional and other factors may have to be analysed, some even in great detail.

Evaluation of development work may be undertaken during the implementation of a programme or project or after it has been completed. This will depend on the overriding purpose of the exercise, but it may be influenced by other factors as well. In terms of overall purpose, we shall soon make a broad distinction between *formative* and *summative* evaluation.

One may, in principle, use a wide range of *methods* of evaluation, from the most rigorous statistical ones to purely qualitative assessments and personal interpretations. The range of applicable methods depends in practice on the nature of the development programme or project to be evaluated, the issues that are being analysed, the evaluator and numerous features and conditions in the surrounding society. Usually, the focus on people and the complex and changing nature of societies makes most statistical methods little applicable. Thus, a point that we have already alluded to and shall substantiate later (particularly in Part Three), insightful and informative evaluations of development work will normally require predominantly qualitative analysis, possibly supplemented with some quantitative data that may exist or may be generated.

## UNDERLYING CONCEPTIONS OF RATIONALITY

Normally, approaches to evaluation will be influenced by the ideology (the general logic) underpinning the development thrust to be assessed, as perceived by those involved in, or influenced by, that thrust. A scientific word for this perceived logical foundation is 'rationality'.

All development work should be rational, according to the normal understanding and usage of the word. However, one ought to distinguish between various notions of rationality. In development work, this means that one should consider other conceptions of the term than the most conventional one, that of *instrumental* or *technical* rationality. In its 'pure' form, instrumental rationality is normally

understood as exclusive attention to and specification of means and ways of attaining predetermined goals.

With reference to Jurgen Habermas' well known and widely quoted typology of modes of reasoning (Habermas, 1975; 1984),<sup>2</sup> other main forms of rationality may be termed 'value-' or 'substantive rationality' and 'lifeworld-' or 'communicative rationality' respectively (Dixon and Sindall, 1994; Servaes, 1996; Healey, 1997).

In the perspective of development work, *value* rationality refers to the values that are embedded in possible or intended achievements of a development scheme, as perceived by the stakeholders in that scheme. Thus, it relates to the top levels of a means-ends structure of the scheme. It is incorporated in what we may refer to as 'normative' planning, being the logical opposite of 'functional' planning.<sup>3</sup>

*Lifeworld* rationality is the kind of reason that tends to be applied in day-to-day communication between people. It is contained in 'the worlds of taken for granted meanings and understandings, of everyday living and interaction, of emotions, traditions, myth, art, sexuality, religion, culture...' (Dixon and Sindall, 1994: 303). In such reasoning, 'we frequently do not separate "facts" from "values"... , [and] the whole process of reasoning and the giving of reasons, what we think is important and how we think we should express this and validate our reasoning claims [are] grounded in our cultural conceptions of ourselves and our worlds' (Healey, 1997: 51).

The rationality or combination of rationalities that underpins development work will directly influence the objectives of that work and therewith also various related design features, such as the types and magnitude of resources provided and different features of the organisation of the programme or project.

In development programmes and projects, the particular blending of rationalities may materialise through a combination of factors, such as: general political and administrative culture of the society; established policy of a donor agency; ideas of individuals involved in planning and management; and the constellation of actors in idea generation, plan formulation and decision-making.

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<sup>2</sup> Habermas refers to these modes as instrumental-technical, moral and emotive-aesthetic reasoning respectively.

<sup>3</sup> We shall address means-ends structures and briefly clarify the concepts of normative and functional planning in Chapter 4. For comprehensive analysis, see Dale, 2004.

Normally, formulation of means–ends structures (being a core exercise in much planning) is easiest when the components may be specified through basically instrumental reasoning. Equally normally, this is the case (a) when a clear and unambiguous goal has been set in advance, or such a goal is just assumed or at least not substantially explored by the planners, and (b) when the planning is done by professionals in the field. This is the situation in much planning. For instance, the district unit of a national roads department will normally not explore the needs of people and the usefulness for people of road building versus other development interventions. The only goal-related question it may normally address in planning is prioritisation between roads. The unit will mostly concentrate on how to build (or maintain) the respective roads and the resource inputs that are needed for construction (or maintenance). Intended benefits for people are then wholly or largely assumed (rather than analysed) in planning.

Evaluations may, of course, still explore such benefits and may even relate them to assumptions about benefits that have been made, to the extent the latter may be reasonably well clarified.

However, most of what we refer to as development work embeds goal analysis—to a larger or lesser extent, and in some form or another. One example of schemes in which goal analysis is fundamental and needs concerted and even continuous attention is relatively open-ended community development thrusts, depending on priorities and views of local stakeholders. In such cases, value rationality assumes prime importance.<sup>4</sup>

Consequently, most evaluations of schemes of this nature should also pay prime attention to aspects of benefit generation.

Value rationality tends to co-exist with lifeworld rationality: beyond the most basic physical needs, wants and priorities are subjectively experienced and culturally influenced, also meaning that reasoning about them will be lifeworld-based. Closely connected, the more interested parties (stakeholders) there are, the more is the tendency for perceived needs and interests to differ. And, the more the respective stakeholders are involved in assessing needs and interests, the more difficult it may be to agree on the relative importance of the latter. The same argument goes for agreeing on objectives of corresponding

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<sup>4</sup> Dale (2004) even defines ‘development planning’ as an exercise that explicitly involves goal analysis.

development schemes as well as ways and means of attaining whatever objectives may have been specified.

Given the need that we have alluded to for clarifying means–ends relations in development work (a point that will be further substantiated in Chapter 4), the question arises whether highly participatory development work may be at all rational. Dale (2004) argues that it may and should be: if one has any purposeful organised thrust in mind, even many and diverse stakeholders must normally be assumed to share at least basic ideas about what should be achieved and what needs to be done to that end. Although they may be general, such ideas will usually represent important guidelines for one's work. Commonly, they may also constitute a sufficient rationale for initial allocation of at least some resources and for other initial commitments.

Simultaneously, through iterative processes of purposeful thinking, decision-taking, action and reflection—typical of schemes of this kind—conceptions of priorities, feasibilities, how to do things, etc., may change. Decisions and actions at any time should still be based on the participants' best judgement at those points in time; that is, they should still be sound in the context of existing perceptions. Moreover, through a process of capacity building—being normally a main thrust of such programmes—the judgements may become more firmly based and sound over time. The perceptual framework for rational choice and action will then have changed.

In general conclusion, our basic argument is that lifeworld rationality is nothing more mysterious than some combination of value and instrumental rationality under perceptual frameworks that may differ from those of professionals (and normally expected to be used in conventional planning contexts). Simultaneously, that distinction is, in itself, a fundamental recognition in development practice.

Connecting to some reflections we have already made on this, there are four general and interrelated *implications for evaluations* of the question of rationality:

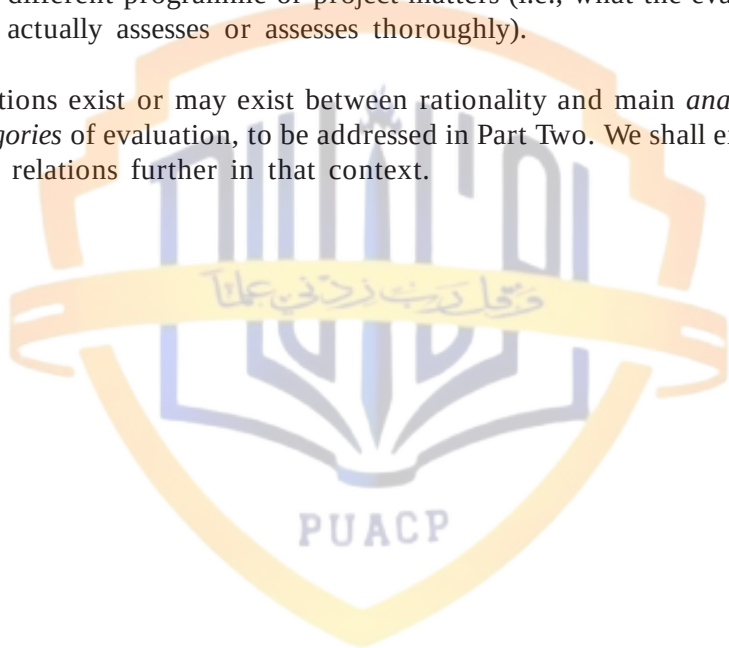
- by directly influencing the objectives of programmes and projects, the underlying rationality (or combination of rationalities) will also influence the focus and scope of evaluations of the particular schemes;
- a need exists for the evaluator to understand the perceived logic (the rationality) behind priorities and actions of planners and



managers, in order to make a relevant and fair judgement of programmes and projects that they have planned and are responsible for;

- different rationalities on the part of programme and project stakeholders may be a cause of collaboration problems or a reason for less than intended benefits, and may therefore have to be comprehensively explored; and
- the evaluator's own ideas of what is important and what is less so in development work may, if the evaluator is not very conscious about it, influence the emphasis that he or she places on different programme or project matters (i.e., what the evaluator actually assesses or assesses thoroughly).

Relations exist or may exist between rationality and main *analytical categories* of evaluation, to be addressed in Part Two. We shall explore such relations further in that context.



## Chapter 2

# PURPOSES OF EVALUATION

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### CHANGING VIEWS ON EVALUATION

Systematic evaluation of development programmes and projects was conceived and formalised from the 1960s onwards by donor agencies, which wanted a 'true' account of how well things had been done and what had been achieved. The idea was to have 'objective' assessments, done by 'independent' persons using 'professional' methods of data collection and analysis (Mikkelsen, 1995; Rubin, 1995). These perspectives were primarily promoted by engineers and economists, being the main professionals in donor agencies at these early stages of development co-operation. But they were also shared by many social scientists, reflecting a general emphasis in most social sciences at that time on obtaining what was considered as objectively verifiable knowledge and on concomitant quantification and statistical analysis.

Many evaluations are still done largely according to these principles. But alternative approaches have emerged. This is to a large measure due to experiences gained by development organisations, but the changes have also become more sanctioned by a new orientation of much social science. The core factor of this redirection has been an increased recognition that societal changes tend to occur through processes that are so complex that only fragments of a relevant and significant reality may be investigated objectively through standardised procedures. This calls for more case-specific, inductive and flexible evaluation designs. In addition, purposes of evaluations have become more varied, with significant implications for approach.

In general concord with Rubin (1995), we can clarify the main features of this revised perspective in somewhat more specific terms:



- a recognition of subjectivity in evaluation, i.e., that one can rarely give one 'true' account of what has happened and why;
- a recognition that interpretations of various involved or affected groups of people (stakeholders) may differ, and a view that all these should be recorded and understood, as far as possible;
- more emphasis on using evaluations to provide feedback of knowledge and ideas to further planning and implementation of the studied schemes, not just to sum up and explain their performance and achievements;
- an understanding that evaluations may be empowering processes, by which intended beneficiaries (and sometimes others) can themselves learn to analyse changes affecting their lives and therewith propose and sometimes even implement corrective, additional or new measures;
- a recognition that quantitative measures rarely provide much insight into complex cause-effect relations and structures, and that qualitative description and reflective verbal analysis are crucial for understanding processes of change;
- a tendency to use less rigid and standardised methods of inquiry, such as semi-structured interviews and participatory assessment.

Many of these points tend to be more or less related. In particular, the last-mentioned (use of less standardised methods) may be a consequence of one of more preceding points. Thus, it may be linked to the recognised need for getting the interpretations of different people; it may be motivated by a wish to have beneficiaries participate in evaluations (which requires use of methods of analysis that such people can understand and work with); and it may be because one finds it impossible to adequately describe and explain complex societal relations and processes by quantitative measures.

Moreover, some authors<sup>1</sup> have argued for and even noted a tendency in many evaluations towards:

- more emphasis on programme and project organisation and management.

This has methodological implications as well, in the general direction mentioned above: most analysis of organisational performance has to

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<sup>1</sup> See, for instance: Oakley et al., 1991; Dehar et al., 1993; Knox and Hughes, 1994; and Dixon, 1995.

be basically qualitative, in order to properly account for and understand the complex relations and processes that are typical in organised development work.

Stronger emphasis on organisation and management may also be connected to a more learning orientated approach, as generally mentioned above, and may sometimes be more specifically based on:

- a wish to use evaluations as learning exercises for responsible and executing bodies, through their own analysis or at least substantial involvement by such bodies in collaborative analysis.

As will be further discussed in Chapter 3, such generative and participatory modes of assessment may lie in the borderzone between monitoring and evaluation, and may often be referred to by either term.

## FORMATIVE AND SUMMATIVE EVALUATION

Depending on how the provided information is to be used, or primarily so, we may make a broad distinction between two main types of evaluation: 'formative' and 'summative'.<sup>2</sup>

Features and purposes of the two types are shown in Figure 2.1.

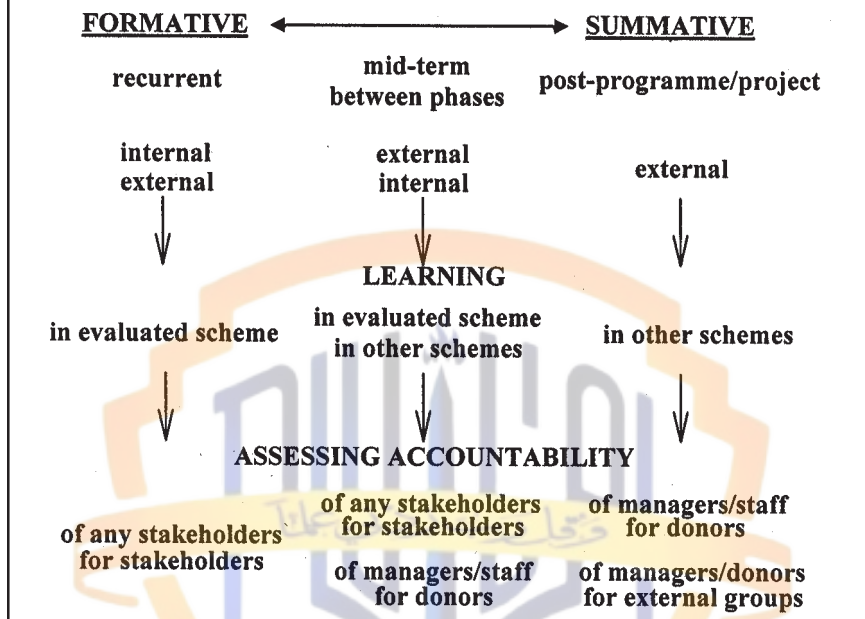
Formative evaluations aim at improving the performance of the programmes or projects that are evaluated, through *learning* from experiences gained. For most programmes, the scope for evaluations to induce changes of design and implementation may be substantial, since programmes tend to have a framework character and a greater or lesser amount of flexibility built into them. For typical projects, meaningful formative evaluations may usually only be done if the schemes are broken down into phases, each of which are preceded by planning events, in which information that is generated through assessment of previous phases may be used.<sup>3</sup>

Formative evaluations are commonly done more than once for a particular scheme. They may then recurrently address the same matters

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<sup>2</sup> These terms are also found in some other literature on research and evaluation, although they may not have been systematically paired for analytical purposes the way I do it here. See, for instance: Rubin, 1995; Dehar et al., 1993; and Rossi and Freeman, 1993.

<sup>3</sup> The concepts of 'programme' and 'project' in the development field will be further clarified later in this chapter.

**Figure 2.1****MAIN PURPOSES OF EVALUATIONS**

and issues or different ones. Commonly, each exercise may be fairly limited. The evaluations may be done at set intervals or according to needs, as assessed by the responsible agencies, in the course of programme or project implementation. They may be managed internally or externally, or through some combination of internal and external involvement.

Summative evaluations are undertaken after the respective development schemes have been completed. Their general purpose is to judge the worth of programmes or projects as well as, normally, their design and management. The findings may be used for *learning* in the planning and implementation of other, similar, development endeavours. Commonly, however, the more immediate concern is to assess the *accountability* of programme or project responsible bodies and/or funding agencies. In practice, summative evaluations have largely been triggered by a need among foreign donor agencies to prove their accountability vis-à-vis their governments and/or other money providers as well as the general public in the donor country.

For this reason, summative evaluations have tended to be undertaken by persons who are considered to be independent of the responsible programme or project organisations and the donor agencies.

As briefly mentioned above, evaluations may also be conducted halfway through programmes and projects (commonly called mid-term evaluations) or between phases of them. While the main purpose of evaluations thus timed is usually to provide information for any future adjustments of the same schemes, accountability considerations may be important here also.

Mid-term and formative evaluations are sometimes referred to as 'reviews'.

There are direct relations between the purpose (or combination of purposes) of evaluations and the way they may be conducted. We shall explore aspects of evaluation methodology in Part Three.

## EMPOWERMENT EVALUATION

As we have already alluded to, evaluations can be empowering processes for those who undertake or participate in them. This idea has got expression through the term 'empowerment evaluation' (Fetterman et al., 1996).

Empowerment evaluations may mainly be done in the context of capacity building programmes and other programmes that emphasise augmentation of abilities of intended beneficiaries. They may also be done more generally of the performance of organisations, emphasising learning by members or employees. Commonly, in such evaluations, assessment of organisational and programme performance will be closely intertwined.

The evaluators may assess activities that are at least largely planned and implemented by themselves, through their own organisations. We may then refer to the assessments as *internal* evaluations. In such contexts, the feedback that the involved people get by assessing the performance and impact of what they have done or are doing may substantially enhance their understanding and capability in respective fields.

Evaluations with an empowerment agenda may also be done as *collaborative* exercises between programme- or organisation-internal persons and external persons or institutions, in which the involvement and views of the former are prominent in the analysis and conclusions. Even basically internal evaluations may often be fruitfully facilitated

by an outsider. Such external facilitation may have a dual purpose: it may assist the participants in conceptualising and reflecting more on perspectives and ideas than they may do solely from their own experience, and it may help structure the process of evaluation itself.

Sometimes, intended beneficiaries may be empowered also by evaluating development work that is mainly or entirely done by some outside organisation or organisations—also schemes other than typical capacity building programmes. That may be the case if they, through their involvement (by some collaborative arrangement), come to influence the programme or project to their own benefit, or if they learn things that augment their ability to perform better in some other context. Of course, the degree and kind of empowerment may also be influenced by many external factors over which the evaluators may not have any or much control.

Most genuine empowerment evaluations are *formative*, aiming at improving the future performance of the evaluated programme or organisation, through the evaluators' efforts and to the evaluators' benefit. Sometimes, participatory *summative* evaluations may also have an empowerment effect, to the extent they help increase the participants' ability to obtain benefits beyond the evaluated programme, as mentioned above.

Fetterman et al. (1996) emphasise the internal and formative nature of most empowerment evaluations. Besides, according to them, such evaluations are normally facilitated. In their own words,

The assessment of a program's value and worth is not the end point of the evaluation—as it often is in traditional evaluation—but part of an ongoing process of program improvement. This new context acknowledges a simple but often overlooked truth: that merit and worth are not static values.... By internalizing and institutionalizing self-evaluation processes and practices, a dynamic and responsive approach to evaluation can be developed to accommodate these shifts [of merit and worth]. Both value assessments and corresponding plans for program improvement—developed by the group with the assistance of a trained evaluator—are subject to a cyclical process of reflection and self-evaluation. Program participants learn to continually assess their progress toward self-determined goals and to reshape their plans...according to this assessment. In the process, self-determination is fostered, illumination generated, and liberation actualized (ibid.: 5–6).

Empowerment, as perceived above, transcends relatively narrow 'technical' perceptions of capacity building, commonly held by development workers and organisations. It incorporates the augmentation of disadvantaged people's self-confidence and influence over factors that

shape their lives, often also involving building of organisations and wider institutional qualities and abilities.<sup>4</sup>

In collaborative evaluations (referred to above), Steven E. Mayer (1996), suggests three mechanisms for allying evaluation of community development work with empowerment of local communities:

- help create a constructive environment of participation in the evaluation, by
  - viewing outside experts and local people as ‘co-discoverers’;
  - viewing negative findings of evaluations primarily as inducements for improvement rather than causes for punishment; promoting partnerships of various stakeholders;
- directly include the voices of the intended beneficiaries, by
  - incorporating their views of the purpose of the evaluation;
  - incorporating their experience, wisdom and standards of good performance (connecting directly to the earlier discussed notion of lifeworld rationality);
  - including the most marginalised people in the group of evaluators;
- help communities use evaluation findings to strengthen their responses, by
  - using various media to spread information and the lessons learnt;
  - creating links between people who may use the information;
  - helping community organisations to build on the experiences that they have gained.

Empowerment evaluations of organised development work will have to be conducted through collective or participatory methods of analysis, to be addressed in Part Three.

## LINKING TO MODES OF PLANNING: PROCESS VERSUS BLUEPRINT

The above presented notion of formative versus summative evaluation connects directly to modes of planning of the respective programmes and projects. One planning dimension is of particular relevance here, namely, that of process versus blueprint planning (Faludi, 1973; 1984; Korten, 1980; 1984; Dale, 2004).

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<sup>4</sup> For definition and further discussion of ‘capacity –’, organisation –’ and ‘institution-building’, see Chapter 8 and Dale, 2000; 2004.



*Process planning* basically means that plans are not fully finalised or specified prior to the start-up of implementation; that is, greater or lesser amounts of planning are done in the course of the implementation period of the development scheme, interactively with implementation and monitoring.

*Blueprint planning*, in its extreme or 'pure' form, means that one prepares detailed plans for all that one intends to do before implementing any of that work. Thereby, the implementers will know exactly what they are to do, in which sequence and at what cost, until the scheme is completed.

Implicit in the above is that planning may be more or less process or more or less blueprint; that is, actual planning events will be located somewhere along a continuum between extreme process and extreme blueprint.

Uncertainty and uncertainty management are central notions in process planning. This planning mode is particularly appropriate in complex environments, where no firm images may be created, or when the planners' control over external factors is restricted for other reasons. Korten (1980: 498–99) also refers to process planning as a 'learning process approach', and he thinks that 'planning with people' needs to be done in this mode.

With blueprint planning, all possible efforts must be made during a single planning effort to remove uncertainties regarding implementation and benefits to be generated. Ideally, then, blueprint planning is 'an approach whereby a planning agency operates a programme thought to attain its objectives with certainty' (Faludi, 1973: 131). To that end, the planner must be able to manipulate relevant aspects of the programme environment, leaving 'no room for the environment or parts of it to act in other ways than those set by the planning agency' (ibid.: 140).

We see that Faludi uses the term 'programme' for the set of activities that are planned and implemented. Korten (1980: 496), however, stresses that, in blueprint planning, it is 'the *project* [my emphasis]—its identification, formulation, design, appraisal, selection, organization, implementation, supervision, termination, and evaluation—[that] is treated as the basic unit of development action'.<sup>5</sup>

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<sup>5</sup> As will be clarified below, this complies with my perception of 'programme' and 'project'.

The attentive reader may already have grasped that formative evaluations may only be done of development schemes that are planned and implemented in a process mode. Indeed, the more process oriented the scheme is, the more meaningful and important may be formative evaluations. Commonly, that also means that they are done more frequently, or that it would be advantageous with relatively frequent assessments.

Box 2.1 presents a programme in which a flexible system of formative evaluations (here called reviews) was designed and implemented, in order to help develop and improve the programme over a number of years.

### **Box 2.1**

#### **MANAGING A PROGRAMME WITH PROCESS PLANNING**

The Hambantota District Integrated Rural Development Programme (HIRDEP) in Sri Lanka, implemented from 1978 to 2000, was an unusually dynamic and flexible development endeavour. During the 1980s, in particular, it was operated according to a well-elaborated model of process planning. A core aspect of this was annual programme documents with the following main components:

- review of the previous year's work and past experience;
- outline of a future general strategy;
- proposals for new programme components (projects) to be started the following year;
- a work programme for the following year, encompassing ongoing and new projects;
- indications of project priorities (beyond already planned projects) over the next three years.

Information for planning was generated from various sources, largely depending on the nature of the respective projects. For instance, much information for the planning of infrastructure projects tended to be available with the respective sector agencies, and might be supplemented with additional information acquired by responsible officers at the field level. Community-based schemes, on the other hand (some of which are most appropriately referred to as flexible sub-programmes), required a more participatory, step-wise and cumulative approach to generating information.

The most innovative part of the system of information-generation was a provision for flexible evaluations—termed reviews—instituted

(Box 2.1 contd.)



(Box 2.1 contd.)

as a direct supplement to current monitoring. The reviews were important tools for feeding back information from ongoing and completed work into further planning. Salient features of this system were:

- the focus and comprehensiveness of the reviews were situation-determined and varied greatly;
- reviews could be proposed by any involved body (in practice, mainly the overall planning and co-ordinating body, sector departments, and the donor agency) at any time;
- the planning of reviews was integrated into the above stated planning process, resulting in annual programmes of reviews;
- the review teams varied with the purpose, consisting of one or more insiders, outsiders, or a combination of the two;
- a system of follow-up of the reviews was instituted, with written comments from involved agencies; a common meeting; decisions on follow-up action; and reporting on that action, mainly in the next annual programme document.

This system became increasingly effective over a period of a few years. It then largely disintegrated along with other innovative management practices. This was mainly due to changes of programme personnel, strains imposed on the programme by political turmoil during a couple of years, and a change of policy and new bureaucratic imperatives on the part of the donor.

Source: Dale, 2000

In programmes and projects that are planned and implemented in an outright blueprint mode, evaluations may be only of a summative nature. In phased programmes or projects, with predominantly blueprint planning of each phase, evaluations between the phases may be both summative (relating to the finalised phase) and formative (relating to any next phase).

## LINKING TO THE CONCEPTS OF 'PROGRAMME' AND 'PROJECT'

In previous pages, I have already used the words 'programme' and 'project' several times. That is because they tend to be the most frequently utilised terms for denoting planned and organised work for societal development. In order to facilitate a focused and constructive

discourse on aspects of development work—including evaluation—we should have their meanings better clarified.

A programme is not easily defined. It is normally regarded as a less specified and/or less clearly bounded entity than a project, in terms of its focus, scope of activities, time horizon, etc. Many development programmes also tend to be relatively broad-focusing and long-lasting.

In terms of frequently used concepts of planning, a programme may be formulated through strategic (overall, framework) planning only or through both strategic and operational (detailed) planning.<sup>6</sup> For instance, in a development programme, strategic aspects may be formulated in a separate document, which will usually be called the programme document. Parts of the development thrust may then be further specified in one or more additional plan documents, which are more appropriately referred to as project documents. Alternatively, strategic and operational planning may be undertaken as parts of one comprehensive exercise and formulated in the same document. In some instances, little or no operational planning may be undertaken by the planning agency, but is done informally by the users of allocated resources. In such cases, we have unquestionably a programme, under which the mentioned users undertake their own, normally very small, schemes (which may be referred to as programme components or projects).

We may distinguish between two main types of development programmes by their scope: one-sector programmes and multi-sector programmes. ‘Sector’ is normally defined by the general type of activity performed or the service rendered. A few examples may be education, primary health care, fisheries, irrigation, financial services, and social mobilisation. To the extent these activities are also concerns of governments, the mentioned categories normally coincide with public administrative responsibility as well.

Both one-sector programmes and multi-sector programmes may be more or less flexible or rigid. That is, they may be planned in more or less of a process or a blueprint mode. Most development programmes do require a substantial amount of process planning. In particular, this applies for relatively diversified programmes, programmes with broad stakeholder participation, and programmes that aim at capacity building.

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<sup>6</sup> See Chapter 4 for a further, brief clarification of these terms. For a more comprehensive analysis, see Dale, 2004.

Multi-sector programmes, in particular, may also be more or less integrated or disjointed; that is, they may consist of components that are functionally more or less connected or unrelated.

There may be hierarchies of programmes as well. For instance, a development programme covering one district may contain several divisional programmes, each of which may contain local community programmes. Within this hierarchy, projects may be planned and implemented at any level.

Note that the word 'programme' is also used with a different meaning in the phrase 'work programme'. A work programme spells out the implementation details of a project or parts of it. Linked to this is 'programming', meaning detailed sequencing of activities.

Definitions of the word project abound in business management literature and in literature on public planning and management. When signifying a formally organised endeavour, a project is normally stated to be a clearly delimited and relatively highly specified undertaking. A synthesis of typical definitions that have been presented may be something like 'a planned intervention for achieving one or more objectives, encompassing a set of interrelated activities that are undertaken during a delimited period of time, using specified human, financial and physical resources'.

The idea is that projects, like other endeavours that use resources that must be accounted for, should be well specified before one may start implementation, leaving as little uncertainty as possible about the quantity and quality of the outputs and their costs.

The logical implication of such a conception is that a development intervention, to be termed a project, should be formulated in blueprint mode and specified through operational planning.

In reality in the development sphere, the word 'project' tends to be used in a broader sense than this, encompassing endeavours that ought to be called programmes, according to most formal definitions of 'project' and the argument above. In my view, a more restricted and stringent usage of 'project' than has been common (and a corresponding more frequent use of 'programme') would be advantageous. This would help unify perceptions about characteristics of various kinds of development thrusts and, therewith, facilitate communication about approaches in development work.

Continuing from earlier statements, the intention of a project in the development sphere (i.e., a development project) should be to generate specified benefits for people, and it should be substantiated

to do so. Usually, benefit-generation is explicitly addressed in the project plan itself. In some cases, however, links to people's well-being may be less explicitly formulated or even just assumed, normally with reference to a wider context (for instance, a programme of which the project may be a limited part). This matter is further explored in Chapter 4.

As will be clarified later, the purpose, focus and mode of evaluation may, to different degrees, depend on whether one evaluates a programme or a project.



## Chapter 3

# EVALUATION VERSUS APPRAISAL AND MONITORING

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### APPRAISAL AND EVALUATION

Three common words of the development vocabulary are partly related. They are 'appraisal', 'monitoring' and 'evaluation'.

In the context of development work, *appraisal* is usually taken to mean a critical examination of a proposal of a programme or project, normally before the latter is approved for funding and implementation. From what we have already said about evaluation, the reader should then immediately see that there is only a limited sphere of overlap between appraisal and evaluation.

The relationship may be further clarified with reference to the definition by Rossi and Freeman (1993) of what they call 'evaluation research', namely, 'the systematic application of social research procedures for assessing the conceptualization, design, implementation and utility of social intervention programs' (ibid.: 5).

The point of attention in the present context is assessment of conceptualisation and design. We have clarified that evaluation of development work should emphasise benefits for people and related aspects. Simultaneously, benefits need to be substantiated and explained, and conceptualisation and design may certainly be factors of substantiation and explanation. The point is that, for an exercise to be called an evaluation, conceptualisation and design must be viewed in this wider context of achievements. An examination of these features alone would be better referred to as 'appraisal', which may be needed before any substantial development work is initiated.

Additionally, evaluations of development work may address aspects of efficiency, occasionally even in their own right (see Part Two). In

such cases, conceptualisation and design would be related to the immediate outputs and the processes that generate these outputs. Thus, even in this narrower context, conceptualisation and design would be assessed in relation to programme or project outcome.

## MONITORING AND EVALUATION

In the development sphere, *monitoring* may be done for three main purposes: assessing the performance of a programme or project; analysing organisational performance; and examining features and processes in the environment of an organisation or scheme. The three purposes may be more or less related. In all instances, for the assessment to be referred to as monitoring, it should be of relatively current or frequent nature.

Monitoring of *programmes and projects* is usually taken to mean relatively current or frequent assessment of planned work and the results of that work. More precisely, we can define it as frequent and largely routine generation of and reporting on information about the performance of a programme or project, comparison of this with the programme or project plans and, commonly, suggesting corrective measures, if any.

Thus, monitoring aims at meeting the information needs of current programme and project management. This presupposes a clarified purpose of, and a reasonably systematic approach to, information collection and use.

Usually, monitoring of development work mainly covers aspects of finance, the quantity and quality of inputs and outputs, as well as actors and time use in implementation. It may also (and commonly should) encompass some regular assessment of relatively direct changes that are brought about by the scheme, and may even address other matters—which may possibly be analysed more thoroughly in some additional evaluation.

This kind of monitoring is usually done, entirely or primarily, by the organisation or organisations that are responsible for the programme or project. There may be several persons involved, often at different levels in the organisation. In some instances, these persons may also be the intended beneficiaries of the work that is done. In other cases, intended beneficiaries may be involved in monitoring even if they do not have any formal implementation role. In yet other

cases, some outside body may be engaged to play a supporting role—in designing a monitoring system or even in implementing it.

Most organisations, also in the development sphere, will in addition have their internal systems for assessment of *organisational performance* more generally, i.e., not directly or primarily relating to specific programmes and projects that the organisations undertake.<sup>1</sup> Occasionally, such general monitoring of the performance of one or more organisations may be done by other organisations. Examples may be supervision of local government bodies by some central government department (which may be more or less direct and comprehensive), and continued gathering of information about the work of built organisations by the organisation-building body.

In addition, we may refer to a third, rather different, activity as ‘monitoring’. This is relatively *current assessment of external (environmental) factors* relating to and influencing the performance of a programme or project or an organisation, coupled with consideration of responses to any changes in relevant parts of the environment.

This is well recognised as a crucial activity for success in the business world. It may be equally important in the development sphere, particularly in long-term programmes that are planned in the process mode, the more so the more open and complex they are. A couple of suitable terms for this activity are ‘strategic monitoring’ and ‘environmental scanning’.<sup>2</sup>

We have already clarified that we consider *evaluation* to be a more specific and time-bound kind of activity than those presented above, and that it tends to focus more on changes relating to intended beneficiaries (and sometimes other people). We have also stated that there may be grey zones between what is unquestionably monitoring and evaluation respectively. For instance, this may often be the case in programmes where the assessment is undertaken by the intended beneficiaries themselves, partly or in full. These may be programmes that are also planned and implemented by people’s own organisations, or they may be programmes or projects that are supported or undertaken by others.

We shall illustrate this issue through two cases of relatively continuous or frequent participatory assessment. Such assessments have been

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<sup>1</sup> Love (1991) addresses such assessments comprehensively, under the heading of ‘internal evaluation’. Dale (2000) presents and discusses dimensions of organisation that may need to be subjected to more or less frequent assessment.

<sup>2</sup> See Dale, 2000 for further elaboration and discussion.



referred to as 'participatory monitoring' (for instance, Germann et al., 1996) or 'process evaluation' (for instance, Dehar et al., 1993)—although the latter may not always involve broad participation.

The two cases are presented in Box 3.1. The first is an example from my own experience. The second builds on a case presented by Germann et al. (1996).

### **Box 3.1**

#### **TWO CASES OF PARTICIPATORY ASSESSMENT**

##### **Monitoring of Infrastructure Projects**

The Kotaweheramankada—Hambegamuwa Area Development Programme (KOHAP) was a sub-programme within the Moneragala District Integrated Rural Development Programme (MONDEP), Sri Lanka. KOHAP addressed a wide range of development issues, including construction of numerous infrastructure facilities in one of the most infrastructure deficient areas of the country. The main components were a main road through the area, several feeder roads, irrigation facilities, school buildings, health centre buildings, and offices of local administrative staff. There was substantial participation by local inhabitants in planning, and some of the infrastructure was built by local organisations (village societies) or with labour contributions by people through such organisations.

Additionally, the inhabitants had been requested to organise themselves for monitoring infrastructure works by government agencies and contractors. Local organisations grasped the idea with enthusiasm, and some even established special committees to undertake this task. The main mechanisms of monitoring by them were: familiarisation and checks through frequent visits to the construction sites; communication with the implementing bodies in the field about any matter that warranted attention; reporting to the MONDEP leadership of any perceived problems that could not be settled through such direct communication; and further examination of such matters by MONDEP with the respective involved bodies.

This was an unconventional and bold venture by MONDEP, with the related aims of (a) empowering local people through their organisations, and (b) promoting higher quality of work.

The intentions with this effort were partly fulfilled. People were convinced that they had helped ensure higher quality of most infrastructure facilities. Difficulties had also been experienced. There

(Box 3.1 contd.)



(Box 3.1 contd.)

had been many instances of disagreement, particularly over irrigation works, and quite a few cases of alleged malpractice had been reported to MONDEP. Most of these had been followed up, with various degrees of success. It is beyond our scope here to analyse issues of performance. Generally, the effort helped clarify possibilities and constraints in participatory monitoring of this kind and conditions under which it may be effective.

### **Self-Assessment of Women's Cooperatives**

A non-governmental development organisation (NGDO) had helped women in a remote and poverty-stricken area in Bolivia to form their own consumer cooperatives (shop management societies), and had given them some initial training in running the shops that they established.

This initiative had been taken because of a long distance between the area and the nearest centre with shops and a marketplace. A couple of traders used to come to the area once in a while to sell consumer items, but the goods were few and expensive.

In spite of the initial assistance by the NGDO, there were problems in the operation of the shops. The members of the cooperatives, facilitated and supported by the NGDO, then decided to establish a system of regular assessments of performance, to enable the members to keep track of all operations and provide inputs for improvements. To this end, a fairly detailed but simple system of monitoring was established, centred on the following core questions:

- what is to be watched?
- how is performance to be watched?
- who should watch?
- how should the generated information be documented?
- how should the information be shared and acted on?

The first of these questions was addressed by specifying expectations that the members had as well as constraints and uncertainties (fears or doubts) regarding fulfilment of the expectations. A couple of examples of stated expectations were:

- the nutrition of the members' families will be improved
- the prices of the goods in the shops will be fair
- all the members will participate in shop operations, on a rotating basis.

Performance was then to be assessed through a set of simple mostly quantitative indicators, relating to stated intentions (basically

(Box 3.1 contd.)

(Box 3.1 contd.)

corresponding to the expectations), and the means of generating information were specified. For example, no items should cost more than 5% more than in the nearest centre (intention), and this should be checked by recording the prices of randomly selected items in randomly selected shops (indicator and means of verification). The assessment was to be made by selected persons, and findings were to be discussed and any action decided on at member meetings.

The first case—involvement by intended beneficiaries in the follow-up of infrastructure building by outside professional bodies (government departments and contractors engaged by them)—is clearly an example of monitoring, by our definition of this term. The follow-up is done fairly continuously, and the focus is on aspects of implementation.

The specified activities of the second case, as well, may be referred to as monitoring. However, one may also refer to them as evaluation. First, they are done at pre-specified points in time and less frequently than monitoring would normally be done. Second, in any round of study, the examination is done of systematically sampled units (goods and shops) only, being a typical feature of most evaluations. Third, the assessment is also intended to address benefits for people, in terms of changes in their nutrition status (although the people themselves may be able to indicate such changes only very indirectly).

In the second case, the activities that are analysed are those of one's own organisation. One may then refer to them as 'self-assessment', 'internal monitoring' or 'internal evaluation' (Love, 1991). If one prefers to use the term 'evaluation' (rather than 'monitoring'), one could add 'process', mentioned above, making this kind of assessment read 'internal process evaluation'.

## A MORE PRECISE DEFINITION OF 'EVALUATION'

We shall round off this chapter by going a step further in defining 'evaluation', bridging the previous overview with the more detailed examination of aspects of evaluation that will be addressed in Parts Two and Three of the book.

The contact sphere between appraisal and evaluation is, we have stated, very limited, and the relation between these two concepts should have been well clarified.

Monitoring and evaluation are much more broadly and closely related. They are both undertaken to find out how a programme or project performs or has performed, including reasons for aspects of performance, whether positive or negative. Thus, a more specific definition of evaluation will primarily need to clarify this concept in relation to monitoring, in situations where this is clearly warranted.

Based on the above, we shall define 'evaluation', in the context of development work, as *mostly a more thorough examination than monitoring, at specified points in time, of programmes, projects or organisational performance, usually with emphasis on impact for people and commonly also relevance, effectiveness, efficiency, sustainability and replicability.*

The last-mentioned terms will be defined in Part Two, as part of an examination of the focus and scope of various kinds of evaluations.

Evaluators may draw on information that has been provided through monitoring as well as additional information that they generate directly, from primary sources, or indirectly, from other secondary sources. Information may be gathered through a range of methods, depending on the evaluation's purpose and context. Aspects of methodology will be examined in Part Three.

Evaluations may be done by programme or project responsible personnel, independent persons, beneficiaries, or any combination of such people. This matter and additional aspects of management will be addressed in Part Three as well.

## Chapter 4

# LINKING TO PLANNING: MEANS-ENDS ANALYSIS

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### CONNECTING DESIGN VARIABLES, WORK CATEGORIES AND INTENDED ACHIEVEMENTS

In the preceding chapters, we have discussed development work, and evaluation in the context of such work, in quite general terms. We shall now connect design features, work tasks and activities of programmes and projects in a more systematic manner, focusing on the essential thrust of exploring and substantiating means-ends relations. Most basically, in development work, resources are allocated for undertaking pieces of work that are intended to generate certain benefits for certain people. Clarifying relations between resource use, work efforts and benefits may be readily proclaimed as a core task and the main challenge in development programmes and projects. To that end one needs, in planning, to conceptualise and specify mechanisms and steps by which resources and pieces of work are intended to be converted into benefits. In evaluation, one will then explore and seek to document whether or to what extent intended relations have materialised or are materialising. In both planning and evaluation, this will invariably also involve analysis of contextual factors (to be specifically addressed in the next chapter).

All organised development work needs to be planned, in some basic sense. At the very least, this will involve some substantiated idea about relations between the above-mentioned categories. Sometimes, the conceptions may be very loose, and may even exist only in the minds of people. More commonly, however, planning is a more comprehensive and substantial thrust, and what is planned may have to be specified in writing. The basic points are (a) that no organisation involved in development work (which may be anything from a small local group to a government department or an international agency)

would use resources for something about the outcome of which it has no idea, and (b) that the amount and type of planning that may be needed to clarify and induce the above-mentioned relations will vary vastly between kinds of development schemes and their context.

We have already made brief mention of the concepts of strategic and operational planning. *Strategic planning* is the most fundamental exercise in development work, on which any other activity and feature builds and to which they relate. It seeks to clarify and fit together the main concerns and components of a development thrust (programme or project). This involves identifying relevant problems for people, making choices about the problem or problems to be addressed, clarifying the availability of resources, and deciding on objectives and general courses of action—considering opportunities and constraints in the environment of the involved organisation or organisations and abilities of various kinds. *Operational planning* means further specification of components and processes that one has decided on during preceding strategic planning. A good operational plan should be a firm, detailed and clear guide for implementation. A planning thrust (strategic and/or operational) may encompass anything from blueprint planning of an entire big project to the planning of a small component of a process-based programme sometime in the course of programme implementation.<sup>1</sup>

What is planned is, of course, supposed to be implemented. In other words, *implementation* is intended to be done in accordance with planned work tasks—which I shall refer to as *implementation tasks*—and planned resource allocation for these tasks—which I shall refer to as *inputs*. Beyond this, relations between planning and implementation depend much on whether one applies a process or a blueprint approach (see Chapter 2).

The direct (or relatively direct) outcome of the work that is done is normally referred to as *outputs*. For certain kinds of schemes, the project managers should be able to guarantee the outputs, since they ought to be in good control of the resource inputs and the work that directly produces them. However, for most kinds of development work, the matter is usually not so straightforward (see also Chapter 5).

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<sup>1</sup> See Dale, 2004 for a comprehensive analysis of strategic development planning and relations between strategic and operational planning.

During implementation, one will *monitor* the resource use, work processes, outputs and, possibly, fairly direct changes caused by the outputs. As clarified earlier, the purpose of monitoring is to know whether or to what extent the programme or project proceeds according to the plans and creates what it is intended to create, and to provide information that may be needed for any changes—regarding plans, mode of implementation or outputs. The role of monitoring may vary substantially between types of programmes and projects. This function, as well, tends to be particularly much related to the planning dimension of process–blueprint.

The outputs are produced in order to create intended *benefits* for people. A major challenge for development planners is to analyse and formulate means–ends relations towards goal–achievement, and an equally big challenge for evaluators is to explore and substantiate benefits and how they are being or have been generated. We shall therefore discuss such means–ends relations more specifically.

## LINKING PLANNED OUTPUTS TO INTENDED BENEFITS FOR PEOPLE

As repeatedly stated, the very purpose of development work is to enhance the quality of life of one or more groups of people. The overall intended improvement in people's life quality (the intended ultimate benefit) is normally referred to as the *development objective* (a term which we will be using) or *goal*.

A major challenge in development planning is, then, to analyse means–ends relations converging on the development objective and to then formulate a logical and well substantiated structure of linked variables, particularly from the level of outputs to this overall objective.

However, some planning does not incorporate any explicit analysis of consequences of what is planned for people's quality of life. Faludi (1973; 1984) and others call this 'functional' planning (as opposed to 'normative' planning). For instance, a part of a project for enhancing the income for farmers under an irrigation system may be to replant the water inflow area (the watershed) of that system, in order to reduce soil erosion, negatively affecting irrigation and therewith cultivation and income. We may well imagine a scenario in which a body other than the overall planning agency is made to be in charge of planning (and normally also implementing) what is to be done to



have the area planted. That body will then consider any benefits for people of these activities to be outside its field of concern. That would be a clearly functional planning thrust. I have in other contexts (particularly, Dale, 2004) argued that such planning in itself should not be referred to as development planning. It should be seen as a delimited part of the latter.

Simultaneously, there are some kinds of programmes with highly indirect relations between outputs and benefits for people that must be considered as development schemes. In particular, some institution building programmes fall into this category. In these, the links from augmented institutional abilities to improved quality of life may be cloudy and hard to ascertain. Let us illustrate this with an example:

A government intends to augment the competence and capacity for managing public development work, by establishing a national Institute of Development Management—for which it may also seek donor funding. The overall objective of the institute may be formulated as ‘promoting economic and social development’ in the country. However, for both the government and for any donor agencies that may support the enterprise, this objective will, for all intents and purposes, remain an assumption, rather than an intended achievement against which any investment may be explicitly analysed. In other words, the operational planning of the institute and any subsequent investment in it will have to be based on relatively general and indicative judgement of the institute’s relevance and significance for development, rather than any rigorous means–ends analysis up to the level of the mentioned development objective. Still, I would think that few people, if anybody, would hesitate to refer to such an institution building thrust as development work. The institution is established with the ultimate aim of benefiting inhabitants of the country in which it is established.

The mentioned gap to benefits notwithstanding, any body that may be willing to invest in such a project should do its utmost to substantiate that conditions for goal-attainment are conducive, before committing resources. In this case, various aspects of governance in the concerned country may constitute particularly important conditions.

A linked question is how directly objectives should express benefits for people, that is, who are to benefit and how. In many development plan documents, even the top-level objective (by whatever name it goes) does not express intended improvements in people’s quality of life, or does not do so in clear or unambiguous terms. We shall



reiterate, once more, that a clear focus on quality of life should be a requirement of any programme or project that purports to be a development endeavour. Moreover, this focus needs to be directly expressed by the top-level objective of that thrust. If we compromise on that, we cloud the very idea of development work. We can then readily agree with Eggers (2000a; 2000b), when he refers to this quality-of-life focus as the ‘master principle’ of such work. While, as mentioned, benefits for people may in some programmes largely remain assumptions, one should not just replace statements of benefit (however much they may be assumptions) with statements that are, in a means–ends perspective, of a lower order.

The next question we need to address is how many levels we should specify between the outputs and the development objective. In most so-called logical framework analysis, which has been and continue to be the main tool for formulating means–ends relations, and then for evaluating them, one works with two levels of objectives. That is, one formulates one category between the ‘outputs’ and the ‘development objective’. However, in certain versions of the framework, a third level of objectives has been incorporated.<sup>2</sup> In practice, we may often construct means–ends chains above the outputs at more than three levels.

Generally, in development planning, it is useful to clarify all important links between the ultimate intended benefit for people and more specific and immediate intended benefits. The former will invariably be generated through the latter. By direct implication, substantiating such connections is also important in monitoring and evaluation. Moreover, benefits of a more specific nature are normally easier to ascertain than is the general benefit expressed by the development objective.

Here, however, we are into the most difficult part of the means–ends analysis of most development schemes. As mentioned, we may normally, through careful analysis, identify several levels between a set of outputs and the development objective.

At the level right below the development objective, one may virtually always identify and formulate directly people-focused objectives, that is, intended benefits for intended beneficiaries. For

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<sup>2</sup> For a comprehensive analysis of the logical framework in development planning and suggestions for improvements of conventional forms of the framework, see Dale, 2004. For a briefer discussion, see Dale, 2003.

example, ‘the people drink clean water’ may be a statement of benefit at that level, in a water supply scheme for a specified population group. Assuming that drinking of unclean water has been a main cause of poor health, the new practice should lead to improved health of the target population. The latter may then be viewed as the project’s development objective.

If we limit ourselves to only two levels of objectives (as conventionally done in the logical framework), we are commonly left with a problem of a fragmented means–ends structure. In such cases, the gap between the outputs (signifying the direct or relatively direct outcome of implementation) and the stated objectives tends to become so big that the causal links between them may get blurred. Consequently, I consider it useful to formalise at least a third level of objectives in most cases of development planning. At this level, we may be somewhat less strict regarding benefit formulation. However, to be at all referred to as objectives, even statements at this level need to express some link with people.

For common understanding and consistent communication, the levels also need to be named. The formulations will differ in the contexts of planning and evaluation respectively: in the former, they will signify an intention; in the latter, they will express achievements that are to be documented and explained. I will suggest the following set of terms in the two mentioned contexts:

| IN PLANNING           |    | IN EVALUATION |
|-----------------------|----|---------------|
| Development objective | —— | Impact        |
| Effect objectives     | —— | Effects       |
| Immediate objectives  | —— | Direct change |
| Intended outputs      | —— | Outputs       |

The terms ‘development objective’ and ‘output’ have already been used above. ‘Effect objectives’ stand for more specific benefits that are planned for, and are intended to contribute to attainment of the development objective. ‘Effects’ are the corresponding term for materialised benefits. ‘Impact’ corresponds to ‘development objective’ in the same way. The two terms—effects and impact—are fairly conventional terms of the development vocabulary, normally used with at least approximately the meanings that we have given them. ‘Immediate objectives’ are intended achievements of more direct kind, through which outputs are intended to be converted into effects.

As mentioned shortly above, they may be less direct expressions of quality of life. The immediate objectives correspond to ‘direct change’. The words ‘immediate’ and ‘direct’ should not be understood quite literally: even these changes may take time to materialise, and they may also be influenced by external factors (see the next chapter).

One thing we must keep in mind is that changes that are induced by a development programme or project may not only be positive. There may be negative changes also. Normally, they should also be examined in evaluations.

The above argument may have sounded rather abstract to some readers. The matter should be better clarified and ought to be better understood through the two examples that will now follow.

## TWO EXAMPLES

Figures 4.1 and 4.2 show the intended means–ends structures of two imagined development schemes. The first of these is most appropriately referred to as a project, the second as a programme.

There are some aspects of the means–ends structures that are presented in these figures that could have been further elaborated and discussed. However, since this is not a book on planning, we shall leave the matter here.<sup>3</sup>

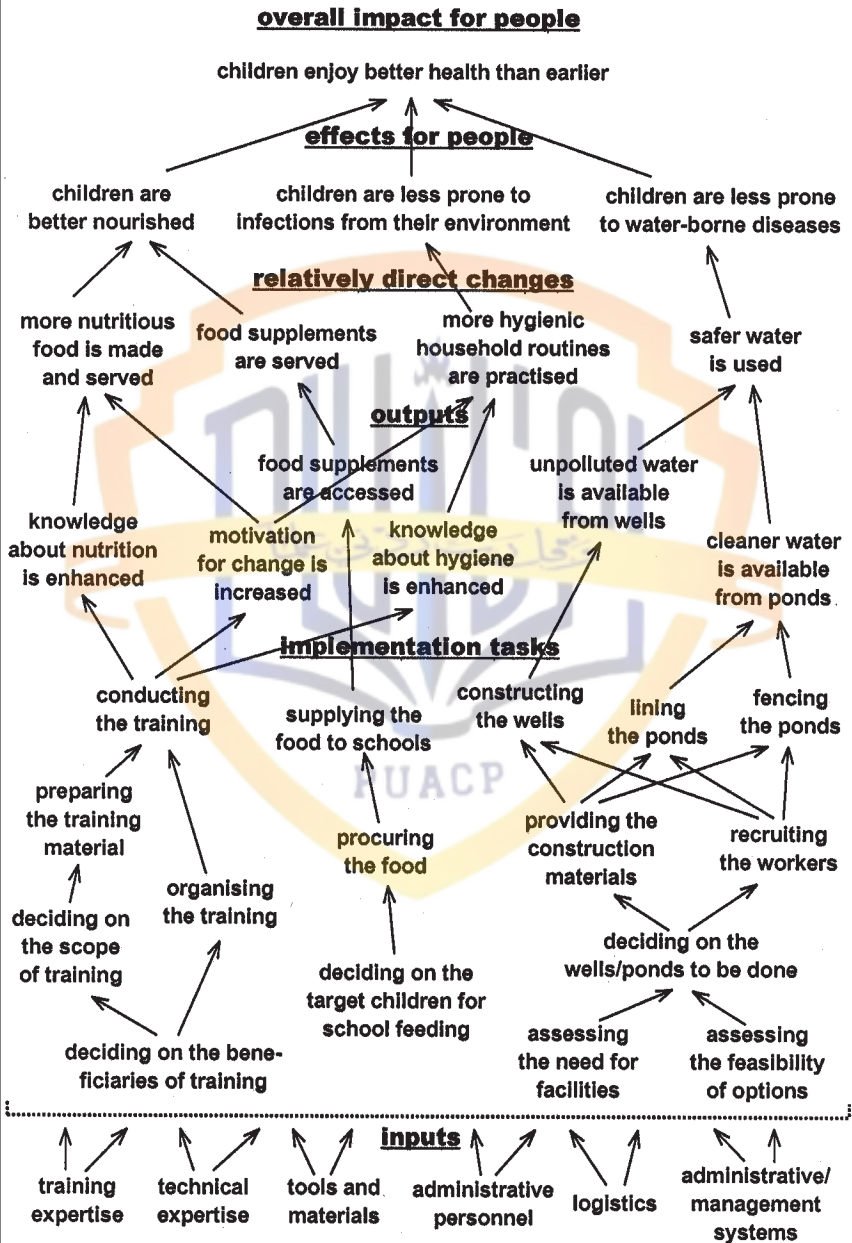
The exception is that we need to clarify differences in the bottom part of the two structures. These differences relate directly to the earlier clarified distinction between blueprint and process planning. The health promotion project is envisaged to have been designed through predominantly blueprint planning; that is, the inputs and implementation tasks are considered to have been specified in sufficient detail, at an acceptable level of certainty, for the whole project period. Of course, we assume here that the formulations in the present schema are generalised statements from more detailed operational plans. The empowerment programme, on the other hand, is envisaged to be an undertaking in a highly process mode. That is, the programme is developed gradually, through continuous or frequent feedback from what has been or is being done, in interplay with inputs and efforts of other kinds during the programme period. The feedback is, of course, provided through monitoring and any formative

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<sup>3</sup> For more comprehensive analysis and discussion, see Dale, 2004.

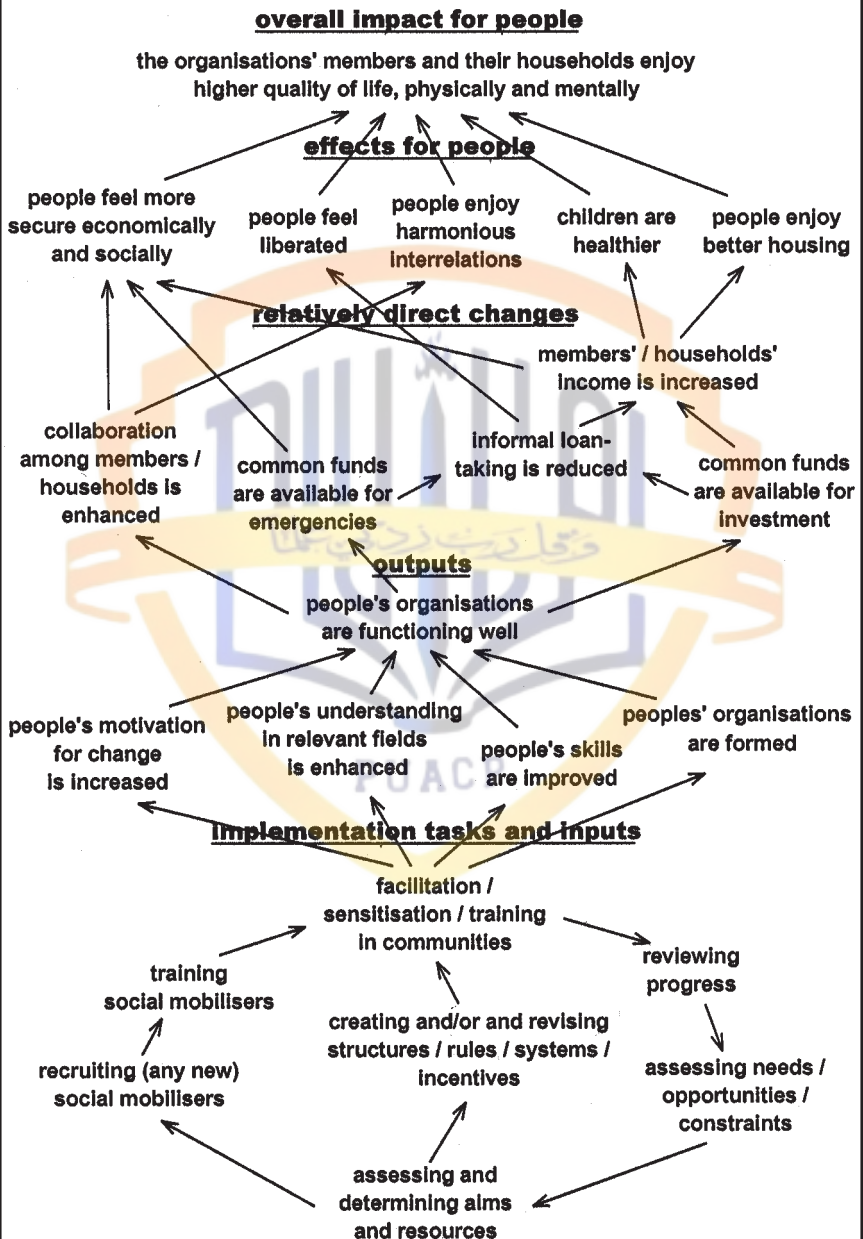
**Figure 4.1**

**MEANS - ENDS STRUCTURE OF HEALTH PROMOTION PROJECT**



**Figure 4.2**

**MEANS - ENDS STRUCTURE OF EMPOWERMENT PROGRAMME**



evaluations. This process approach is visualised in the figure by interrelated changes of various implementation tasks and inputs (in some sociological literature referred to as ‘circular cumulative causation’). These changes will, in turn, generate changed or additional outputs and achievements, hopefully signifying a gradually more important and effective programme.



## Chapter 5

# LINKING TO PLANNING: SOCIETAL CONTEXT ANALYSIS

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### THE BASIC ISSUE

We have emphasised that development work is a normative pursuit, explicitly aiming at improving aspects of the quality of life of people. Any meaningful analysis of people's quality of life and changes in it involves an assessment of people's living environment and the complex, changing and often little predictable interrelations between the people and a range of environmental factors. Such factors may be grouped under headings such as political, economic, social, cultural, organisational, built physical (infrastructural), natural environmental, etc. Many of these (political, administrative and other organisational, cultural and certain social factors) may be viewed as entities of a broader category of 'institutional'.

Moreover, development programmes and projects are, we have clarified, organised thrusts. From the point of view of a responsible organisation, development work is about creating benefits for people through interaction between the organisation and aspects in the organisation's environment. The intended beneficiaries may then belong to the organisation or they may be outsiders (in the organisation's environment), and they may often be involved in that interaction, to various extents and in various ways.

By implication, people-related changes that one intends to bring about by a development intervention must be analysed in the societal context of that intervention. This concern of planning is matched by a corresponding concern in evaluation. Virtually always, changes to be evaluated are being or have been generated through more or less complex interaction between factors internal to the assessed programme



or project and factors in its environment. The extent to which processes of change may reflect or be connected to what has been planned will vary, though. Normally, at least, such processes will be or will have been substantially influenced by planned actions (if planning has not been ineffective), but the evaluator may also trace numerous influencing factors and processes that one may have neither addressed or taken cognisance of nor even been conscious about during planning. In any case, the evaluator may have to pay major attention to the way in which planners have addressed the interface and the interaction between programme or project internal matters and contextual factors.

## OPPORTUNITIES, CONSTRAINTS AND THREATS

Common terms of contextual analysis are *opportunities* and *constraints*. There may be present and future opportunities and constraints. The future ones may be more or less uncertain. For that reason, one tends to refer to potential future negative influences as *threats* rather than ‘constraints’. In the same vein, relating to the future, one often ought to talk of *potential opportunities* rather than just ‘opportunities’.

In development work, one must clearly distinguish between two different *perspectives* on opportunities, constraints and threats.

1. They may be concerns of planning; that is, they are variables that planners may actively relate to in various ways—depending on the intended scope of the scheme, perspectives and competence of the planning agency, capabilities during implementation, and a range of contextual factors.
2. Following the stage or stages of planning, they are programme-external or project-external factors that may influence the implementation and achievements of the development scheme, in various ways and to various extents.

Thus, factors external to a programme or project, or any part of it, that has been planned (point 2), are actual or potential influencing forces that are outside the scope of action of the scheme. In other words, they are opportunities, constraints and/or threats over which the responsible organisation or set of organisations exerts no direct influence (or, at least, cannot be expected to exert influence), once the scheme, or the respective part of it, has been planned.

Of course, these concepts are relevant also for evaluation of development schemes, in ways that we have already indicated. Most obviously, when analysing societal changes, one needs to assess to what extent these changes are being or have been generated by the particular intervention, by other factors, or through the interaction between elements of the programme/project and other factors (linking to point 2 above). Additionally, when analysing programme or project performance, one must analyse the scope of the designed scheme (that is, what societal sphere it has been planned to influence) along with the way the planners have addressed related opportunities, constraints and threats (point 1 above). Commonly, the latter may connect to the earlier clarified planning dimension of process–blueprint as well as other dimensions of planning—an issue that we cannot pursue further here.<sup>1</sup>

There are some additional, more specific, features of and perspectives on opportunities, constraints and threats that one should be conscious about.

There may be *animate* and *inanimate* opportunities, constraints and threats. The first are external human beings (individuals or groups) or organisations that exert influence on the development programme or project or may do so, normally through purposive action. By a commonly used term, they are actual or potential outside stakeholders. In most sensible development work, one will interrelate with them rather than just influence or command them. Inanimate factors, on the other hand, may not respond (for instance, the hours of sunlight) or may do so only mechanistically (for instance, soil quality, in reaction to some treatment).

A crucial question in development work is, obviously, whether or to what extent opportunities, constraints and threats are *amenable to change*. That may decide whether, to what extent and how one may or should address them. For instance, in a watershed reforestation project, the amount of rainfall (on which survival and growth of the tree seedlings may depend) may not be influenced. On the other hand, it may be possible to address a problem of harmful activities of people in the watershed, such as cultivation (for instance, through resettlement of people who used to cultivate there).

Moreover, it may often be difficult to distinguish clearly between internal and external phenomena, that is, to establish a clear *boundary*

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<sup>1</sup> See Dale, 2000 (Chapter Three); Dale, 2002b; and Dale, 2004.

between them. Commonly related, there may be *different perceptions* of what is internal and what is external. Especially, this may be the case in programmes with broad participation of stakeholders and in programmes and projects that are collaborative efforts between two or more organisations. Of course, this may have direct bearings on perceptions about what may be done and how things may be done, i.e., ideas about and attitudes towards opportunities, constraints and threats.

For instance, in community development programmes, local people may be involved in numerous activities in various ways, ranging from well-formalised participation to involvement of an entirely informal nature. Thereby, the boundary between the programme and its environment becomes blurred, and different involved persons may view their own and other actors' roles, abilities and scope of action differently. This will influence views about what may be opportunities, constraints and threats and how these may be exploited, influenced or contained.

In cases of collaborating organisations, the matter of internal versus external—and therewith ways and means of exploiting, influencing or otherwise relating to opportunities, constraints and threats—may be particularly complex and sometimes also ambiguous. Let us illustrate this by a community-based pre-school programme, being a collaborative venture between a non-governmental organisation (NGO), a community-based organisation in each of the programme communities and a government department. The NGO provides most of the support from outside the local communities, including initial motivational work in these communities, training, provision of teaching materials, advice in various fields, and overall monitoring over a certain period. The exception is a modest salary to the pre-school teachers, which is to be paid by the government department. The community-based organisations are intended to do whatever they can with local resources and capabilities, such as recruiting local persons as teachers, erecting a simple building, and operating and maintaining the pre-school over the longer term.

In this case, we may distinguish between three main categories of variables on the internal–external dimension: variables internal to the organisations individually, other variables internal to the programme as a whole (whether considered as internal or external to the individual organisations), and variables external to the entire programme. Success of the programme will depend on the extent to which all the

collaborating partners agree on and understand their own and the other actors' roles and fulfil their obligations accordingly.

Simultaneously, each organisation will have different degrees of control of or influence on different activities. For example, although the NGO has an overall coordinating and monitoring role, it cannot ensure the quality of the other organisations' work in the same direct way as the quality of its own work. Thus, although it may provide comprehensive support to all the community organisations, some of the latter may perform poorly for reasons beyond its ability to influence. Likewise, the NGO may not be able to prevent any general policy-change by the government regarding payment of pre-school teachers. Such a policy-change may then be a threat to the programme, which only one of the partners may in reality be able to relate to.

## MOVING BOUNDARIES BETWEEN THE INTERNAL AND THE EXTERNAL

The interface and interrelations between internal and external variables of a development programme or project is a major strategic issue addressed in planning. We shall here reflect somewhat further on relations between this dimension of internal-external and other dimensions of planning and management. The connected aspects of design are crucial in relation to programme or project performance, and therefore need to be examined in evaluations as well.

For the sake of the clarity and consistency of the argument, our perspective will be *expansion of the scope* of a development scheme. We shall seek to clarify the main reasons for expanding the scope and major consequences for the programme or project of doing so.

There may be at least four main arguments for expanding the scope of a development thrust. For a particular scheme, one or more of them may apply.

One argument for expanded scope may be to *reach more people* or *address other needs* of people. For instance, a regional development programme may be expanded to encompass additional and more diverse projects for ameliorating the problems of people in the region who have hitherto been outside the operational sphere of the scheme.

A second, and sometimes related, argument for expanding a programme or project may be to make it *more normative*. This means, basically, to move the main focus higher up in a conceivable means—

ends structure. For instance, let us assume that the health improvement project that was presented in the previous chapter (Figure 4.1) has been expanded from an initial nutrition promotion project, whereby we have also added one higher-level aim (improved health more generally). Looking at the presented means–ends structure, we immediately see that we have therewith also substantially broadened this thrust.

A third argument for expanding the scope may be to make the scheme *more robust* against threats. For instance, we might increase the sustainability of an irrigation-based land settlement scheme by broadening it from mere construction of irrigation facilities and land allocation to also include promotion of community-based institutions of various kinds, development of other physical and social infrastructure, training in cultivation methods, etc.

The two last-mentioned justifications, in particular, may be closely related with a third argument, namely, *increased effectiveness* of the scheme. More direct concern with fundamental aspects of people's living situation may help augment the benefits of a development thrust, while greater robustness may also promote the sustainability of attained benefits.

Sometimes, just doing more of the same thing—that is, increasing the scale of a programme or project—may have the above-mentioned effects. For instance, producing more of a new product in an area may promote a more effective and sustainable marketing system for that product from that area, and training more people in a specific vocation may indirectly help promote an industry that needs persons with the particular skill.

Normally, however, we include more in the idea of expanded scope than an increase of scale. The scope may even be augmented without any change of scale or along with a reduced scale. What we primarily have in mind is greater diversity of components and activities.

The latter, in particular, may have substantial implications for planning and implementation, largely depending on the type of development work and the degree of expansion of the programme or project.

Greater diversity normally means that the work will be done by a larger number of organisations, organisational units, and/or individuals. Moreover, for the sake of efficiency and often also effectiveness, different components and activities commonly need to be inter-related, often both operationally and in terms of the complementarity of outputs and benefits.

All this creates additional challenges of management. By common terminology in management science, we may broadly summarise the most important ones as challenges of 'leadership' and 'co-ordination'.

*Leadership* is sometimes used with a relatively narrow meaning, encompassing motivation, inspiration and informal guidance. More frequently, it is used in a broader sense, by which it also becomes more significant in the present context. It may then also involve formal guidance in policy and strategy formulation, clarification of role structures, etc., and outward promotion of the organisation and its work.

*Co-ordination* may be an even more obviously important concept in relation to challenges from increased diversity. Unfortunately, in the development arena, the concept has tended to be used rather vaguely for a rather narrow set of collaborative arrangements in planning and, particularly, implementation. Drawing to some extent on Mintzberg (1983), I have elsewhere (Dale, 2000) formulated a typology of mechanisms of co-ordination in the development sphere, which planners and managers may apply in various combinations for effective and efficient management of complex programmes and projects.

In some instances, increasing the scope of a development thrust may involve a more substantial *change of approach*. This may include major aspects of organisation, composition of components, and mode of work.

A good example is programmes for making financial services available to poor people. Over decades, issuing credit in the form of standardised packages by state or state-controlled banks has been a main measure to promote production and alleviate poverty in developing countries—particularly among farmers, but also others. Over the years, it has become increasingly recognised that such schemes have been little effective, for a range of reasons that have gradually become better understood.<sup>2</sup>

These experiences have led to searches for alternative approaches to augment financial services for poor people.

A main lesson from conventional credit disbursement schemes has been that they have been too narrow and rigid, also leaving the people who have been intended to benefit out of decision-making. Consequently, in many more recent programmes, one has explored more

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<sup>2</sup> For a brief and instructive overview of main issues and experiences, I recommend Birgegaard, 1994.



participatory approaches, normally coupled with a broader array of financial services and incorporation of these services in more comprehensive development thrusts, including components of a non-financial nature as well. Moreover, many development agencies now promote systems of financial services that are anchored in people's own organisations. To this end, social mobilisation and various organisation building measures are normally essential.

Thus, a recognised need for more comprehensive and flexible systems of financial services, often along with ideas of people's empowerment, has led to the promotion of new organisational structures and modes of operation. Through these, the financial services have become embedded in more elaborate systems of decision-making and operation relating to a broader set of people's concerns. In other words, increasing the programme scope—from mere delivery and recovery of credit to a wider range of services linked to a broader set of concerns of the beneficiaries and more comprehensive involvement by the latter—have required a fundamental change of approach in virtually all senses.<sup>3</sup>

It should go without saying that such questions of programme and project delimitation and related aspects of purpose, management, performance and goal achievement may be crucial matters for analysis in evaluations of virtually any development programme and project. They may constitute highly important analytical variables for assessing impact as well as other performance dimensions of development schemes (see Part Two), and may be of particular significance in formative evaluations of programmes with a relatively high degree of flexibility.

## STATING ASSUMPTIONS: ONE EXAMPLE

In plan documents, external factors on which the performance of a planned development programme or project may depend are often presented as *assumptions*. For instance, this is one of three dimensions of development schemes that are incorporated in the earlier mentioned logical framework—the two others being means–ends relations (addressed in Chapter 4) and indicators (to be addressed in Chapter 14).

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<sup>3</sup> For further elaboration and discussion of issues involved, reference is made to much recent literature on community organisation and micro-finance. I have done some research on this myself (for instance, Dale, 2002a).



Stated assumptions are direct responses to the question: ‘under what conditions may the intended outputs be produced/the intended benefits generated?’. This basically equals: ‘what are the requirements in the programme or project’s environment that need to be fulfilled for the intended outputs/the intended benefits to materialise?’.

Simultaneously, we have stated, in many instances the distinction between a development scheme and what is external to the scheme may be a porous boundary rather than a clear-cut dividing line. Moreover, the boundary may change, particularly in process programmes.

Relations between components of a means–ends structure and assumptions relating to each of these components are illustrated in Table 5.1. The structure resembles parts of the structure of our health promotion project (Figure 4.1).

Note that the specified assumptions in any row relate to fulfilment of objectives in the row above. That is, they are conditions under which outputs/objectives in the same row are intended to be converted into related objectives in the next row.

We can discern different degrees of firmness or clarity of the boundary between elements of the means–ends chain and the formulated assumptions. Thus, some assumptions may not be expressions of exclusively external factors. For example, the participants’ motivation to learn may mostly depend on aspects of their living situation that the project does not address, but it may also be influenced by the mode of teaching. On the other hand, the economic ability of the households to buy additional food items will not at all be affected by this project (given that the stated output is the only one, created through a corresponding set of inputs and implementation tasks).

Such porous boundaries between concerns of programmes and projects and aspects of their environment may also inject an amount of ambiguity into the formulation of means–ends structures and relations between these and the set of stated assumptions.

The means–ends chain of this table is more elaborate than such chains in a logical framework format, for instance (see the previous chapter). Obviously, when compressing means–ends structures, one also has to reformulate the assumptions, usually making them more general. It falls outside the scope of this book to explore these issues further.<sup>4</sup>

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<sup>4</sup> For a comprehensive analysis, see Dale, 2004 (Chapter 8).

**Table 5.1**

**RELATIONS BETWEEN MEANS-ENDS CATEGORIES  
AND ASSUMPTIONS**

**EFFECT OBJECTIVE**

Children are better  
nourished

**IMMEDIATE OBJECTIVES**

Children's consumption  
of more nutritious food  
is increased

More nutritious meals  
are provided

More healthy food  
is accessed

The parents' knowledge  
about nutrition  
is enhanced

**OUTPUT**

Information about nutrition  
is given to parents

**ASSUMPTIONS**

The effect of more nutritious  
food is not counterbalanced  
by other practices

The children <sup>and</sup> accept ~~to~~ eat  
more nutritious food items

The higher-quality food is  
properly handled and prepared

The households can afford  
additional food items

The households prioritise  
healthy food for children

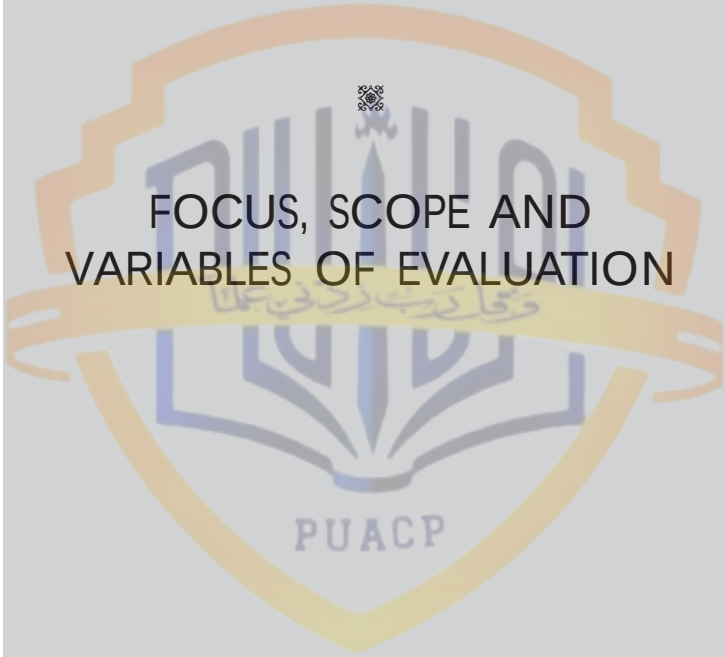
**ASSUMPTIONS**

The trainees are able to  
understand the information  
The trainees are motivated  
to learn

## PART TWO



# FOCUS, SCOPE AND VARIABLES OF EVALUATION





## Chapter 6

# A FRAMEWORK OF ANALYTICAL CATEGORIES

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### THE GENERAL PERSPECTIVE

Figure 6.1 provides a basic perspective on evaluation of development work, in terms of analytical categories and relationships. In the figure we have:

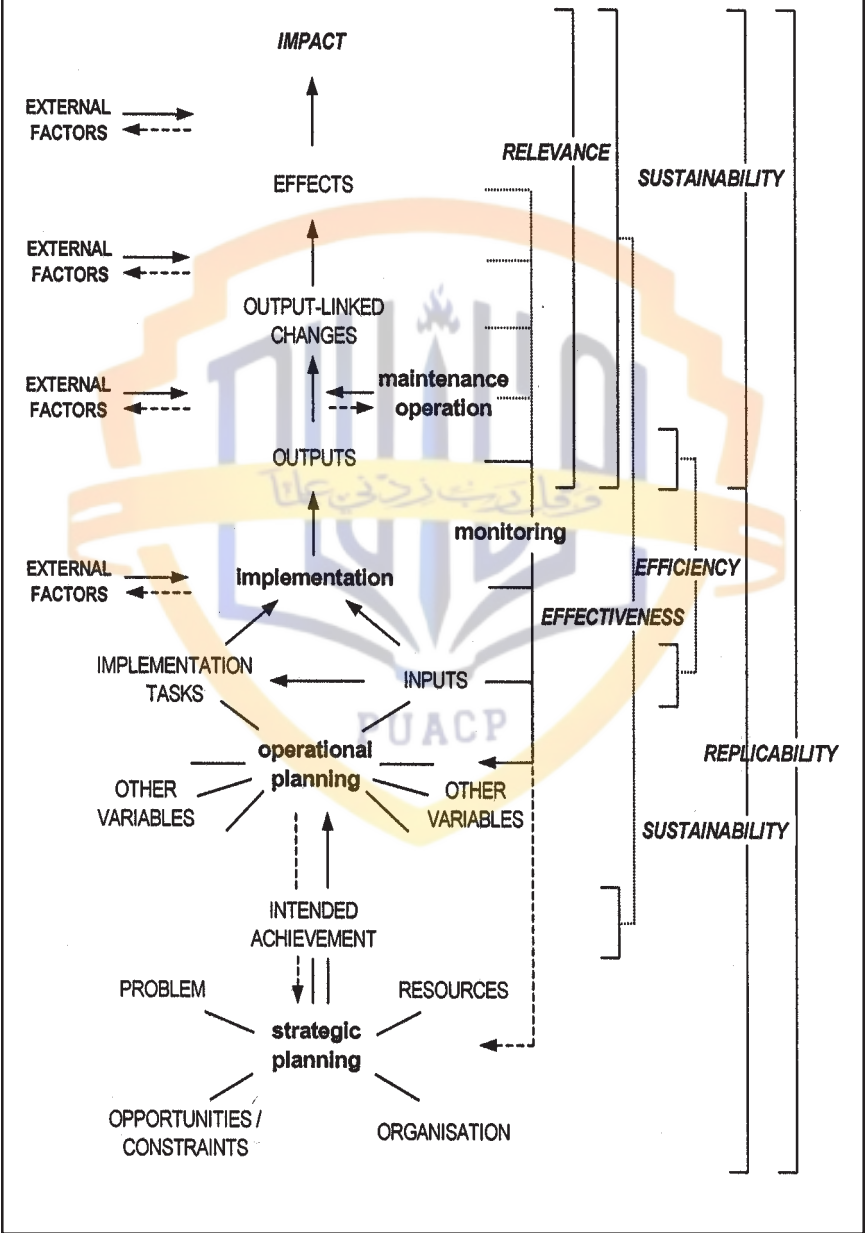
- connected the basic *variables of planning* to the general *means-ends structure* of programmes and projects; and
- related this set of variables to the core *analytical categories of evaluation*.

In line with our perspective in Part One, a distinction has been made between *strategic planning* and *operational planning*, both involving an interrelated analysis of a range of variables and concomitant decision-taking about courses of action.<sup>1</sup> Planning is then shown to be followed by *implementation*, that is, the execution of tasks that have been planned, using allocated resources. Programme or project activities will also be subjected to *monitoring*, as clarified in Chapter 3. Implementation will, in turn, create *outputs*, which are intended to generate a set of linked *benefits* at different levels, as outlined in Chapter 4. Since we are concerned with actual rather than planned changes, we have used evaluation-related terms (for instance, ‘impact’ rather than ‘development objective’).

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<sup>1</sup> For a comprehensive overview and discussion of dimensions, variables and processes of planning in the development field, the reader is again requested to read Dale, 2004. Evaluators often need to assess such aspects of planning, as they are commonly crucial explanatory variables for programme and project performance. The mentioned book should help equip evaluators with analytical concepts and tools to that end.

**Figure 6.1**  
**EVALUATION PERSPECTIVE 1**



Influence from the programme/project environment on the scheme and its achievements is visualised by arrows from *external factors* to the respective parts of the means–ends chain. Stippled lines are drawn in the opposite direction, indicating a possibility in some instances for the programme or project to influence factors that are generally viewed as existing in the scheme’s environment. This, then, signifies the porous nature of many boundaries between the internal and the external, emphasised and exemplified in Chapter 5. Of course, the strength and importance of external factors may vary greatly for various programme/project components at various levels. Usually, such factors tend to be particularly influential at the levels of effects and impact. As already alluded to, in most projects of a technical nature, the responsible organisation or organisations ought to be in good control of the production of outputs. In other cases, however, even outputs may have to be generated in interplay with many and strong environmental forces. This applies most of all to outputs of an intangible or a qualitative nature. For instance, many intended outputs of institution-building programmes (see Figure 4.2) are of this nature.

The major concerns of evaluation are illustrated in Figure 6.1 by connections between the *main analytical categories* of evaluation and relevant entries in the means–ends and activity structure of programmes and projects. That is, the respective evaluation categories are viewed as relating to specific and different parts of that structure. The categories of evaluation are italicised in Figure 6.1. Note that this also applies to one of the means–ends categories itself—that of ‘impact’. This will be clarified later.

While the most direct focus in evaluations will normally be on one or more components of the means–ends structure, it is, of course, equally important to analyse features, activities and forces that are linked to these components and the nature and strength of the relations. That is how one may explain manifestations on various components. It may involve analysis of numerous dimensions of organisation; systems and processes of planning, implementation, monitoring, and, possibly, operation and maintenance; and external forces and how the responsible organisation or set of organisations relates to them.

The formulated evaluation categories (including ‘impact’), or some of them, are widely considered to be the most basic ones in evaluations. However, they may not anywhere else have been presented



and related to components of programme/project structures quite the way I have done it. Moreover, parts of the terminology in evaluation documents often deviates from the one used here.<sup>2</sup> Mostly, it is a matter of using the same or similar terms with somewhat different meanings. Such deviations may be of limited concern when the terms are well defined and are used consistently. That, however, is often not the case. Such vague and inconsistent usage of core terms is unfortunate, in that it may blur the focus and scope of the analysis, confuse readers, make recommendations unclear, hamper discussions of follow-up action, and be a bottleneck against cumulative learning. I hope that my efforts to define terms well, and to use the terms in accordance with these definitions, will be helpful well beyond the reading and understanding of this book.

## THE ANALYTICAL CATEGORIES

### Relevance

The issue here is *to what extent the programme or project has addressed or is addressing problems of high priority*, mainly as viewed by actual and potential stakeholders, particularly the programme's or project's beneficiaries and any other people who might have been its beneficiaries.<sup>3</sup>

The question may be whether the resources that have gone into, or are going into, the scheme might have been used to greater advantage in *alternative development measures*. For most development schemes, though, use of resources in entirely different fields might not have been a realistic option (in the perspective of summative evaluation) or may not be so (in the perspective of formative evaluation). If at all, it may here be a matter of some reorientation within the same general field. In other instances of formative evaluation, the evaluators

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<sup>2</sup> Samset (2003) is an example of a writer who uses the same set of terms, except 'replicability', with almost identical meanings, in the context of conventional projects.

<sup>3</sup> 'Stakeholder' is a commonly used term in development planning and management. We have also made brief mention of it earlier. Most generally stated, stakeholders are beneficiaries and other bodies with an interest in a programme or project. The connected 'stakeholder analysis' may be generally defined as identifying the bodies with an interest in the scheme, assessing their present and/or future stakes in it, and clarifying any actual or potential involvement by them in it or other influence on it.

may have a possibility of influencing direction more substantially. For instance, this may be the case for the profile and composition of projects within flexible programmes, or the fields of priority of a mutual benefit organisation (possibly assessed by the organisation's own members, through an internal evaluation).

Closely related, one may ask whether it is the *people most in need* of the rendered assistance who have received or are receiving the benefits of the programme or project.

A more specific question may be whether intended beneficiaries may *avail themselves* of a provided facility, for affordability or other reasons. For instance, there may be costs attached to the use of some service after the programme or project period that may exclude certain people from it. While the service may in itself be viewed as useful, it would then no longer be relevant for those people.

Moreover, for long-term development schemes planned in a basically blueprint mode, an appropriate question may occasionally be whether *original priorities* are still appropriate. If initial circumstances have changed, it may be warranted to change or in exceptional cases even terminate such a scheme before its completion.

Yet another question may be how well the programme or project fits with other development work that is or has been undertaken in the same area or the same field. Sub-questions may be whether it supplements such other work or instead overlaps with it, and whether it mobilises additional resources (local or external) or competes with other schemes for the same resources.

## Effectiveness

'Effectiveness' expresses to *what extent the planned outputs, expected changes, intended effects (immediate and effect objectives) and intended impact (development objective) are being or have been produced or achieved*. This is shown in Figure 6.1 by a link between 'intended achievements' on the one side and 'outputs', 'output linked changes', 'effects' and 'impact' on the other side.

In practice, in effectiveness analysis, it may often be most useful to focus mainly on the *effects* on the achievement side, for the following reasons:

- the effect level is commonly the first level at which benefits for the intended beneficiaries are directly expressed, making effects

a more significant measure of achievements than more direct changes and much more so than outputs;

- being more directly derived from the activities of the respective programme or project than the more general impact, the effects will normally be less influenced by intervening external factors and may therefore be assessed quicker and more reliably; and
- thorough impact assessments, being commonly highly complex, may require a partly different methodology and may therefore most effectively be done additionally (see immediately below).

## Impact

As clarified in Chapter 4, 'impact' means *the overall consequences of the programme or project* for the intended beneficiaries and any other people. The consequences may be more or less indirect and will usually take some time to materialise. They may sometimes be studied in the course of implementation of a programme or project (particularly in long-term programmes with process planning), shortly after a programme or project has been terminated, or—usually most effectively—at some later time. In the last-mentioned case, sustainability will also be an issue (see shortly below).

The main impact is, of course, expected to be positive. However, there may be negative impact also, on beneficiary groups or others. This should be analysed as well.

In some cases, negative consequences may have been suspected or even expected at the planning stage. They may then have been mentioned in the plan documents, with or without counteracting measures. In other cases, they may have been unforeseen. They may then also be more difficult to trace for evaluators.

The impact is normally generated through complex relations and processes. It may therefore need to be analysed through broad-focusing, beneficiary-centred investigations, often with the use of more than one method (see Chapters 9 and 12 for elaboration).

Sometimes, in practice, it may not be easy, or perhaps even useful, to distinguish clearly between what we have referred to as 'effects' and 'impact', or one may for other reasons find it more appropriate to focus on certain effects rather than the more general impact of a scheme. That may be the case even in evaluation thrusts that purport to examine the overall change for intended beneficiaries, and in which a corresponding methodology may also be used. This might have been

visualised in Figure 6.1 by italicisation of the ‘effects’ category as well. I have not done so, in order to avoid confusion about the general purpose and scope of this kind of evaluation. In such cases of rationally chosen more specific variables of benefit, the basic logic of impact evaluation still applies—the justification being to emphasise certain achievements that the evaluator thinks are particularly significant in the specific context.

### Efficiency

With this is meant *the amount of outputs created and their quality in relation to the resources (capital and human efforts) invested*. This is shown in Figure 6.1 by a link between ‘inputs’ and ‘outputs’. It is, then, a measure of how productively the resources (as converted into inputs) have been used. One may then have to examine a range of activities and related systems and routines, such as procedures of acquiring inputs, mechanisms of quality assurance, various aspects of organisation, etc. The efficiency may also be related to the time taken to create the outputs.

All inputs are usually quantified. The total cost of the outputs equals the sum of the costs of the various inputs that have gone into producing the outputs (which may include shares of general overhead costs and sometimes even an assessed value of unpaid labour).

For most physical engineering projects, one may estimate fairly objectively the amounts of various inputs that are reasonable for producing outputs of certain amounts and quality. For most other development schemes, this is usually not possible, and much subjective assessment by the evaluator may therefore be needed. Such judgements have to be based primarily on circumstances and conditions under which the programme or project under evaluation has been planned and implemented. They may be further substantiated by experiences from the same or similar development work or by sound theoretical reasoning.

Irrespective of the basis for such judgements, one will, for most societal development schemes, have to be satisfied with indicative conclusions only.

In principle, efficiency analysis may also relate to higher levels in a means–ends structure than outputs, that is, changes and benefits that are derived from the latter. However, meaningful analysis of efficiency at these levels requires that the changes or benefits are not

substantially influenced by environmental factors, or influenced in ways that may not change much—a situation that is rare in development work.<sup>4</sup>

Quantitative benefit–cost and cost-effectiveness analysis are special approaches for assessing efficiency, applicable in specific situations under specific conditions. Due to the latter, and because of the importance that has tended to be attached to these economic tools in certain kinds of evaluation, we shall address them in a separate chapter (Chapter 13).

We have emphasised the focus in development work on benefits for people, and that evaluations of development programmes and projects should normally also have this focus. That makes efficiency analysis a strictly limited part of such evaluations, if aspects of efficiency are at all addressed. However, here we may need to distinguish between single-standing comprehensive evaluations of development schemes (just assumed) and evaluation thrusts that constitute parts of a bigger evaluation system. For the former, the above should definitely apply. For the latter, there may be more flexibility of focus. For instance, within a system of primarily formative evaluations such as the one presented in Box 2.1 (Chapter 2), single evaluation thrusts (or reviews, which they may alternatively be called), may have a more specific purpose and narrow scope. Some such exercises may even focus exclusively on aspects of efficiency—providing feedback into planning processes that should, of course, have a clear overall focus on benefits for people.

### Sustainability

This means *the maintenance or augmentation of positive achievements induced by the evaluated programme or project (or any component*

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<sup>4</sup> Fink and Kosekoff (1985) present a case of performance analysis relating to benefits, in the social service sector. In their case, residents of a centre for elderly people were randomly assigned to one of three alternative care programmes for a certain period of time. Thereafter, the quality of the three programmes, as assessed by the beneficiaries, was compared (which could be done relatively reliably, due to the large number of residents and the method of selection of participants in the respective programmes). This may primarily be a case of *effectiveness* analysis. Simultaneously, if the cost per beneficiary of the three programmes was similar, the outcome of the assessment might be a measure of *efficiency* as well. In our context, the core point in relation to efficiency analysis is that the programme managers were able to establish strict control over the experiment through measures that prevented substantial unpredicted influence by programme-external factors.

*of it) after the scheme (or any component of it) has been terminated.*

Evaluators may assess the prospect for sustainability of the scheme in the course of its implementation (being often essential in process programmes) or at the time of its completion, or they may substantiate the sustainability at some later time.

Sustainability may relate to all the levels in our means–ends framework. It may, however, not always be relevant for the lower part of our model (the operational levels). That depends on whether the kind of development work that has been or is being done by the programme or project is intended to be continued after the termination of that intervention, through the same organisation or through one or more other organisations.

More specific examples of sustainability are:

- maintenance of physical facilities produced (such as a road);
- continued use of physical facilities (such as a road) or intangible qualities (such as knowledge);
- continued ability to plan and manage similar development work, by organisations that have been in charge of the programme or project or any other organisations that are intended to undertake the work;
- continued production of the same outputs (for instance, teachers from a teachers' training college);
- maintenance of the scheme's effects and impact (for instance, continued improved health due to new sanitation practices); and
- multiplication of effects and impact, of the same or related kinds, through inducements from facilities or qualities created by the programme or project.

### Replicability

Replicability means *the feasibility of repeating the particular programme or project or parts of it in another context*, i.e., at a later time, in other areas, for other groups of people, by other organisations, etc.

This is an issue that may or may not be relevant or important. In some instances, replicability may be a major evaluation concern. That is most obviously the case with so-called pilot programmes and projects, that is, schemes that aim at testing the feasibility or results of a particular intervention or approach. But replicability is important



for all programmes and projects from which one wants to learn for wider application.

The replicability of a development scheme depends on both programme/project-internal factors and environmental factors.

A replicability analysis may also include an assessment of any changes that may be made in the evaluated scheme in order to enhance its scope for replication.

## SOME EXAMPLES

For further familiarisation with the presented analytical categories, examples of possible evaluation variables under each category are listed in Table 6.1, for one project and one programme. Of course, these are just a few out of a larger number of variables that might be analysed. Based on the clarifications above, the variables should be self-explanatory.

A special comment may, however, be warranted on the impact statement for the Industrial Development Fund. In our exploration of means–ends structures in Part One (Chapter 4), we mentioned that in some instances a development objective (if at all formulated) may be just an assumption or close to that (while still, of course, having to be logically derived and credible). That is, it is not always an intended achievement that one may try to substantiate, at least vigorously and systematically. Most likely, the stated intended impact of this programme is of this kind.



**Table 6.1****EXAMPLES OF EVALUATION VARIABLES****WATER SUPPLY AND  
SANITATION PROJECT****INDUSTRIAL  
DEVELOPMENT FUND****RELEVANCE**

Hygiene related problems of the beneficiaries compared with those of other people

Criteria for use of the fund in relation to perceived needs of industrialists

Hygiene related problems of the beneficiaries compared with other problems in their living environment

The ability of new entrepreneurs to access the fund

**EFFECTIVENESS**

In relation to intended outputs/objectives:

The number of wells of specified quality that have been constructed

Change in the profit of supported enterprises

Change in the frequency of water borne diseases

Change in the level of employment in economic fields of support

**IMPACT**

Change in the frequency of water borne diseases

Changes in perceived economic situation of people in the programme areas (through changes in employment)

**EFFICIENCY**

Cost per constructed well of acceptable quality

Number of persons employed in fund management

Unit cost (cost per hour/trained person) of sanitation training

Administrative cost per unit (e.g., 1000 USD) of lent money

**SUSTAINABILITY**

Adequacy of maintenance of the wells

Change in the size of the fund through loan repayment (principal + interest)

Continued functioning of Water Users' Associations

Long-term demand for loans

**REPLICABILITY**

Feasibility of replicating the project management model in other districts

Feasibility of replicating the programme with other banks

## Chapter 7

# ASSESSING ORGANISATIONAL ABILITY AND PERFORMANCE

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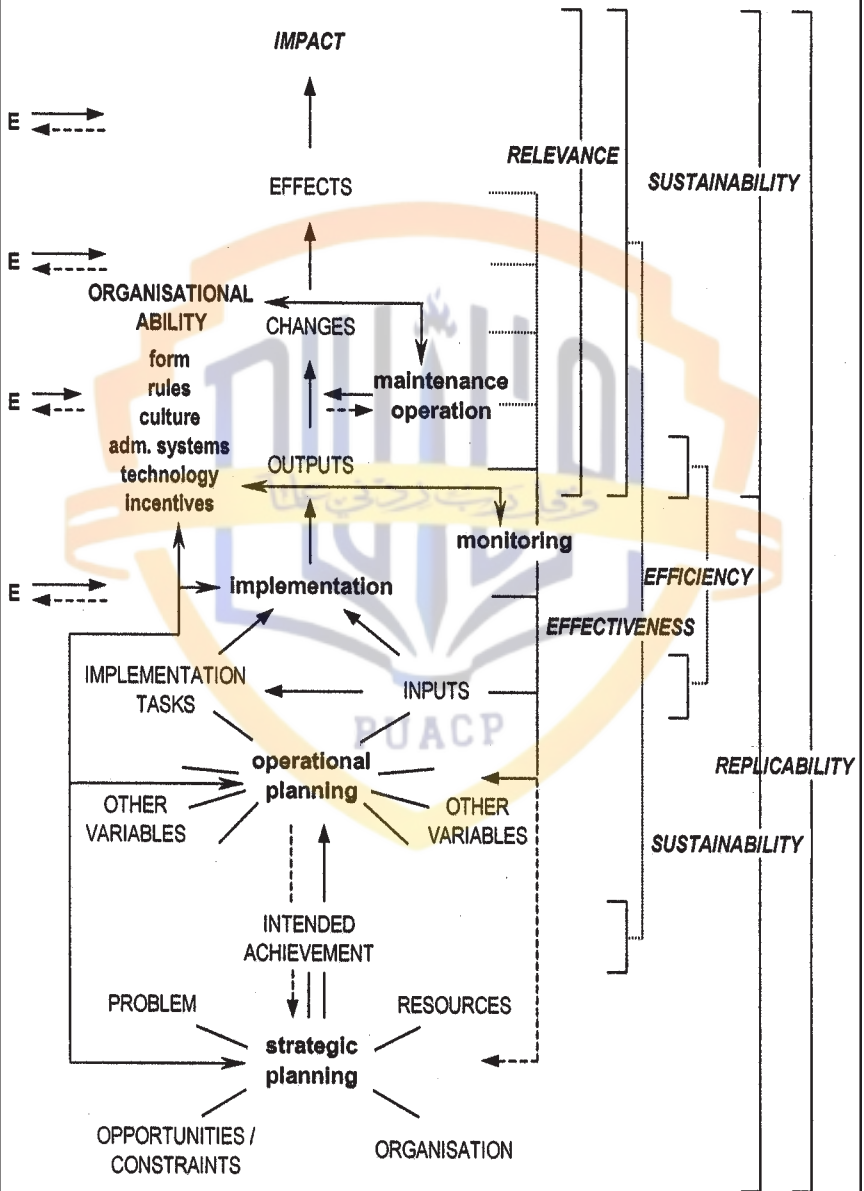
### ANALYSING ORGANISATION IN PROGRAMME/ PROJECT-FOCUSED EVALUATIONS

In Figure 7.1 we have added the dimension of organisation to the model that we developed in the preceding chapter (Figure 6.1). We have specified features of organisation that may be considered as the primary variables in analyses of organisational performance: form; rules; culture; administrative systems; technology and incentives. These variables will be briefly clarified soon, together with some other, more derived, variables of organisation.

Just note that, in Figure 7.1, we have abbreviated a couple of category designations, due to space limitations. Thus, 'output-linked changes' in Figure 6.1 has become just 'changes' and 'external factors' just 'e' (which may also be taken to stand for 'environment').

As clarified in Part One, development programmes and projects are organised thrusts. Obviously, then, aspects of organisation are crucial for the quality of work that is done. In the figure, organisational ability is shown to influence all the categories of work in a programme or project—planning, implementation, monitoring, operation and maintenance—and therewith all the achievements of the scheme. There is also a link in the other direction: organisational ability will normally also be influenced by work experience.

Equally obviously, evaluators of development programmes or projects will usually have to analyse organisational ability and performance in relation to activities and achievements that are analysed. Commonly, variables of organisation ought to be given major attention, as they are often the main explanatory factors for the quality of work and the benefits that are generated.

**Figure 7.1****EVALUATION PERSPECTIVE 2**

This notwithstanding, in my experience, organisation analysis has tended not to be given due attention in many evaluations. This may be linked to a rather technocratic tradition in much development work (and in academic fields where most development planners, managers and even researchers are educated), having tended to marginalise behavioural factors.<sup>1</sup>

## ORGANISATION-FOCUSED EVALUATIONS

Figure 7.2 illustrates basic *perspectives* in evaluations with the primary focus on one or more development organisations, rather than programmes or projects.

Consequently, ‘organisation’ and analytical variables of organisation are located in the centre of the figure. For undertaking any kind of work, the organisation must have access to resources of various kinds (in the figure specified as human, financial, physical and material). Moreover, the organisation will work in a societal setting (context). As clarified in Chapter 5, contextual concerns may be expressed as present opportunities, future (potential) opportunities, present constraints and future threats. In Figure 7.2, the organisation is shown as linking up with resources and connecting to its environment, normally involving more or less complex relations and interactions. These variables and connections will be basic concerns in planning, but will be equally important in evaluations of performance and achievements.

In Figure 7.2, the evaluated organisation is shown to be undertaking development work at various stages of progress. We may conceive of each of the illustrated enterprises as projects. By the time of evaluation, three projects have generated or are generating benefits (generally stated as ‘achievements’), also meaning that they have been completed or are ongoing. One project has reached the initial stage of implementation, and one is at the proposal stage only. There may also be other project ideas in the organisation, not (yet) developed into what we might call proposals.

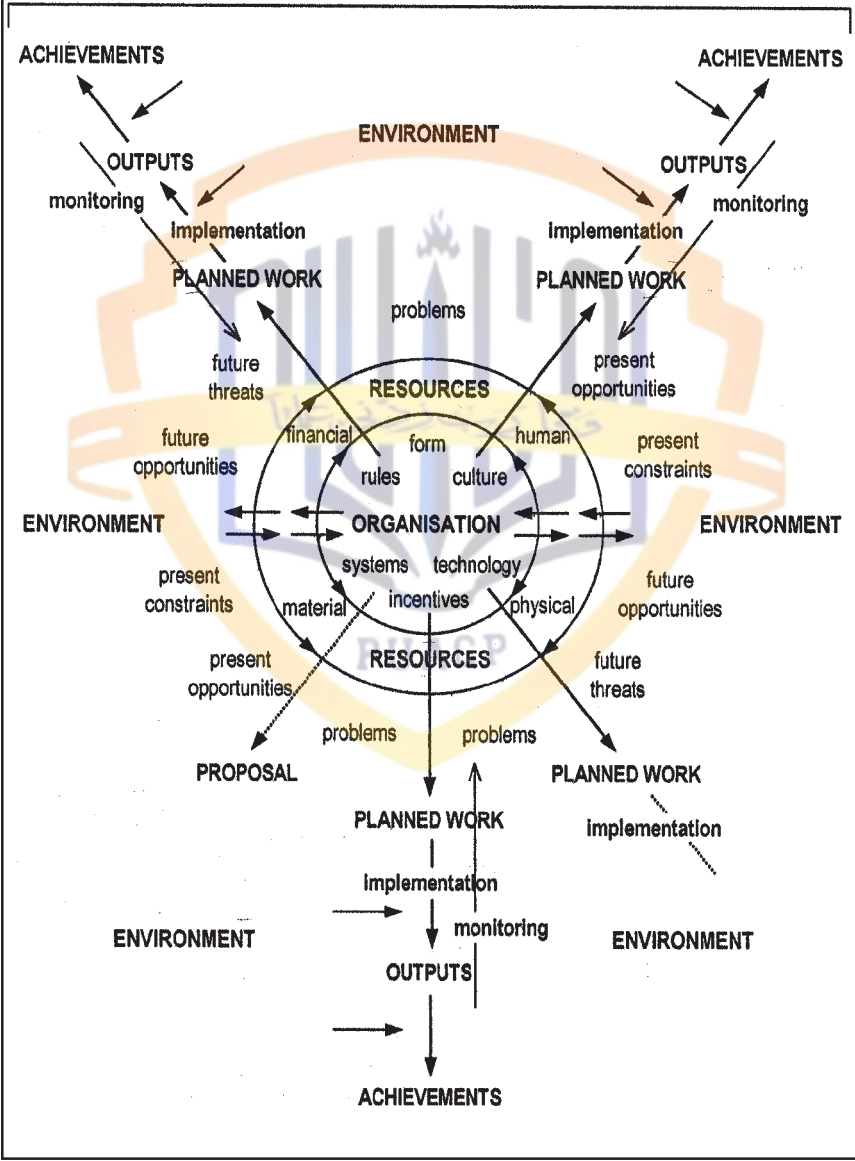
Organisation-focused evaluations will normally address both various aspects of organisation and the performance and achievements

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<sup>1</sup> An indication is the dominant position of the logical framework and the so-called logical framework analysis in much planning in the development sphere.

**Figure 7.2**  
**EVALUATION PERSPECTIVE 3**

|                   |                       |                      |
|-------------------|-----------------------|----------------------|
| <b>EFFICIENCY</b> | <b>SUSTAINABILITY</b> | <b>REPLICABILITY</b> |
| <b>RELEVANCE</b>  | <b>EFFECTIVENESS</b>  | <b>IMPACT</b>        |



of work that the organisation undertakes. Somewhat more specifically, the assessment may *encompass*:

- the organisation's general vision and mission as well as general and more specific objectives of the work that it does, normally also incorporating the kinds of people whom it is serving or intends to serve;
- how the organisation analyses and deals with features and forces in its environment, i.e., problems to be addressed and opportunities, constraints and threats;
- internal organisational features and processes (overall and in specific work tasks and programmes/projects);
- acquisition and use of resources (overall and in specific work tasks and programmes/projects);
- benefits that the organisation has generated and/or is generating for people.

Work that the organisation undertakes ought to be analysed in the perspective of the general analytical categories that we have specified (appearing at the top of the figure). Just to indicate, one may emphasise aspects such as relevance of programme or project objectives, efficiency of resource use, effectiveness of one or more projects or project types, sustainability of impacts, etc.

Such evaluations may be limited to one organisation or cover more than one organisation. In the latter case, comparison of features of the organisations and of the performance and achievements of their work may be a main purpose.

Evaluations of single organisations may often be done by members or employees of the respective organisations. We have already referred to such assessments as *internal evaluations*. This means that members of an organisation scrutinise their organisation's priorities, features, activities and achievements in a formalised and relatively systematic manner, solely or basically for internal learning. Of course, some kind of assessment of aspects of one's organisation and its work is usually done frequently by people in the organisation, but the extent to which such exercises are conducted as formalised interactive processes varies greatly.<sup>2</sup>

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<sup>2</sup> For a broad examination of internal evaluations, see Love, 1991. Other authors, as well, examine issues of internal evaluation, albeit under other headings. Simple

Evaluations of organisations need to be very sensitive to and thoroughly examine *changes* over time. This involves specifying the changes, explaining them (for which it is essential to sort between organisation-internal and -external factors), and analysing how the changes have affected the workings of the organisation. More specific questions may be to what extent the organisation has learnt from changes in its environment, and whether it has adjusted its vision and mission as well as its objectives, plans and modes of operation in response to such changes. Another set of questions is how constructively the organisation has addressed internal conflicts or other internal crises that may have occurred, and what it has learnt from such conflicts and crises for its future pursuits.

## MAIN ORGANISATIONAL VARIABLES

I shall here give a concise overview of the main variables of organisation that frequently need to be analysed in both planning and evaluation of development programmes and projects.<sup>3</sup>

We have already, in the figures of this chapter, listed a set of basic variables of organisation. Brief definitions and elaborations of them are as follows:

An organisation's form stands for the number and types of units within the organisation and main relations of work between these

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while informative contributions include those by Drucker (1993), for non-profit organisations, and Germann et al. (1996), under the heading of 'participatory impact monitoring', partly relating to locally managed organisations.

In the business field, in particular, a range of techniques have been devised for primarily internal analysis of the purpose, approach and performance of organisations. They may be applied for assessing the organisation generally or specific activities, and may cover anything from the general rationale of the organisation to specific aspects of effectiveness and efficiency. Mostly, however, they have been applied to analyse aspects of organisational strategy (as defined earlier in the book). For such analysis, techniques include: lifecycle analysis, portfolio analysis, stakeholder analysis, PEST (political, economic, social and technology) analysis, and SWOT/SWOC (strengths, weaknesses, opportunities, and threats/constraints) analysis. All these tools are of a primarily qualitative kind.

<sup>3</sup> The presentation is largely taken from Dale, 2004. It is, however, beyond the scope of both that and the present book to substantially examine relations between organisational variables and the performance of development schemes. For further reading, see Cusworth and Franks (eds), 1993; Dale, 2000. Porras (1987) contains a good analysis relating to organisations more generally, of substantial relevance for the work of development organisations also.



units. It reflects the purpose and sphere of work of the organisation and predominant patterns of communication, responsibility and power.

Dale (2000) distinguishes between the following primary forms of development organisations:

- *Collective*: a group of people who work together, more than casually, on relatively equal terms for a common purpose;
- *One-leader body*: an organisation, usually small, in which one person directly guides and oversees all major affairs;
- *Hierarchy*: a firmly structured organisation, having one person in overall charge at the top and an increasing number of units at successively lower levels, each of which has a manager, being responsible for the work of that unit as well as any linked units at lower levels;
- *Loosely-coupled network*: an entity, often of changing size, consisting of people who primarily work together on a case-to-case basis, often through changing partnerships and normally relating to one another on fairly equal terms;
- *Matrix*: one organisation or a constellation of organisations or parts of them in which individuals are responsible to two managers (or two sets of managers) for different (but often similar) work tasks.

All these forms have their strengths and their weaknesses, and may be suitable for different pursuits and environments. For example, the collective may be appropriate for relatively simple activities done by small numbers of equals; some form of hierarchy will be needed for work according to bureaucratic principles; and the loosely-coupled network, by its flexibility, may respond best to challenges in uncertain and changing environments.

Like most typologies, this typology represents an approximation of more complex realities. While most development organisations are at least primarily characterised by features of one of the mentioned forms, a few may be more difficult to locate in this framework. One reason may be that they are changing. For instance, a one-leader body may gradually be transformed into more of a hierarchy as it grows, because the leader may no longer have the capacity to be in direct charge of all that is done.

The concept of organisational culture has its roots in the anthropological concept of 'social culture'. Generally stated, an organisation's

culture is the set of values, norms and perceptions that frame and guide the behaviour of individuals in the organisation and the organisation as a whole, along with connected social and physical features (artefacts), constructed by the organisation's members. All these facets of culture are usually strongly influenced by the customs of the society in which the organisation is located.

*Values* are closely linked to the organisation's general vision and mission.<sup>4</sup> They may be very important for development organisations. Many such organisations are even founded on a strong common belief in specific qualities of societies, which then becomes an effective guiding principle for the work that they do. Usually, the ability to further such qualities will then also be perceived by the members or employees of these organisations as a main reward for their work. Some people may not even get any payment for the time they spend and the efforts they put in.

Examples of important *norms* and *perceptions* in organisations may be: the extent of individualism or group conformity; innovativeness and attitudes to new ideas and proposals for change; the degree of loyalty vis-à-vis colleagues, particularly in directly work-related matters; the extent of concern for the personal well-being of colleagues; perceptions of customers or beneficiaries; and perceptions of strains and rewards in one's work.

In a study of community-based member organisations, Dale (2002a) found that the following features of culture were particularly important for good performance and sustainability of the organisations: open access for everybody to organisation-related information; regular (commonly formalised) sharing of information; active participation by all (or virtually all) the members in common activities; respect for and adherence to agreed formal and informal rules of behaviour; sensitivity to special problems and needs of individual members; and a willingness to sacrifice something personally for the common good.

Values, norms and related perceptions of importance for organisational performance may, of course, differ among an organisation's members. Influencing and unifying an organisation's culture is often one of the main challenges for the organisation's leader or leaders.

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<sup>4</sup> These terms stand for the most general and usually most stable principles and purposes of development organisations. For fuller definitions, see Dale, 2004 (Chapter 3).

Rules are provisions for regulating the behaviour of individuals in the organisation and the organisation as a whole, in internal matters and in dealings with outside bodies. Rules are needed for two main purposes: (a) to properly institutionalise organisational values and norms, by which they will permeate the organisation's pursuits, and (b) to promote work efficiency.

Rules may be formalised to larger or lesser extents. Normally, they are then formulated in writing, in greater or lesser detail. Highly formalised rules about processes of work are commonly referred to as 'procedures'. But rules may also be less formal and sometimes even entirely informal. They may then be quite direct manifestations of the organisation's culture, and the distinction between culture and rules becomes blurred.

Administrative systems encompass all formally designed and established routines and formats for co-ordinating and controlling the organisation's work. In most organisations beyond a minimum size, main examples of administrative systems are: management information systems (including a monitoring system); a financial accounting system; and a personnel management system.

An organisation's technology encompasses the set of tools that the organisation uses to plan, implement and monitor its work, along with the knowledge in using the tools. In development organisations, concepts, methods and techniques of planning programmes or projects are essential, as are guidelines for implementing and monitoring planned activities. More specific tools for converting inputs into outputs are also needed. Examples may be: a teaching methodology; techniques of organisation building; and physical things such as hand tools, machines and energy. More specific aspects of a monitoring technology are methods and techniques of generating, processing and using information about performance.

Of course, the degree of sophistication of technologies varies vastly. Moreover, in some kinds of development work, planning, implementation and monitoring may be so closely interrelated that one may not easily distinguish between technologies for each of them. In particular, this may be the case for simple or recurrent activities of collective organisations and for some programmes with predominantly process planning.

Incentives are the rewards that the organisation's personnel get from the work that they do, in terms of money, other tangible benefits, and intangible benefits (such as work satisfaction). Formalised

reward mechanisms may be referred to as a reward system, which may be considered as one of the organisation's administrative systems.

Most organisations have some reward system. However, as mentioned, in many development organisations non-formalised intangible rewards may be at least as important as the tangible ones, sometimes even the only kind of reward.

In addition to the basic organisational variables that have been outlined above, I shall briefly mention some other highly important dimensions of organisation, which tend to be of a more derived nature. In other words, they are variables that tend to be influenced or even largely determined by the already addressed variables, but they may also be influenced by other factors. There may be some influence in the other direction also; in other words, there may be more or less complex interrelations between the variables.

Organisational structure is often used instead of organisational 'form'. However, in much literature the term is used vaguely, even incorporating (albeit usually implicitly) features of other above-mentioned variables. This is unfortunate, easily clouding organisation analysis. In addition, 'structure' may be used to express organisational set-up beyond single organisations, not covered in our concept of 'form'. It is this meaning that I would like to allocate to the concept of 'structure' in an organisational context. For instance, certain co-operatives, community organisations, etc., may be structured in hierarchical tiers—such as primary, secondary and tertiary societies. Units of one tier may then be referred to as organisations with their particular form, while the full set-up of functionally interrelated bodies may be referred to by the term 'structure'. Moreover, there may be formalised collaborative arrangements between more independent organisations, the sets of and functional relations between which we may also call a 'structure'. For instance, we may use this term to signify the set of and relations between formally collaborating independent organisations in a regional development programme (such as an overall coordinating body, government line agencies or parts of them, community-based organisations, etc.).

Management and leadership, while not easy to define precisely, are crucial for the performance of organisations, including development organisations. The two terms are sometimes used interchangeably or largely so. In other instances, management is considered as the wider term, embedding leadership. For example, Mintzberg (1989) refers to the 'leader' role as one among several management roles. It

involves motivating and inspiring the people in the organisation, for which the leader needs vision, a good sense of judgement, and ability and clout to guide. Beside this leadership role, the 'manager' is also expected to play the roles of figurehead, liaison person, monitor, disseminator of information, spokesperson, entrepreneur, disturbance handler, resource allocator and negotiator.

Others consider 'leadership' to also encompass endeavours such as developing a clear vision of the organisation's future, building a supportive organisational culture, and creating and responding to opportunities in the organisation's environment (for instance, AIT, 1998).

Co-ordination is a highly important concept of organisation. Unfortunately, in the development field, the term has tended to be used rather loosely. This has reduced its analytical value correspondingly. Drawing on work by Mintzberg in the business sphere (particularly, Mintzberg, 1983), I have in other contexts (Dale, 1992; 2000) formulated a typology of modes of co-ordination that should be of direct relevance and applicability for most development organisations in relation to most of the work that they do. Basically, the typology should help promote an understanding of mechanisms of interaction and corresponding measures to improve collaboration towards common aims.

Dale (2000) broadly defines 'co-ordination' as the harmonisation of work that is done by various units within an organisation or by collaborating organisations. It is accomplished through a range of alternative or complementary mechanisms that are effectuated through specific tasks. The mechanisms specified by Dale are: promoting a common vision; establishing common objectives; standardising outputs; standardising skills; routinising work; direct supervision; and mutual adjustment.

The most effective combination of co-ordination mechanisms in any particular programme or project depends on numerous factors. They may be broadly summarised as: the size and complexity of the development scheme; the mode of planning that is applied; the size, form and other features of the organisation or organisations that are responsible for the scheme; and opportunities, constraints and threats in the environment of the responsible organisation or organisations.

Participation is another important dimension of organisation, having received increasing attention in much development work. Linked to the concept of 'stakeholder', it may be used with a variety

of meanings, largely depending on its scope. In the development sphere, it is most often applied in the sense of 'people's participation'. This is broadly understood as participation in development work by 'common' people in local communities, who are frequently also intended beneficiaries of the development work that has been, is being or is intended to be done.

Participation by intended beneficiaries and other stakeholders may be promoted for a range of reasons and may have various effects, for the development thrust and for the persons involved. The potential scope of people's participation is well expressed by the following three notions, presented by Oakley et al. (1991): participation as contribution, participation as organising, and participation as empowering.

People's participation may be analysed along a number of additional dimensions also. Examples of such dimensions are: free–forced, spontaneous–induced, direct–indirect, comprehensive–selective (partial), and intensive–extensive.

All the above-mentioned features of organisation apply and are relevant and significant for analysing performance and achievements of virtually all development organisations and the work that they do. In other words, they are highly important variables of evaluation, primarily for explanation, but sometimes even as intended or actual achievements that may have to be explained (for instance, the degree and forms of participation or leadership ability).



## Chapter 8

# EVALUATING CAPACITY-BUILDING

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### THE CONCEPTS OF CAPACITY-, ORGANISATION- AND INSTITUTION-BUILDING

Capacity-, organisation- and institution-building are now common terms of the development vocabulary. Their meanings overlap, but are not identical.

The broadest concept is capacity-building. This may relate to people directly (whether individuals or groups), to organisations, and to institutional qualities of a non-organisational kind.

When relating directly to *persons*, we may distinguish between two main notions:

First, capacity-building may mean the augmentation of people's resources and other abilities for the improvement of their living situation. The resources and abilities to be augmented may be varied. Examples may be money, land, other production assets, health for working, vocational skills, understanding (of any issue relating to the person's living environment) and negotiating power. In the context of development work, capacity-building in this sense normally applies to disadvantaged people, that is, people who do not have capacities that they need for ensuring reasonable welfare for themselves and their dependants. Thus, we are talking of the empowerment of deprived people.

In order to become empowered, active involvement (participation) is often required (see, 'participation as empowering', mentioned in the previous chapter). However, certain resources or qualities may have to be directly provided by others. Examples may be allocation of land or curing of a debilitating illness.

Second, development agents may seek to augment capacities of individuals not for their own benefit or not primarily so, but for the



benefit of others. One example may be the training of health personnel for the purpose of improving the health of the people whom they (the health personnel) serve. Another example may be the training of entrepreneurs, for the sake of increasing production and employment in an area, with the intention of benefiting the people who live there.

When relating to *organisations*, capacity-building may focus on a range of organisational dimensions and processes. Main examples are: need and policy analysis; strategic and operational planning; aspects of technology; management information systems; individual skills of various kinds; personnel incentives; and aspects of organisational culture.

In development fields, capacity-building of organisations is usually done by some other organisation. The promoting organisation may then augment capacity directly, by measures such as formal staff training, supply of office equipment, and assistance in improving work systems and routines. It may also provide financial and other kinds of support for development work that the new or strengthened organisations undertake. Under certain conditions, the latter type of support may also be capacity promoting, more indirectly, by helping the planning or implementing organisations learn from the work that they do.

We may, then, simply define organisation-building for development as building the capacity of organisations for whatever development work they undertake or are involved in (or which they intend to undertake or be involved in).

The concept of 'institution' is normally considered to extend beyond that of 'organisation'. Thus, institution-building may incorporate 'organisation-building', but also other activities. For instance, 'institution-building for a more democratic society' may go beyond the formation or strengthening of organisations (if at all incorporating organisation building). It may encompass components such as: formulating new national laws and regulations in various fields; conducting training in democratic principles of governance; influencing attitudes of politicians; encouraging participation by the wider public in decision-making forums; and promoting freedom of the press. Or, 'institution-building for deprived people' in local communities may involve measures that are complementary to the building of organisations for deprived people or organisations in which such people may participate. A couple of examples of wider measures may

be: assisting local governments in formulating regulations to secure access by poor people to forests or other local natural resources; and promoting co-operation between people of different ethnicity or religions.

‘Institution’ and ‘organisation’ are related in a somewhat different sense also. An organisation may be said to be institutionalised—that is, to be an institution—when it is widely recognised by those for whom it is or may be of concern, as a distinguishable unit with its own legitimate purpose and tasks (Uphoff, 1986, for instance). Thus, most organisations that are formed or strengthened to undertake development work should be institutions as well, or should be intended to become one. There may be exceptions, though, particularly in societies characterised by political repression.

Organisations should also possess wider institutional qualities than the above-mentioned one of recognition in their environment. Such qualities may largely be features of organisational ‘culture’—if that concept is defined broadly (as we have done)—and may even be embedded in organisational ‘rules’. Thus, some of the variables of organisation analysis that we specified in the previous chapter incorporate aspects of institution.

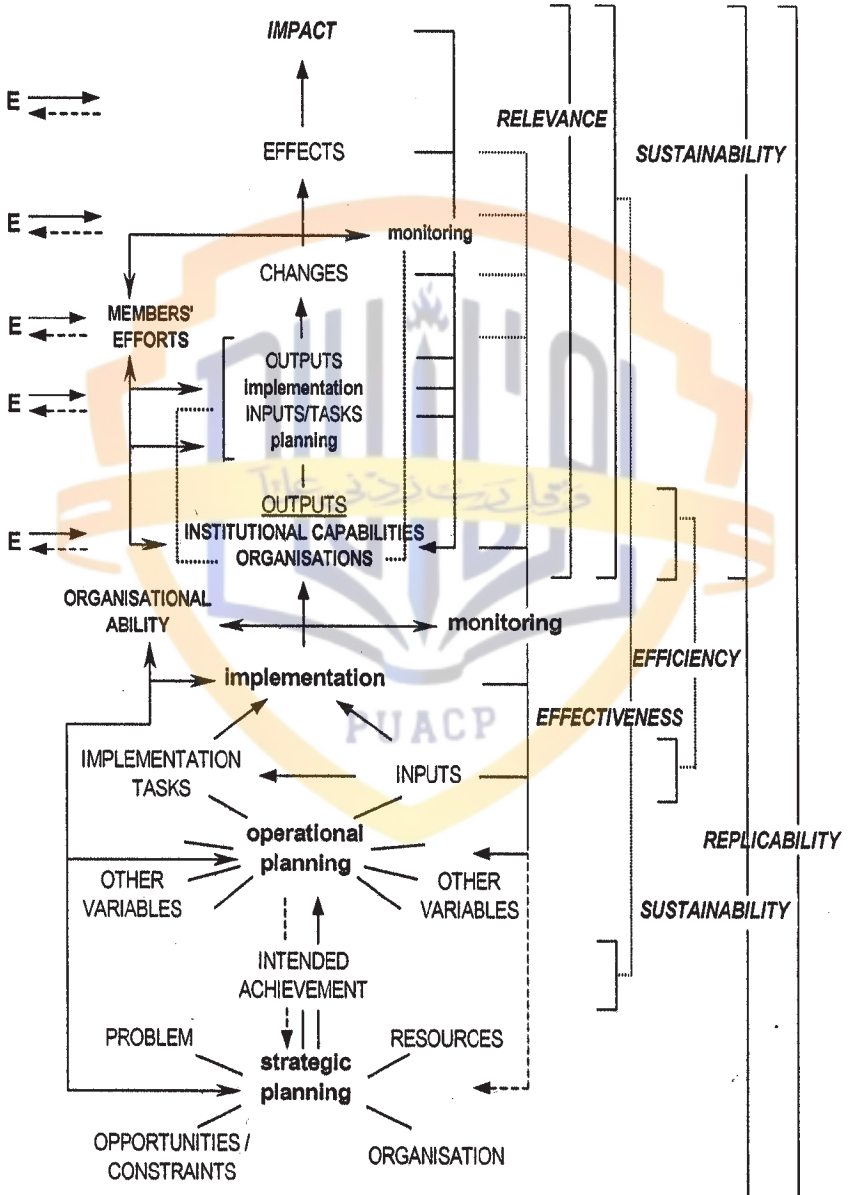
By direct implication, we must also incorporate augmentation of institutional qualities of the above-mentioned kinds in our concept of ‘organisation-building’.

## ELABORATING ORGANISATION-BUILDING

Figure 8.1 shows the general activity cum means–ends structure and connected evaluation categories in programmes of organisation-building for development. In such programmes, an organisation (or a set of organisations) helps create or strengthen other organisations to undertake work for the benefit of certain people, rather than doing such work itself. New organisations may be formed or the capability of existing organisations may be augmented.

Such endeavours are often referred to by development organisations as ‘institution-building’ rather than ‘organisation-building’. This may often be equally appropriate, since, as we have clarified, development organisations must also possess institutional qualities. Whether we should use the term ‘organisation-building’ or ‘institution-building’ may also depend on the focus and scope of the promotional effort—that is, whether the main emphasis is on strengthening relatively

**Figure 8.1**  
**EVALUATION PERSPECTIVE 4**



specific and tangible aspects of organisations, or whether the focus is on wider pursuits (for instance, organisational policy, contextual analysis and/or features of internal organisational culture).

Here, we incorporate in the concept of 'organisation-building' any efforts that build organisations in any sense that help them function and perform in intended ways. This is visualised at the output level of Figure 8.1 by the combined terms of 'organisations' (meaning physical entities with more or less formalised features and specific capacities) and 'institutional capabilities' (carrying wider notions, as clarified above).

The new organisations, or the augmented capability of existing organisations, are, then, most appropriately referred to as the *outputs* of the programme. We are still not at the level of benefits for people. Developmental achievements—*effects* and *impact*—of such organisation-building programmes should then be viewed as the benefits that are generated through the work that the new or strengthened organisations undertake.

For example, in a programme for building community-based organisations of poor people, intended to help improve aspects of the members' life situation, a set of planned outputs may be: 'people's motivation enhanced'; 'people's organisations formed'; and 'skills of the organisations' members improved'. These achievements may, in turn, be viewed as the main conditions for well-functioning people's organisations, which in means–ends terminology may be formulated as 'people's organisations are performing as intended'. This latter achievement may, then, be viewed as an output at a second level, or as an output-linked change (see Chapter 4).<sup>1</sup> For generating effects and impact, the organisations that have been built will conduct *their* planning, implement *their* tasks, and produce *their* outputs. Consequently, for analysing such achievements we must shift our focus from the organisation-building programme (the support programme) to the new or strengthened organisations.

This idea of *dual focus* is visualised in Figure 8.1. The direct affairs of the organisation-building programme are shown as ending at the level of the built or strengthened organisations, while the latter are shown as undertaking their own work.

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<sup>1</sup> In another context (Dale, 2004) I have developed a full means–ends structure of such a programme and formulated this along with indicators and assumptions in an improved logical framework format.

Often, though, this may be a somewhat simplified notion. The organisation in charge of the support programme may also help the built organisations in their planning and implementation, at least over some period. Moreover, it will want to know that these organisations do useful work. This concern may be instituted as part of the monitoring system of the support organisation, as also indicated in the figure.

Still, for effective capacity-building, the basic distinction that we have made between the concerns of the support programme and those of the built organisations will generally apply. In order to avoid confusion of roles, it is essential that those in charge of the support programme recognise and abide by this principle of clear separation of purpose and responsibilities.

Another crucial feature is close interrelations between strategic planning, operational planning, implementation and monitoring, and between these work tasks and organisational ability. For the support programme, this is shown by two-way links between the two main categories of planning, the feedback link from monitoring to both of them, and connections between work tasks and organisational ability. For the member organisations (where we have simplified somewhat), it is shown by the interrelations between members' efforts, work tasks and organisational ability. This signifies the *generative (process) nature* of virtually any effective capacity-building programme. Organisational and institutional abilities are almost invariably built gradually through some interplay between support from outside and learning from experience. This learning process involves both the supporting and the supported organisations. Consequently, the former may initially, in most instances, formulate only indicative support measures and will normally need to modify the support over the programme period—considering effectiveness at any point in time and long-term sustainability of the promoted organisations and the work that they do. Commonly, this also involves gradual expansion and then gradual reduction of the support.

## SPECIFIC CONCERNS OF EVALUATION

In Figure 8.1, we have also incorporated our familiar evaluation categories and linked them with the components of the means–ends structure, the way we have done in the preceding chapters.

While the general perspective is similar, the above-stated unique characteristics and modes of work of organisation-building programmes will constitute specific challenges for, and must be well recognised by, evaluators of such programmes. Indeed, this may make evaluations of organisation—and institution-building programmes quite different exercises from evaluations of many other kinds of schemes, particularly engineering projects and other projects of a relatively technical nature. Normally, one will need to put major emphasis on stakeholder constellations and roles (including the crucial distinction we have made between the support facility and the institutions to be built); systems and processes of planning, implementation and monitoring; and complex and fluid interactions between bodies of the programme and their environment. Moreover, generation of benefits must be analysed in a long-term perspective, emphasising gradual changes and their interplay with features of attitude, capacity and organisational performance.<sup>2</sup>

We might have elaborated Figure 8.1 further, by specifying a separate set of evaluation categories pertaining to the work of the built/strengthened organisations. Actually, when the focus in evaluation is on programmes or projects of these organisations (rather than activities of the organisation-building programme), it is essential that this be done. And, when the focus is on the promoted organisations and what they do more generally (that is, beyond specific schemes that they undertake), an appropriate perspective has already been presented in the previous chapter (Figure 7.2).

Box 8.1 elaborates further important issues of the design of community organisation-building programmes, of direct importance for evaluators.

We see that evaluations may supplement monitoring as a tool for providing feedback to the fairly continuous or recurrent planning processes that are required—with direct implications for implementation, of course. Moreover, in such evaluations, systems, processes and choices of planning will in themselves be major evaluation concerns, in relation to any of the main analytical categories of evaluation that we have clarified. Thus, intended achievements—constituting one kind of planning choices at any given time—will directly feed into recurrent effectiveness analysis, and more indirectly into the

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<sup>2</sup> Evaluation of such a programme is documented in Dale, 2002a.



### Box 8.1

#### BUILDING LOCAL COMMUNITY ORGANISATIONS OF POOR PEOPLE

The scenario is a development organisation that undertakes a programme of building organisations of poor people in local communities, intending to plan and implement development work on behalf of and for their members. The promoting organisation may be governmental or non-governmental, and we assume that the community organisations are intended to be long-lasting and after some time independent of the promoting organisation.

The *outputs* of the programme will then be these local bodies with their organisational abilities and other institutional qualities, while the programme's *effects* and *impact* will be the benefits that are generated by the local organisations for their members (being the intended beneficiaries of the programme). Consequently, a clear distinction needs to be made between the concerns of the institution building endeavour and those of the local organisations.

In *strategic planning*—which will be an ongoing thrust during the programme period—the main focus of the programme authorities has to be on *organisation analysis*, at two levels:

Community-level:

- the desired features of the local organisations (form/structure, rules, other aspects of culture, administrative systems, technology, member incentives and modes of operation);
- the kinds of people who may become members of the organisations;
- the societal context of the organisations (generally and specifically in each community), involving analysis of opportunities, constraints and threats.

Programme-level:

- the type, magnitude and modalities of support by the promoting organisation, considering needs in the communities, people's abilities, and opportunities, constraints and threats.

A core question is how uniform the programme authorities want the local organisations to be: will they all work according to a common set of objectives and be exactly like in other main respects, or can they vary to larger or lesser extents? The answer to this question will determine or influence important modalities of support, such as

(Box 8.1 contd.)



(Box 8.1 contd.)

the degree of standardisation of the support, the amount and form of initiatives that are expected from the communities, and, consequently, the mode of communication between the support organisation and the communities.

The programme-level analysis will normally involve prioritisation of programme communities and, possibly, specific measures in various communities, in order to meet needs, exploit opportunities, and reduce risks as much as possible. Like other aspects of strategy, prioritisation ought to be a relatively current (or recurrent) activity.

The support organisation *needs to conduct operational planning for its support*, the degree and modalities of which will depend on the strategy to be pursued.

Whether it will plan anything operationally on behalf of *the supported organisations* will largely depend on the extent to which it wants to guide their work.

In order to provide feedback to effective and efficient process planning, a complementary and well-functioning monitoring system is essential. This may be supported by evaluations (reviews) of a primarily formative kind. In addition, of course, one or more summative evaluations may be done in the aftermath of the programme. To be effective, any formative evaluation should deal comprehensively with aspects of planning and implementation, and be designed so that it promotes systematic learning on the part of all stakeholders.

analysis of relevance, impact and sustainability, while various aspects of planning may constitute important explanatory factors for findings on any evaluation category.

## Chapter 9

# EVALUATING SOCIETAL CHANGE AND IMPACT

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### HIGHLIGHTING COMPLEXITY AND UNCERTAINTY

The main challenge in most evaluations of development schemes is to trace and specify changes in people's living situation—within the scope of relevance of the assessed scheme—along with the causes of these changes. This involves finding out to what extent changes have been:

- created directly by the evaluated programme or project;
- created more indirectly by it; or
- created or influenced by factors outside the programme or project.

Explanation of changes involves, of course, analysis of cause–effect structures and alterations in such structures over time. The difficulty of this task will be influenced by many factors. Normally, a major one is the *level in the means–ends structure* of the studied scheme that is in focus in the analysis. Thus, the challenge of substantiating and explaining changes tends to be particularly big at the level of *impact*.

Impact evaluation (which may also involve analysis of the sustainability of impacts) tends to be the more emphasised the more *normative* the scheme is, that is, the more it focuses on fundamental aspects of people's living situation.<sup>1</sup> We may then also refer to the development thrust as a 'deep' intervention. Moreover, a highly normative programme will often have a relatively broad scope, which

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<sup>1</sup> See Chapter 2 for a brief further clarification of 'normative' versus 'functional', and Dale, 2002b; 2004 for more comprehensive analyses.

may be captured by the word *comprehensive*. That is because substantial changes in people's living conditions may require that one addresses several, usually more or less interrelated, problems.

An example of a highly normative and comprehensive scheme may be a programme that aims at changing power structures in local communities by building institutions of deprived people. Analysing the influence of such a thrust on the living conditions of the intended beneficiary groups may be a highly complex and time-consuming endeavour. In the present context, we may compare this with a project to promote a particular cash crop through distribution of seedlings and cultivation advice. The intended effect of that project will normally be increased income for farmers from the promoted crop. That achievement (which may be expressed in effectiveness terms) may be easier to document and explain, and assessments of benefits of the project may stop there.<sup>2</sup>

Another dimension that may further increase the difficulty of documenting changes and linking them to the studied development scheme is the *duration* of the scheme. That is, interventions that create outputs over a long period are generally more difficult to evaluate than interventions that produce them once or over a short period only. And frequently, duration may also be positively related with the variety of outputs—and thereby with the above-mentioned dimension of comprehensiveness of the scheme.

Moreover, the above-mentioned features of depth, breath and duration may be related with the degree of *flexibility* of interventions: great depth and breadth and long duration may call for substantial flexibility, because these factors tend to cause high uncertainty of outcomes. Consequently, schemes with such features may not only have to be adjusted but even planned incrementally in the course of their implementation, that is, in a process mode. We have earlier discussed relations between modes of planning and the role of evaluations (formative versus summative). Generally, the total evaluation challenge (whether through a number of basically formative

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<sup>2</sup> Should one still want to analyse the wider and longer-term impact of the farming households' use of any additional income, the challenge of this may vary depending on numerous factors such as: how much the household income has increased due to the project; other employment opportunities; changes in other sources of income and in the amounts earned from them; and the extent to which any such other changes may also be related to the project inducements.

evaluations or one or more summative evaluations) will be greater for schemes that undergo changes than for rigid schemes.

Clearly, we are here stressing features that together tend to distinguish programmes from projects. We may then also conclude that evaluations—of impact and often also of other dimensions—tend to be more challenging for the former than for the latter.

## ANALYTICAL SCOPE: SOCIETAL PROCESSES

The complex and often highly uncertain nature of impacts may justify a methodological distinction between, on the one hand, much genuine impact evaluation and, on the other, evaluation of other aspects of a development scheme. Moreover, this alternative approach may be particularly needed for analysing the benefits of schemes with characteristics that have been emphasised above—that is, highly normative, broad-focusing and/or long-lasting programmes, being normally also planned in more or less of a process mode.

It may be argued, as in Box 9.1, that we may most fruitfully analyse benefits of complex, relatively indirect and often uncertain nature from the location of the intended beneficiaries rather than from the standpoint of the studied programme. In other words, the primary focus may have to be on the respective groups of people in their societal context. This may be the only approach for generating the information that one needs to really understand the role and contribution of the development intervention in the context of complex patterns of societal interaction and change. It means that evaluators do not *methodologically* distinguish between programme-internal and -external factors of change; they may incorporate into their analytical framework, and emphasise, any factors of importance for the life situation of the respective people, whether internal or external to the programme.

Although most obviously desirable for programmes (and certain programmes more than others), the society-focused perspective may also be the most appropriate one for evaluating benefits of many projects. Even such more clearly bounded and specific interventions may produce outputs the impact of which gets moulded through complex processes of change, involving a range of factors.

This perspective is visualised in Figure 9.1.

Documentation of impact will here be generated from an analysis of changes in relevant aspects of the living situation of the intended

### Box 9.1

#### A NEW VIEW OF FINANCE PROGRAMME EVALUATION

In a contribution on evaluation in Otero and Rhyne, 1994, Elisabeth Rhyne argues as follows:

The conventional approach of finance programmes has been to funnel credit to particular groups for specific production purposes, through financial institutions that have been created to that end or through specific arrangements with existing banks. Programmes with this approach:

- have considered lack of credit to be a binding constraint, the removal of which would directly promote development;
- have sought to compensate for failures of the mainstream financial system by providing an alternative service;
- have been financed from donor or government funds rather than from funds generated within the domestic financial system itself.

An alternative view is now gaining ground. Core features of this view are that:

- it is better to build the capacity of general financial institutions for a development promoting portfolio of services, in order to obtain a wider and more sustainable impact;
- sustainable financial services must be based on domestic savings, generated by the same institutions;
- the causal links between individuals' receipt of credit and production improvements are indirect, as credit is but one among several factors influencing complex processes of decision-making regarding production.

Based on this alternative perspective, Rhyne proposes a framework for evaluating finance programmes encompassing two main dimensions: institutional viability and client-service relations.

Variables of institutional viability are: *financial self-sufficiency* of the services rendered, *financial condition* of the institution (in terms of profitability, portfolio quality, liquidity, and capital adequacy), and *institutional strength and context*. In our analytical framework, these together express aspects of *efficiency*, *effectiveness* and *sustainability*, and they must be analysed from an examination of the structures, systems and processes of the particular financial institution.

(Box 9.1 contd.)

The main variables of client-service relations are: *the quality of the services and how the services fit with the clients' financial management process; and the extent to which they serve continuous needs of the clients.* These denote, in our framework, aspects of *relevance, effectiveness and impact.*

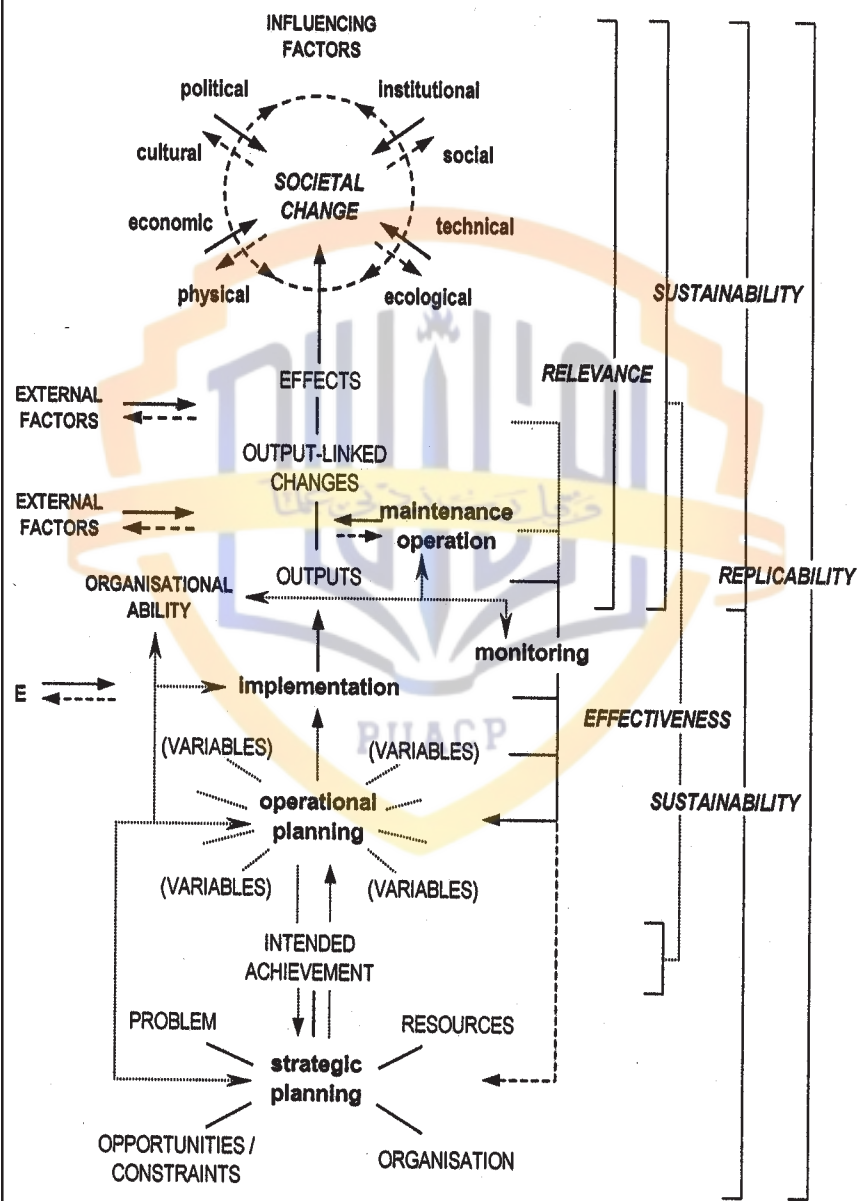
**These last-mentioned factors need to be analysed not from the point of view of the finance institution or its particular programme, but from the standpoint of the person or enterprise receiving the credit, in his/her/its societal context.** In studying the function of the credit, one needs to recognise that:

- credit is but one among many factors affecting production decisions;
- credit may be used for many purposes, including consumption;
- clients normally seek financial services recurrently, and such services may be provided by different agents; and that client decisions involve considerations of service availability in interplay with other opportunities and constraints, internal or external to the respective household or enterprise.

beneficiaries (and sometimes others who may be or have been influenced by the programme or project under examination) along with factors that cause or contribute to these changes. Such analysis will normally be complex, in the sense of having to incorporate numerous variables and many directions and patterns of change. Any substantiated impact of the evaluated programme or project may then be further connected to and explained by features of the scheme—shown by the link between ‘societal change’ and the design, activity and means–ends categories of the development intervention.

For instance, in our case of financial support (Box 9.1), this would mean assessing numerous variables that may influence people’s economic adaptation, among which the financial services under investigation may be more or less important, and then substantiating and explaining the role of the provided services. For a preventive health programme, it may mean finding out what factors influence people’s health, the way in which they do so, whether and how the factors have changed or are changing, to what extent they are interdependent, etc., and from that trying to elicit the role and influence of measures of the programme.

**Figure 9.1**  
**EVALUATION PERSPECTIVE 5**





Positive impact of a development scheme will always be influenced by the scheme's *relevance* for the intended beneficiaries and will normally be connected to the scheme's *effectiveness*. Moreover, the impact may substantially influence and be influenced by aspects of *sustainability* of the programme or project. Thus, besides clarifying impact, society-focused evaluations may provide information of high importance for such other programme features as well, which evaluators may also address.

## ASSESSING EMPOWERMENT

An example of development schemes of particular significance in the present context are programmes with *empowerment* aims. To the extent that they are successful, such programmes may trigger very complex processes of change among the respective groups or in the respective communities, which may only be properly described and understood through a community-focused analysis.

'Empowerment' basically means a process through which people acquire more influence over factors that shape their lives. The concept tends to be primarily applied to disadvantaged groups of people, and is usually linked to a vision of more equal living conditions in society (Dale, 2000). Empowerment may primarily be the aim of institution-building programmes of various kinds. We addressed specific perspectives and concerns in the planning and evaluation of such programmes in the previous chapter. Our additional point here is that evaluators of the impact of such programmes, more than perhaps any other kinds of programmes, need to start their exploration from the standpoint of the intended beneficiaries as already clarified.<sup>3</sup>

A more specific example may be evaluation of programmes that aim at influencing *gender relations*, or programmes that may be expected to have influenced or to be influencing gender relations more indirectly.

A framework worked out by Mishra and Dale (1996) for gender analysis in tribal communities in India may be illustrative and helpful in many assessments of gender issues.

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<sup>3</sup> In Chapter 2, we addressed a different aspect of empowerment in the context of evaluation—namely, that evaluations can be empowering processes for intended beneficiaries (or primarily such people) who may undertake or participate in them. We referred to this as 'empowerment evaluation'.

The authors specify a set of variables and elements at four levels, of particular importance in these communities, for analysis by gender. The variables at the two highest levels are:

- Access to resources
  - Economic resources (different categories of land)
  - Political resources (political representation)
  - Cultural resources (formal and indigenous knowledge; role in rituals)
- Ownership of resources
  - Land (of different categories)
  - Livestock
  - House
- Control over resources
  - Land (of different categories)
  - Livestock
  - House (by decisions about building and repair)
  - Income (that is, its use)
- Access to alternative opportunities
  - Outside support (from NGOs and the Government)
  - Outside wage employment (also through migration)
  - Product markets
- Social decision-making power
  - Regarding health care
  - In marriage (choice of partner; sexual freedom/bondedness; opportunity for divorce).

Obviously, any study of the above variables may only be done from within the local communities themselves. For explaining situation and changes, any factors of assumed importance may in principle be analysed and interrelations between such factors will have to be explored. If such a study is done in the context of programme evaluation—that is, evaluation of the impact of a development programme on gender relations in the respective communities—one must then proceed by specifying and elaborating programme factors that may have contributed to observed changes in such relations, in various ways and to varying extents. This will then be followed by further analysis of the appropriateness of various features of the programme and, in the case of formative evaluation, any ideas and proposals for changes of approach.

Studies of the kind addressed in this chapter are time-consuming, since information and understanding are generated incrementally through intensive exploration. To make the approach feasible, one may have to limit such society-focused analysis to relatively few study units (households, organisations, etc.), and possibly broaden the coverage of the evaluation through the use of quicker methods of study which address more directly programme- or project-related matters. Of course, the various methods and their function in the total evaluation effort should then be made to match each other as well as is possible. Also, due to their demand on time and expertise, comprehensive studies of this nature may often have to be one-time exercises only.

However, in a simplified form, society-based studies concentrated on selected units (such as a few households) may be done recurrently. For flexible and dynamic programmes there are, in fact, strong arguments for designing such evaluations to become an important management tool, continuing through the lifetime of the programme (see also Chapter 2). If such studies are conscientiously planned and the information is well managed, each exercise can be done with much less effort than a one-time evaluation. This is because information and insight accumulate gradually with the decision-makers and are refined over time, and also because the intended beneficiaries may be more aware and actively involved in providing information and views. If fully incorporated into the management system of a programme, this may even be referred to as a system of *impact monitoring*.

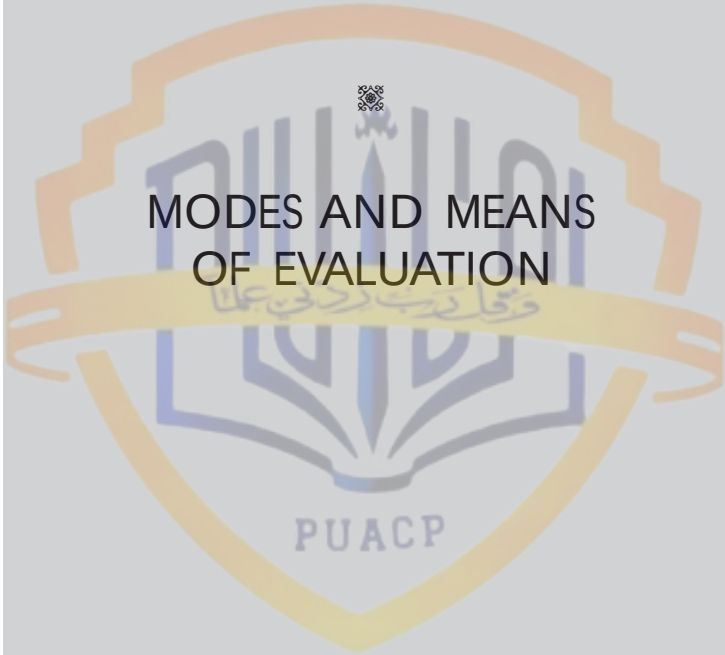
For instance, recent writers on micro-finance programmes have argued for such systems in these development schemes. Thus, Johnson and Rogaly (1997) write that because 'the usefulness of financial services varies over time as well as between different groups of people', it is 'necessary to engage in continuous dialogue with a representative cross-section of scheme members...' (ibid.: 79). Through such current discourse, one may be able to describe and understand 'the dynamics that the intervention...can catalyse' (ibid.: 78).



## PART THREE



# MODES AND MEANS OF EVALUATION





## Chapter 10

# SCHEDULING OF EVALUATIONS AND EVALUATION TASKS

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### THE TIME DIMENSION IN EVALUATION

Evaluation of development programmes and projects is basically about describing, judging and explaining what has been done, how activities have been performed, what has been achieved, and, commonly, what future prospects or options may exist.

This means that one must seek to link *past* situations (in terms of status, events, processes and/or activities) to a *present* situation. That is, one must describe and substantiate any differences between the situations and explore how and why such differences have been created—or the reasons for no or only small changes, if that is the case. This involves exploration of programme- or project-internal strengths and weaknesses and environmental opportunities and constraints, as well as examination of how these have been or are being addressed (exploited, removed or avoided)—commonly at various stages or points in time. Additionally, if one is looking into the *future*, one must ask whether changed situations are likely to persist or changes are likely to continue; explore factors that are likely to influence sustenance or augmentation, positively and negatively; and, usually, recommend measures to help ensure sustainability. And, to the extent replicability is an evaluation concern, one must assess scenarios of possible replication in some future context.

‘Past’, ‘present’ and ‘future’ are relative concepts, related to the timing of evaluations or parts of them. For instance, the last period of a project will be ‘future’ in the context of a mid-term evaluation, while it will be ‘past’ from the point of view of a post-project evaluation. Of course, this is closely connected to what may be assessed and how



information about it may be generated. Moreover, time distances are important, both between situations that are examined and between such situations and the time at which the evaluation is undertaken. Normally, such time distances have bearings on the degree to which and the ways in which processes may be examined—having, in turn, implications for methods of study that may be applied.

Such considerations of time and timing are, therefore, a crucial part of the design of evaluations. In order to shed some more light on the issue, we shall next present some scenarios of evaluation in a time perspective.

## A RANGE OF OPTIONS

Figure 10.1 outlines six scenarios of how one may proceed to trace, describe, judge and explain performance and changes, in terms of timing and steps of analysis. The latter may be more or less discrete or continuous. As a common reference frame, we use the already clarified concepts of summative versus formative evaluation and programme versus project. Implicitly, this also incorporates the related dimension of blueprint versus process. Notions of process are in the figure (Scenarios Five and Six) expressed as ‘phased’ and ‘open-ended’. Steps of analysis are expressed by numbers (1, 2, 3, etc.).

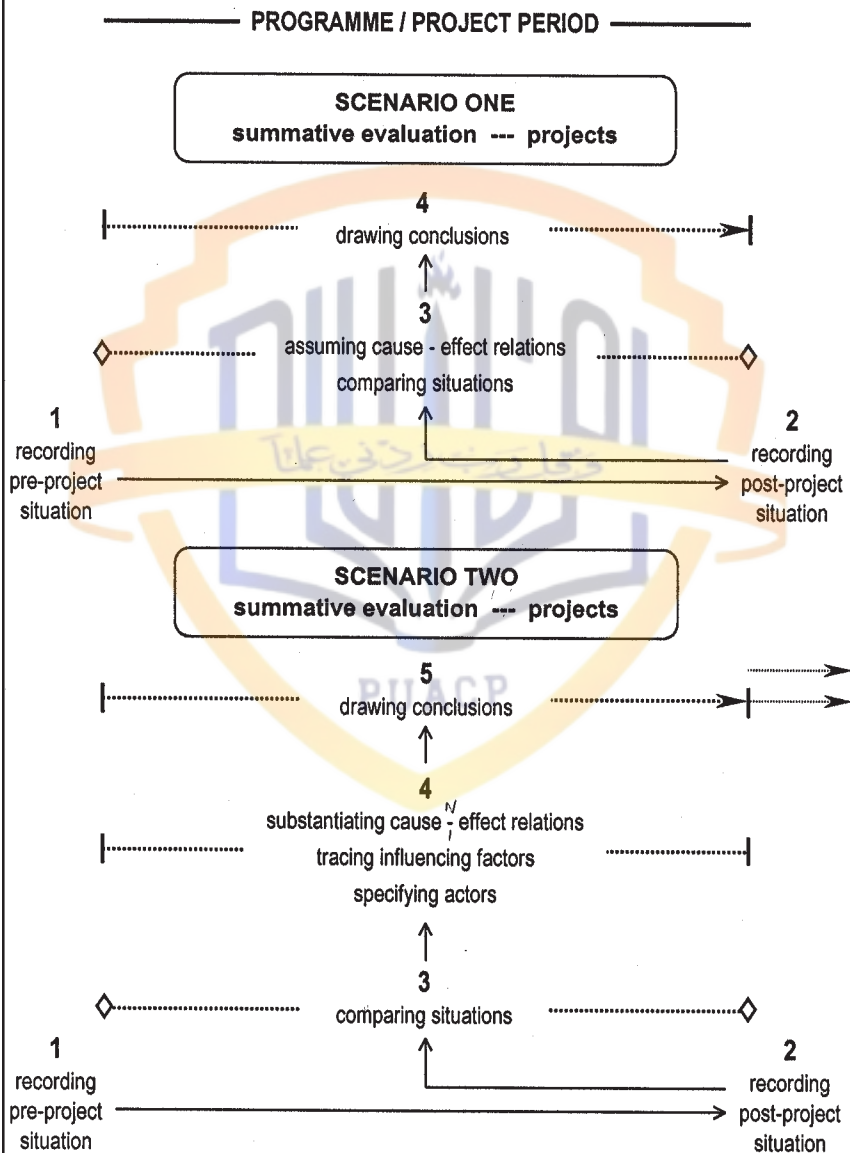
To go by the number of presented options, there seems to be an over-emphasis on summative and project. However, this merely reflects a practical consideration: since summative project evaluations are the easiest to illustrate, we start with varieties of such evaluations, by which we cover aspects that may be relevant to and incorporated in other scenarios as well.

Scenario One is conceptually the simplest one. It shows studies among the intended beneficiaries at two points in time: before the project was started and after it has been completed. This is done to directly compare the ‘before situation’ with the ‘after situation’, pertaining to features that are relevant for the evaluated programme or project. The two exercises are commonly referred to as ‘baseline’ and ‘follow-up’ studies respectively.

This approach has been used mainly for studying effectiveness and impact of clearly delimited and firmly planned development interventions—that is, conventional projects. Most of the information collected in this way will be quantitative (expressed by numbers), but some qualitative information may also be collected and then

**Figure 10.1**

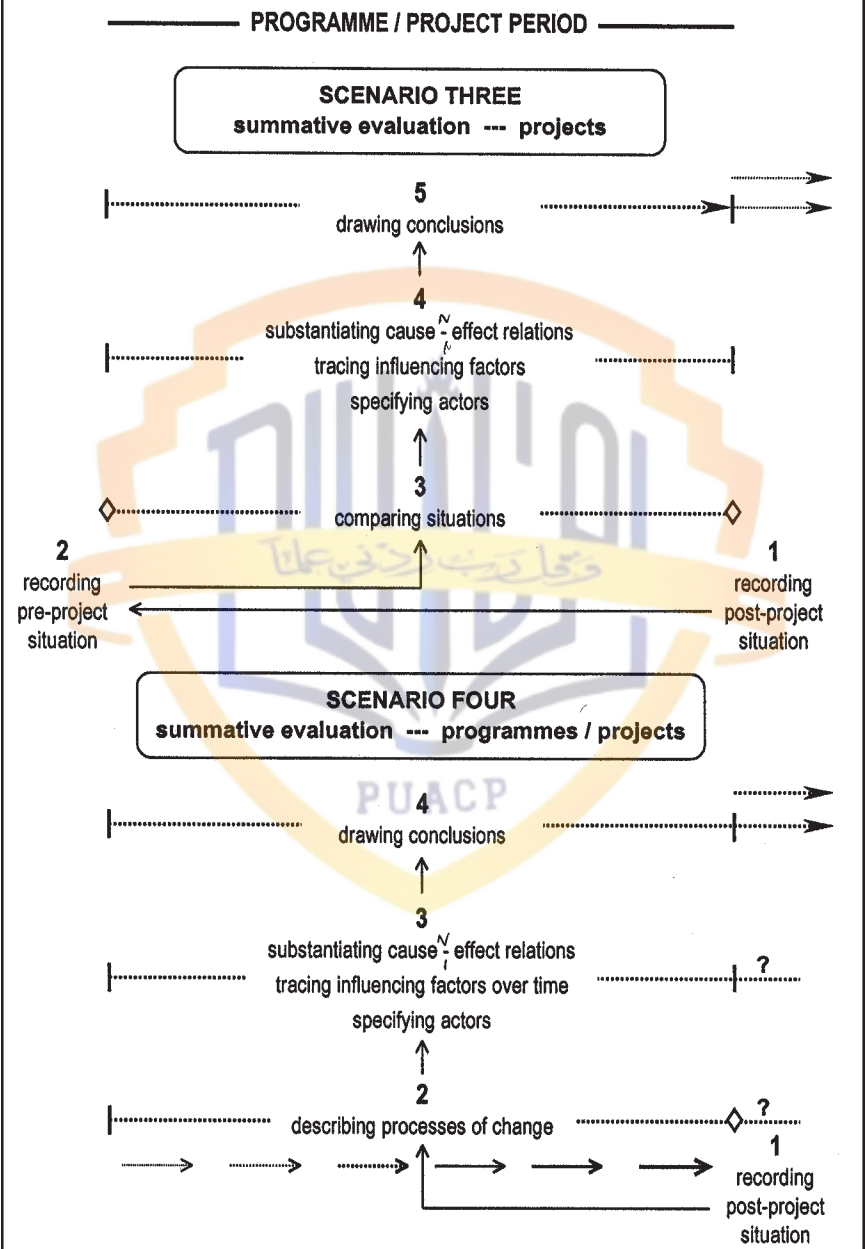
# STEPS, TIMING AND TIME HORIZONS IN EVALUATION: TYPICAL SCENARIOS



(Figure 10.1 contd.)

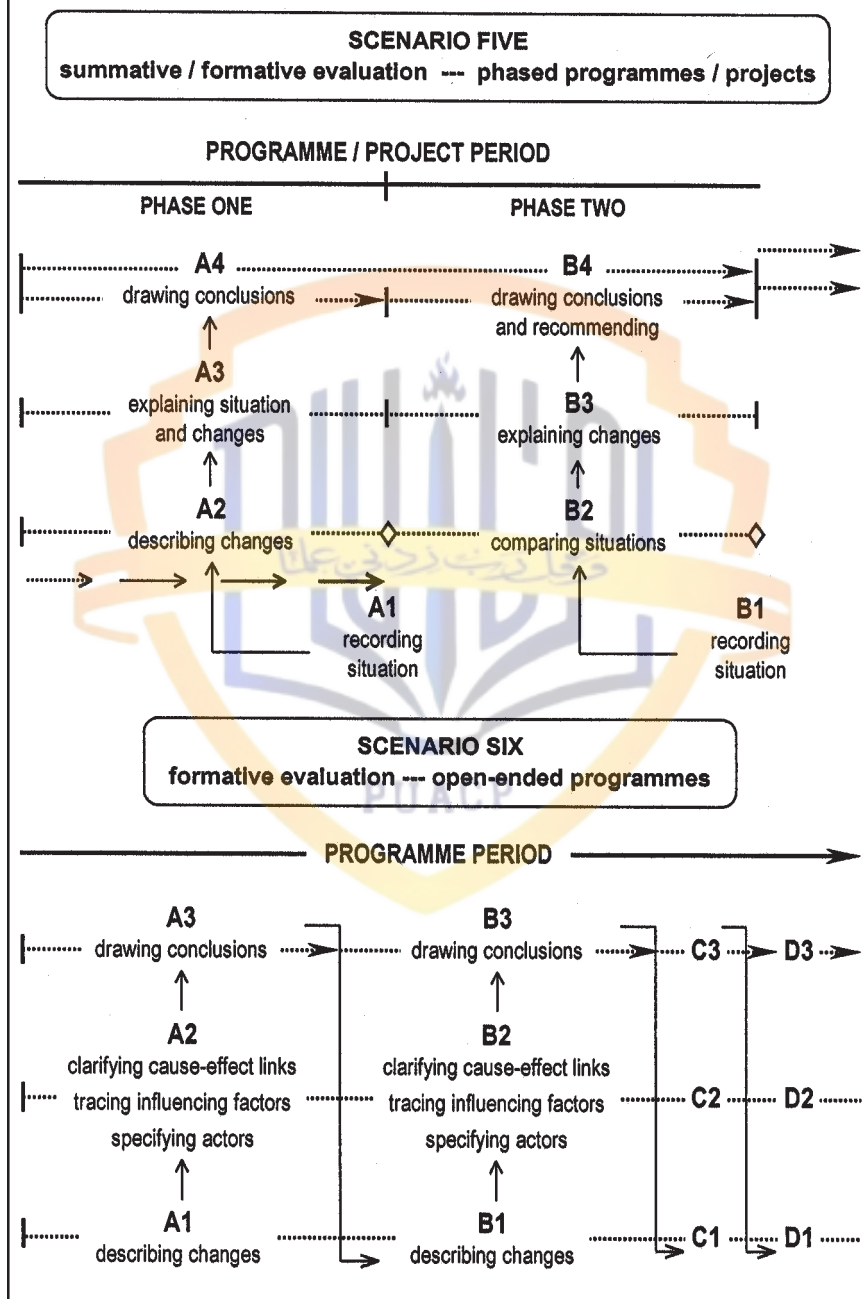
(Figure 10.1 contd.)

Figure 10.1 (cont.)



(Figure 10.1 contd.)

(Figure 10.1 contd.)

**Figure 10.1 (contd.)**

standardised through further manipulation—by which it also becomes much simplified.<sup>1</sup>

In this scenario, conclusions about causes of observed changes are based on assumptions rather than verification in the field. That is, one concludes at least mainly from what one thinks is logical or reasonable, not from an analysis of actual processes of change and factors that cause these processes. Commonly, one may then tend to quickly conclude that the documented changes have been wholly or mainly caused by the programme or project that is evaluated. In some cases, this may be highly likely or even obvious; in other cases, such judgements may be little credible.

Besides this deficiency, the approach cannot be used to address matters of efficiency, and it may not generate sufficient understanding to make sound judgements about relevance, sustainability or replicability.

Still, this approach is normally demanding on resources: substantial and comparable baseline and follow-up studies take a long time to complete, involving both comprehensive fieldwork and much additional data analysis.

Shortcomings of this kind are sought to be reduced in Scenario Two. Here, as well, baseline information is recorded prior to the start-up of the project and corresponding information is collected after its completion. Unlike in Scenario One, the evaluator then proceeds by exploring processes and connected actors and influencing factors in the course of the project period. Both processes of work and processes of change may be analysed.

To the extent mechanisms of change may be clarified and well understood, the approach expressed by this scenario may also generate information for judging future courses of events and options, that is, for assessing aspects of sustainability and, if relevant, replicability. This is in the figure illustrated by the arrows beyond the time of termination of the project (the lower arrow signifying future prospects of the evaluated scheme and the upper arrow future prospects in other contexts).

How deeply one may explore processes and relations will depend on some combination of project-internal factors (such as the scheme's complexity and duration), numerous factors in the project's environ-

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<sup>1</sup> For more on this and related aspects of methodology, see the following section of this chapter and the next two chapters.

ment, and features of the evaluation (such as the time at the evaluator's disposal and the evaluator's attitude and competence). Usually, in evaluations that start with collection of 'before' and 'after' data and proceed with primarily quantitative analysis of these data, process analysis will be given low priority and relatively little attention. In most cases, therefore, the additional activities of Scenario Two may not constitute more than a modest adjustment to the tasks of Scenario One. They may be inadequate for generating a good understanding of processes and their causes, and of consequences for the assessment of many matters that ought to be emphasised.

A further drawback of the approach in Scenario Two is that it is even more time-consuming than the previous one.

In Scenario Three, and in the following scenarios, no baseline data are collected before the start-up of the project. In fact, systematic collection of baseline data has been relatively rare in evaluations, notwithstanding a widely held view that this ought to be done. Presumably, the main reasons for this situation are the need for rigorous planning of studies in advance of the development intervention and the relatively large resources and the long time required for baseline and follow-up studies.<sup>2</sup>

In Scenario Three, instead, the evaluator records the situation at the time of evaluation and simultaneously tries to acquire corresponding information from before the initiation of the programme or project. Beyond this modification, Scenario Three is similar to the previous one.

In Scenario Four there is no intention of acquiring systematic comprehensive information about the 'before' situation. Instead, the evaluator starts with recording the present situation and then explores changes backward in time, as far as is feasible or until sufficient information about changes and their causes is judged to have been obtained. Selective pieces of information may also be elicited about the pre-programme or -project situation, to the extent these may help clarify the magnitude and direction of changes. For instance, one may try to obtain some comparable quantitative data at intervals of a year—for instance, last year, the year before that, and in addition immediately before the start-up of the evaluated scheme—for the purpose of

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<sup>2</sup> Information that may be acquired in advance of a development scheme in order to justify it and/or help in the planning of it will rarely be sufficient and in a suitable form to be used as baseline data for evaluation.

aiding the analysis of processes. Primarily, however, one will explore changes more qualitatively, commonly with the main emphasis being on the relatively recent past, for which detailed and reliable information may be most readily obtained. Thereby, processes and related factors may be more emphasised and become better clarified.

This approach may be adopted because it may not be possible to obtain sufficient information about the situation before the programme or project was started. But it may also be chosen because the evaluator does not consider it necessary or worth the effort to collect such baseline information. Instead, a concerted exploration of processes and relations of change over some period may be considered to be more significant for documenting and understanding such changes and for tracing and explaining the role of the evaluated programme or project in producing them.

By its emphasis on processes and related factors (internal and external), the approach of Scenario Four may be suitable for analysing all matters that normally may be subjected to evaluation. Thus, in addition to effectiveness and impact (in focus in our previous scenarios), one may better explore aspects of relevance, sustainability and, if relevant, replicability. Analysis of future prospects and courses may be aided by critical extrapolation of courses up to the time of evaluation (illustrated by extended lines with question marks). Moreover, to the extent one also addresses project inputs and work processes, aspects of efficiency may be analysed as well.

Since one starts with the present and well known and explores changes relating to directly experienced situations, the approach may also be well suited to self-evaluation (for instance, assessment by the members of a mutual benefit organisation of the organisation's performance) and other assessments with people's participation.

Scenario Five adds specific perspectives applicable to phased programmes and projects, in which evaluations are undertaken at the end of each phase. Note that, in order to save space, the text of steps 2 and 3 has been somewhat generalised from that used in the previous scenarios.

The figure shows two phases (which may be all or two out of more phases). In such cases of repeated evaluation, baseline and follow-up studies of each phase would be highly unlikely. Even documented findings of one evaluation may not be used consistently as baseline data for the next evaluation. It would be unlikely that each exercise be designed in such a way that sufficient amounts of relevant quantitative



(or quantifiable) data would be generated and processed in a suitable form for it. Instead, findings of one exercise may be used for more selective and normally more indicative comparison. Nevertheless, such less systematic and more qualitative comparison may be the main aim, for evaluations following the first one. This is emphasised in the figure, for the second evaluation. There may, however, be substantial attention to processes also.

Except the last one, such phased studies will have some combination of a summative and a formative purpose, that is, (a) analysing and drawing conclusions about performance and achievements of the evaluated phase, and (b) drawing on experiences from this phase in formulating substantiated recommendations for the following phase.

Scenario Six is one of genuine formative evaluation of programmes. The analysis here is of an iterative kind, through repeated evaluation events, aiming at enhancing learning and providing inputs into the planning and implementation of future programme components and activities.

The presented picture is a much simplified one, emphasising the mentioned iterative nature of evaluation events. In reality, there is a range of options regarding the focus, scope, organisation and execution of formative programme evaluations, largely connected to the overall strategy and modes of planning of the programme into which the evaluations are incorporated. Therefore, a further discussion of such formative evaluations needs to be undertaken in the context of the wider programme approach. We shall not go further into that here. For a brief exploration of this context, the reader is referred back to Chapter 2. Persons who want to delve deeper into the matter are requested to read Dale, 2004 (Chapter 3, in particular).

## LINKING TO METHODS OF GENERATING INFORMATION

In the next two chapters, we shall explore designs and methods of study. Here, we shall just indicate main links between the scenarios that we have addressed and methodology of generating information, to smoothen the transition to the analysis in the following chapters.

As already mentioned, the main body of information collected in studies that systematically compare situations in a population (before and after or, for that matter, before and some time during) will be quantitative (expressed by numbers). The most common method for gathering that information in its 'raw' form—usually referred to as

‘data’—is normally the household survey. This may sometimes be supplemented with interviews with key informants or some kind of measurement. Usually, the comparison is made by entering the data for the pre-situation and the post-situation in tables and calculating differences between the values. A few examples may be comparison of school enrolment rates, incidences of diseases, and income from some line of production. Such simple comparison may be followed by other kinds of statistical analysis, including testing of the statistical significance of calculated differences.

Sometimes, pieces of qualitative information—for instance, people’s judgement about something—may also be collected for the same purpose. To serve this purpose of comparison, this ‘raw’ information must then be transformed into simple information categories, on what we call a nominal or ordinal measurement scale (for instance, ‘better—the same—worse’). In some cases, certain phenomena may be directly judged by the evaluator based on direct observation, and the judgement presented in the same simple categorial form.

As we have already indicated, and shall substantiate better later, information in quantitative form is usually both highly selective and shallow in relation to what is needed for good understanding of the phenomena that are studied. Normally, therefore, we need a lot of qualitative information. This is the main argument for resorting to other designs than those visualised by Scenarios One, Two and Three, even for analysing impact and effectiveness (in focus in these scenarios). To that comes the predominantly qualitative nature of virtually any analysis of other programme and project qualities that we have addressed (relevance, sustainability, replicability, and even efficiency in most cases). Primarily qualitative study designs are therefore needed in most evaluations of development programmes and projects.

Chapter 11 gives a brief overview of main study designs and a critical examination of their strengths and weaknesses. This is followed by a further exploration of more specific methods of information generation and analysis in Chapter 12. In line with the general argument immediately above, the main emphasis is placed on qualitative (or primarily qualitative) methods, and a typology of such methods is presented. Simultaneously, the merit of quantitative data in some instances is recognised, primarily to substantiate certain arguments or specify certain matters in unambiguous terms. Normally, then, any such quantification will be done within the framework of a basically qualitative exploration.

## Chapter 11

# GENERAL STUDY DESIGNS

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### SOURCES OF INFORMATION

One may broadly distinguish between primary and secondary sources of information. The information collected from these two sources is usually referred to as primary information and secondary information respectively.

Usually, most *primary information* is provided orally by people, particularly persons who have been or are involved in the programme or project that is evaluated and persons who are expected to get benefits from it. In self-evaluation, the information is in the form of facts, opinions and judgements expressed by the evaluators themselves. Otherwise, it is facts, opinions and judgements that the evaluator gets from the mentioned persons through direct communication with them, using various techniques of inquiry. Additionally, primary information may be acquired through direct observation or some kind of measurement by the evaluator.

Primary information is usually the most important type of information in evaluations.

*Secondary information* is information that has been generated and analysed to a greater or lesser extent by others. Sources of secondary information may be monitoring forms and reports, any other relevant evaluation reports, other written documents, maps, etc.

Secondary sources may provide important background information for placing the evaluation in context, they may provide specific data that the evaluator may use as a basis for further exploration and analysis, and they may contain information that supplements other pieces of information or helps substantiate arguments.

Therefore, the evaluator should scan any existing information material that may seem relevant and then carefully consider what

information from such material may be useful. Further, he or she must determine what information from these sources can be directly used, what information may be used subject to further checking, what information may be used with supplementary information, and what information may be too unreliable to be used at all, even if relevant.

Occasionally, evaluations may be done primarily, or even exclusively, using secondary information.

## QUALITATIVE AND QUANTITATIVE APPROACHES

A variety of methods exist for studying structures of and changes in societies. The same range of methods is available for evaluations as for other kinds of analysis of societal entities and processes. Of course, the applicability of and emphasis on various methods will differ with the purpose at hand.

In development science, as in many other professions, it has become common to broadly distinguish between *qualitative* and *quantitative* modes of searching, processing and presenting information. In the former, words and sentences are the only or the main analytical tool; in the latter, statements in numerical form are most important.

The mentioned categories of generating and managing information—searching, processing and presenting—are normally closely related, in that the approach that is applied in one of them has strong bearings on the approach in the others.

Following most conventional science, studies in the development field have commonly been done through a basically predetermined design with a clearly step-wise approach, in which data collection is succeeded by data processing and then presentation of the findings. This is a hallmark of quantitative analysis, particularly when statistical testing is involved. Reliable statistical associations may only be produced from relatively large numbers of directly comparable data of an unambiguous and specific nature. Such data, in turn, may only be generated through a pre-determined design, and needs to be analysed through specifically scheduled tasks.

Alternatively, one may apply more generative approaches, with greater flexibility in searching and analysing information. The perceived need for information and the gathering and processing of that information may then be interrelated and evolving, to a larger or lesser extent, through processes of cumulative learning during the study process. This disqualifies an overall quantitative design with

statistical analysis as the main tool. More qualitative modes of analysis will then be required—which may, nevertheless, also allow collection and treatment of specific pieces of quantitative information.

We have earlier (mainly in Chapter 2) clarified similar differences of approach in the context of programme and project planning and implementation, under the headings of ‘blueprint’ and ‘process’ planning respectively. We have also clarified that these differences in planning and implementation are directly linked to modes of monitoring and any evaluation that may be done, and we used the terms ‘summative’ and ‘formative’ to express corresponding perspectives on evaluation.

Moreover, directly corresponding perspectives may be applied for individual evaluation events also. That is, whether formative or summative, evaluations may be designed in more or less of a blueprint or process mode, with implications for the choice of study methods. In reality, the mentioned preference for basically quantitative, and therewith also blueprint, design in much academically founded development research (also of development schemes) has not been much reflected in studies of a more specific kind that have gone under the name of ‘evaluation’. Usually, the closest one has come, here, to such an approach has been in exercises aiming at comparison between ‘before’ and ‘after’ (see the previous chapter). Otherwise, much more flexible and qualitative (and, we might add, more pragmatic) approaches have tended to prevail. This may have been the case because one has not had the required time and resources at one’s disposal to pursue studies in accordance with basic requirements of a quantitative design. Simultaneously, we shall substantiate, there are more fundamental reasons for the choice of basically qualitative approaches in most evaluations of development programmes and projects.

The primary general features of qualitative and quantitative approaches to information generation and management are summed up in Table 11.1. This conceptual framework helps guide the design and pursuit of any systematic evaluation of any programme or project in any societal context.

Differences of approach outlined in the table may sometimes be derived from differences of a more *ideological* nature, that is, from ideas about how the world around us is structured and how human beings, groups and organisations behave, and also how we may best learn about societal structures and social behaviour and change. With few general words, a quantitative analyst tends to perceive of the

**Table 11.1**

**QUALITATIVE AND QUANTITATIVE APPROACHES TO INFORMATION GENERATION AND MANAGEMENT**

| <u>QUALITATIVE</u>                                                                                       | <u>QUANTITATIVE</u>                                                      |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Sampling of study units through personal judgement                                                       | Sampling of study units through pre-determined criteria and techniques   |
| Flexible overall research design                                                                         | Pre-determined and unchangeable research design                          |
| Enquiry through more than one method                                                                     | Enquiry through one method only                                          |
| Facilitates incorporation of a broad range of research variables and allows high complexity of variables | Reduces the field of investigation to what is statistically controllable |
| Allows direct exploration of processes of change                                                         | Confinement to the contemporary or to different points in time           |
| Information recorded in flexible formats                                                                 | Information recorded in fixed form in pre-determined categories          |
| Substantiating relations through reasoning and interpretation                                            | Verifying relations through statistical testing                          |
| Participation in analysis by non-professionals possible                                                  | Analysis by professionals only                                           |
| Source: Dale, 2004                                                                                       |                                                                          |

objects of study as detached from and independent of the researcher, making it possible to analyse them objectively (value-free), whereas a qualitative analyst thinks that the reality is bound to be viewed differently by different analysts and that, consequently, the outcome of the analysis will be coloured by the analyst’s attitudes and experiences.<sup>1</sup>

<sup>1</sup> For elaboration, see textbooks on research design and methodology. A few examples of books with a relatively practical orientation are Creswell, 1994; Mikkelsen, 1995; and Pratt and Loizos, 1992.



Moreover, study designs may be rooted in ideas in science about generalisation of findings, commonly presented as notions of *theory building*.

Linking such basic conceptions and actual study designs, Creswell (1994) broadly describes a *quantitative methodology* in social science research as follows:

[One] use[s] a deductive form of logic wherein theories and hypotheses are tested in a cause and effect order. Concepts, variables, and hypotheses are chosen before the study begins and remain fixed throughout the study.... One does not venture beyond these predetermined hypotheses (the research is context free). The intent of the study is to develop generalizations that contribute to the theory and that enable one to better predict, explain, and understand some phenomenon. These generalizations are enhanced if the information and instruments used are valid and reliable (ibid.: 7).

The same author summarises main features of a *qualitative methodology* with the following words:

In a qualitative methodology inductive logic prevails. Categories emerge from informants, rather than are identified *a priori* by the researcher. This emergence provides rich 'context-bound' information leading to patterns or theories that help explain a phenomenon. The question about the accuracy of the information may not surface in a study, or, if it does, the researcher talks about steps for verifying the information with informants or 'triangulating'<sup>2</sup> among different sources of information...(ibid.: 7).

The notions of hypothesis testing and theory building in a strict scientific sense are hardly ever applicable in evaluations of interventions for societal development. Topics and issues that are addressed are just too context-dependent, complex and fluid for this to be a relevant and meaningful perspective.

In some cases of evaluation of development work, one may perhaps embed a looser notion of generalisation, something like 'efforts to verify patterns or outcomes that are expected, based on evidence in similar cases and/or logical reasoning'. But even such a notion may only very rarely have been built into an evaluation design, at least explicitly, and it may only occasionally be relevant or possible to do so.

Moreover, the above statements by Creswell reflect 'pure' manifestations of quantitative and qualitative enquiry respectively. It may

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<sup>2</sup> 'Triangulation' has become a common term for the use of complementary methods to explore an issue or corroborate a conclusion.



be important in both basic research and evaluations to be clear about which of the two paradigms (quantitative or qualitative) the investigation is grounded on, due to the basic methodological implications that we have already indicated. Still, in reality, investigations will normally contain methodological features that are more typical of the other paradigm. And certain methods may be applied to generate both quantitative and qualitative information. For example, the questionnaire survey, being the main tool of information collection for quantitative analysis of societal phenomena, may commonly be used fruitfully as a method in a basically qualitative approach as well (see Chapter 12). Of course, this links directly to the presentation of findings. Very few evaluation reports will contain analysis of information in only numerical or verbal form.

In order to be in better concord with what is feasible while not having to virtually discard in its entirety the concept of 'quantitative design' in evaluation of development work, we shall in the following broaden the concept of the latter term somewhat from conventional conceptions. We shall conceive of it as encompassing designs with primarily quantitative techniques, also when the studies do not aim at broad generalisations and may not always enable rigorous statistical testing (of effects and impact, in particular). Even then, we shall see, quantitative designs have very limited applicability in evaluations of development programmes and projects.

The account below is limited to methods and techniques for collection of primary information. Accessing secondary information is a different and hardly a scientific issue (while, of course, interpretation of such information may require scientific insight).

## QUANTITATIVE DESIGNS

Quantitative designs may primarily be applied in the evaluation of certain kinds of projects, for measuring *effects* and *impact*. Different degrees of quantification may also be endeavoured in relation to other evaluation categories, but then within the confines of an overall qualitative design.<sup>3</sup>

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<sup>3</sup> Some readers may question this, on the ground that inputs, outputs and some relatively direct changes may be more readily quantified than effects and impact. In this regard, one needs to recognise the following:

While inputs and outputs are normally quantifiable in monetary terms and inputs and some outputs may be so in other terms as well, quantifying them is not any

In this context, a quantitative design involves direct comparison between entities or situations. In fact, such direct comparison is both the primary justification for such a design and a main condition for applying it. As we shall soon see, populations or groups within one population are normally compared with respect to analytical variables of relevance in the particular cases. Moreover, in the perspective of evaluation, any such comparison makes sense only if the populations or groups may be compared also in a time perspective, enabling comparison of changes on the respective variables for the respective entities.

To illustrate, a few examples of achievements that may be directly quantified (and for which comparison may also be done in quantitative terms) are: level, composition and regularity of income; frequency and pattern of diseases; the proportion of people freezing (due to poor housing, for instance); and the rate and level of literacy. In addition are variables the values on which have been quantified—usually as perceptions on an ordinal measurement scale—from originally qualitative information (see the last section of Chapter 10 and also Chapter 14). A few examples of them may be the quality of the food consumed in the household, the regularity of income, access to health services (for instance, as a component of social security), and the degree of empowerment achieved (through a range of possible more specific measures).

Most of the information that is needed for quantification of effects and impact will normally be gathered through questionnaire surveys,

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evaluation concern, at least in its own right, nor does presentation of quantified inputs and outputs in itself carry much significance. When confined to the input/output levels, an evaluation is concerned with efficiency of resource use, which may only rarely be assessed through direct quantitative measurement (see Chapter 6). Similarly, inputs, outputs and/or directly related changes—along with ways in which they are being or have been generated—may in evaluations be presented and examined as parts of an analysis of any of the other more overriding concerns of evaluations that we have examined (relevance, effectiveness, impact, sustainability and/or replicability). Although many of the former may be expressed quantitatively, it is hard to imagine that such quantitative measures (of output, for example) may be used in a basically quantitative analysis pertaining to any of these analytical categories, other than certain effects and impacts. For instance, relevance and sustainability may be analysed using some numerical data, but the analysis can hardly ever be based primarily on such data, let alone on statistical testing of relations between variables. For a few examples of quantitative or quantifiable variables of effect and impact, see the main text.

usually covering intended beneficiaries and any control group or groups. The data are entered in numerical form in pre-determined categories (which may be directly reported values or pre-specified value ranges). This makes the data amenable to statistical manipulation.<sup>4</sup>

Additionally, *benefit–cost* analysis and *cost-effectiveness* analysis are normally of a quantitative kind. They are specific tools for assessing efficiency in certain cases under specific conditions, and may occasionally also be used for calculating economic values on which a broader analysis may be based. Benefit–cost analysis extends beyond outputs, incorporating effects or impact on the benefit side. Cost-effectiveness analysis usually juxtaposes inputs and outputs, but may also incorporate effects or impact. Due to their specific characteristics and the specific requirements that need to be fulfilled for their use, and due to the emphasis on them in some literature on planning and evaluation, we shall examine these tools separately in a later chapter (Chapter 13).

### Genuine Experimental Design

The setting for evaluation is here the ‘ideal’ laboratory-like situation, in which some units in a population are randomly selected (sampled) to receive some programme or project service while others do not received it. Alternatively, some units in a population are sampled at random to receive different kinds of service.<sup>5</sup>

In evaluating the performance of such programmes or projects, samples of the different groups (that is, those that have received the service and those that have not done so, or groups that have received different kinds of service) are selected for comparative analysis. Relevant variables of the groups are then quantified before and after—and possibly also sometime during—the programme or project period, in order to find out if there are differences between the groups regarding any changes on these variables. Subsequently, statistical methods are used to test whether any differences are big and consistent enough to be attributed to other factors than chance, that is,

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<sup>4</sup> The books listed in the References by Fink and Kosekoff (1985); Page and Patton (1991); Nichols (1991); and Fink (1995) are examples of relatively easily accessible literature on quantitative methods, recommended for supplementary reading.

<sup>5</sup> See Chapter 12 for a brief presentation of types and techniques of sampling.

whether such differences can with high probability be linked to the programme or project intervention.

In the sphere of societal development, such a design is mainly applicable for large-scale (such as national) interventions of a trial nature, for example, an information campaign on a specific topic through randomly selected schools. Occasionally, it may also be applied for more specific interventions in certain economic or social fields.<sup>6</sup> For most other societal development schemes, such a design is hardly applicable. Besides its limitation to quantitative measures, the reason is that beneficiaries of a development programme or project are hardly ever selected randomly; instead, one aims at groups with some specific characteristics.

### Quasi-Experimental Design

This design does not involve random samples from a population for the development intervention that is planned.

For evaluation, one draws a random sample from the population of intended beneficiaries, purposively selects one or more control groups which one considers to be or to have been fairly similar to the beneficiary group before the start of the programme or project, and then draws a representative sample of the control group or each of these groups.

Preferably, one should study these groups both before and after the implementation of the programme or project. In practice, one may only do so after the scheme (or a phase of it) has been completed. One may or may not formulate hypotheses initially, but in any case statistical methods are used for testing whether any differences in documented changes between the groups are statistically significant.

### Statistical Design without Control Groups

Usually, the quasi-experimental design is little applicable as well. It is normally very difficult to work with control groups when analysing the achievements of societal development programmes and projects.

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<sup>6</sup> We have earlier, in another context, mentioned an example from Fink and Kosekoff (1985) of an intervention in the social service field in which a randomised experimental design was applied. This was the random assignment of residents of a centre for elderly people to one of three care programmes, after which the quality (as assessed by the residents) and the cost of the three programmes were compared.

This may be because it is difficult to find comparable groups, or because there are so many other factors than those of the programme or project which may cause changes that the control aspect becomes highly uncertain. Studies with control groups may also require large resources. For these reasons, they are rare in evaluations of development schemes.

Alternatively, one may work with a sample of beneficiaries only, quantifying changes on relevant variables pertaining to the beneficiaries that have occurred during the programme or project period or a part of it. Frequently, with a quantitative design, this sample is then divided into sub-samples, in order to quantify changes for each such smaller group and analyse any differences in changes between them. Such sub-samples are delineated according to specific characteristics—such as level of education, size of agricultural land, number of working-age persons in the household, etc. Sometimes, the full sample is divided into different sub-samples for analysing different matters. Subsequently, associations between documented changes and characteristics of units (mostly households or individuals) of the different sub-samples may be traced through statistical testing, based on which relations are inferred between changes on the various variables and programme or project inducements.

Fink and Kosekoff (1985), among others, distinguish between three types of quantitative (or mainly quantitative) studies of changes in one population (commonly referred to as longitudinal studies): trend design, cohort design and panel design. A *trend* design means studying comparable samples of societal groups that are in the same situation at recurrent (such as annual) rounds of study (say, groups of pupils being of the same age at the particular study times), over a certain period (say, five years). In a *cohort* design one studies different random samples of the same population at different points in time (say, different samples of intended beneficiaries before and after a project intervention). A *panel* design involves collection of information from the same sample over time (such as before, during and after a project intervention).

## QUALITATIVE DESIGNS

A lot of information cannot be quantified (expressed by numbers) or cannot be quantified in a meaningful way for the purpose at hand. Moreover, usually, any numerical data that may be generated have

to be further analysed in a context that cannot be quantified or can be quantified only partly; consequently, the data will have to be wholly or largely explained qualitatively (in verbal terms).

Broadly speaking, a basically qualitative approach is necessary at least in the following situations:

- when studying *complex processes*, involving many interrelated factors (usually characterising societal changes);
- for analysing *relevance*, due to the value judgements involved;
- for analysing *sustainability* and *replicability*, due to (a) the essential organisational issues that are normally involved (see the next point) and (b) the judgemental nature of any analysis of future scenarios and other programme or project contexts;
- for studying most *organisational matters*, only very general or, conversely, very specific (narrowly technical) aspects of which may usually be expressed quantitatively;
- quite generally, for *exploring* issues in depth and when endeavouring to *explain* findings comprehensively.

We can already from this list safely conclude that evaluation of development work will mainly have to be done through qualitative inquiry, even when applying the somewhat 'relaxed' notion of quantitative analysis that we indicated some pages back.

Simultaneously, the subjective, judgemental and little standardised nature of qualitative approaches makes it much more difficult (and hardly fruitful) to specify a set of general designs of such approaches. It is much more appropriate to clarify approaches through a presentation of a set of alternative or complementary methods of inquiry and corresponding analysis. That will be done in the next chapter (Chapter 12).

However, in addition to the points just listed, it may be useful to draw attention to some other general analytical dimensions of wide relevance and significance in this regard, namely:

- degree of flexibility;
- degree of participation;
- degree of formative intention;
- explanatory power.

These are dimensions on which qualitative approaches offer more opportunities and a wider range of choices than quantitative approaches.



Moreover, choices on these dimensions will influence the choice of specific study method or combination of methods.

A hallmark of quantitative designs is very little *flexibility* in the planning and implementation of studies (including evaluations). As already emphasised, a highly standardised approach is a requirement for sound statistical analysis. Oppositely, greater flexibility may be the main justification for choosing qualitative methods—and some such methods over others.

Likewise, due to the specific analytical abilities that are required, quantitative analysis tends to be a domain for professionals in the field only. Many qualitative methods, on the other hand, allow *participation* by a broader spectrum of stakeholders, and some methods are even by nature participatory.

Since a quantitative methodology involves direct comparison of values on variables that have been intended to be influenced by the evaluated scheme, evaluation through a quantitative design will normally be of summative nature, at least primarily.<sup>7</sup> Qualitative approaches, by their flexibility in many senses, may be highly *formative*, and may thus be applied in evaluations across the formative–summative continuum.

Whenever very specific conditions (stated above) are fulfilled, evaluations through a quantitative design may be a *forceful* means of clarifying and *verifying* relations between analysed variables, within and between samples of study units. However, these variables tend to be exclusively or mainly what we may call *primary* or first-level variables—that is, variables that directly *express* changes, possibly in relation to intentions—rather than variables for the *explanation* of the primary ones. And, to the extent *linked* variables are sought to be incorporated in a quantitative design, they tend to be of overt nature, with very limited explanatory power. Qualitative analysis, on the other hand, carries virtually endless possibility for elaboration and explanation. We may also refer to the above perspectives as ‘horizontal’ versus ‘vertical’ analysis.

As already clarified, qualitative designs do not exclude collection and analysis of quantitative data. One should even exploit opportunities that may exist for quantification, due to the unambiguous nature of numbers and the concise way in which they may normally

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<sup>7</sup> In phased programmes or projects, results from an evaluation of one phase may be used as an input into the planning of a subsequent phase.



be presented. But, in a basically qualitative design, such data will always be incorporated into a more comprehensive and substantial analysis primarily in text form.

This also means that the methods that will be presented in the next chapter may also, to varying extents, enable generation of data in numerical form, within this broader analytical context.

Before proceeding to methods of study, we shall present a rather 'pure' case of qualitative analysis, conducted as part of an evaluatory study of a community development programme (Box 11.1). The case, borrowed from Iddagoda and Dale (1997), is an individual story, which may be one possible method (mainly a supplementary one) in many evaluations. The case is sufficiently self-explanatory for the present purpose, and should demonstrate the need for qualitative analysis of the matters that are explored.

### **Box 11.1**

#### **SEETHA'S STORY**

*Seetha started telling us her story, showing us a suitcase:*

We began our married life with only this. It contained a few clothes, two earrings, two pairs of rubber slippers, a few plates and cups, a pan, and a few other small things.

After marriage, I came to this village with my husband. That was in 1986. We rented a small mud house with roof of palm leaves. My husband started to work as a casual labourer. When he had no work, life was difficult, and it became even more difficult when I became pregnant. In order to help us out, women in our neighbourhood shared their food with us many times.

When we could not bear the hunger any more, I decided to mortgage my earrings, which I had got from my parents. They were the most valuable things I had.

*When telling this, she wept.*

At that time, Ms. ...[the community worker] came to the village and started to talk to us. She said that the poor people should think more—why they are poor—and work more together to improve their lives. She informed us about the social mobilisation programme that she worked for and how many of the programme participants had already improved their situation.

(Box 11.1 contd.)

(Box 11.1 contd.)

We were encouraged by this, and soon I and five poor women who were my neighbours formed a group. We started to save two rupees each per week to our group fund. That was very hard. But Ms. ...encouraged us so much that we managed it. We already started to think about how we could use the saved money and also what training we should ask for.

After two months, we had collected 100 rupees. Together with members from some other groups I got training in making sweets. I then borrowed the 100 rupees and started to make sweets for sale in the village. I earned some money from that, and I could pay back the loan within one month, with interest also. Then other members took loans and started other activities.

In one group meeting we discussed about our children's future. Then the idea came to start a nursery school. The other members said that I should do this, because I was the only member who had completed primary school. I decided to try. So I borrowed money—100 rupees again—to buy some equipment, and one member gave me a room in her house for the class.

In another training class they told us about the nutritional value of these plants (*she pointed to some wild-growing leafy plants nearby*) and showed us how we could prepare them for food. Every day I made porridge for the children from these plants, and after some time other people in the village started to use them also.

*She told us how many in the village appreciated her nursery school, and that she could even earn a little money from it, through small contributions by parents who sent their children there.*

*She then took yet another loan, of 200 rupees, to buy more utensils to increase her sweet production and also to start making food for sale. In the meantime, she and her husband had built a hut for that purpose. The hut was gradually developed into a boutique, from which they also sold other items.*

In 1990, I got my first loan from our society—we had formed it a year earlier. I took 1,000 rupees. That was a big event for me. I used the loan for our boutique, and I also bought a small piece of land, where we started to grow vegetables. Other members did the same. We also got some training in good methods of cultivation. Our husbands helped us.

Our income increased more from this. So, we and other group members have started to build permanent houses. Our society has a

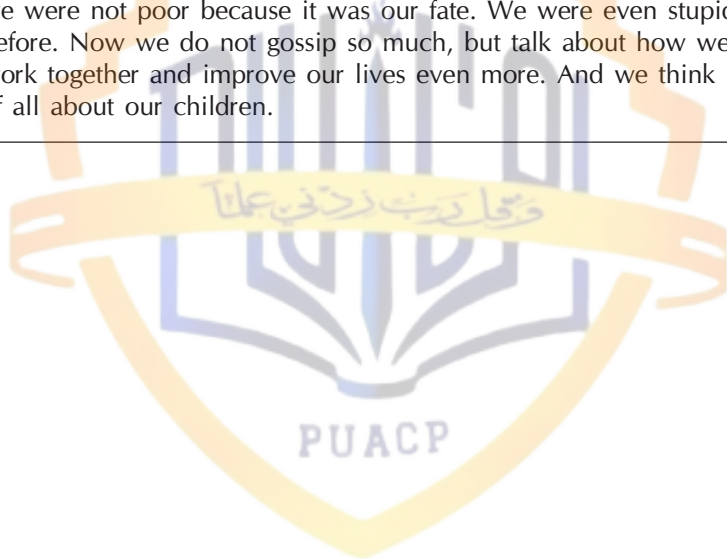
(Box 11.1 contd.)

(Box 11.1 contd.)

separate loan scheme for house building. To get a loan from this, we have to make the bricks ourselves, and the group members help each other to build.

*Seetha was very proud of their society, of which she was an office-bearer. She knew by heart the exact size of its fund at the time and how much of this had been generated through various mechanisms (purchase of shares, compulsory and voluntary savings, interest, and a one time complementary contribution by the support programme).*

All the members and their households have got better lives. Nobody starves any more, and we can buy things that we only saw in the houses of rich people. We have also got much more, which we cannot buy with money. Now we know that we are strong and that we were not poor because it was our fate. We were even stupid before. Now we do not gossip so much, but talk about how we can work together and improve our lives even more. And we think most of all about our children.



## Chapter 12

# METHODS OF INQUIRY

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### INTRODUCTION

The purpose of this chapter is to give an overview of and discuss methods for generating information in evaluations. The scope of the book does not permit any detailed presentation of individual study methods. For that, the reader is referred to textbooks on research methodology.<sup>1</sup>

As already clarified, the methods are a repertoire of tools that are available within the scope of basically qualitative study designs. As also clarified, such designs involve analysis primarily in words and sentences, but may also include some quantification. Such quantification may range from presentation of single-standing numbers through construction of tables for descriptive purposes, to statistical testing of associations between certain variables. Additionally, of course, the analysis may include construction of charts, graphs and maps of various kinds, of a purely conceptual or a more technical nature, relating to the text or to sets of numbers (for instance, based on tables).<sup>2</sup>

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<sup>1</sup> Some examples of books, listed in the References are:

- Neuman, 1994 and Mikkelsen, 1995, for relatively comprehensive general presentations;
- Casley and Kumar, 1988, with direct reference to monitoring and evaluation;
- Rietbergen-McCracken and Narayan, 1998; Germann et al., 1996; and Dixon, 1995, on participatory assessment;
- Pratt and Loizos, 1992 and Nichols, 1991, for particularly simple general presentations.

<sup>2</sup> See Dale, 2000 (Chapter One) for some further reflections, and for an example of a flowchart of a conceptual kind. For a brief overview of techniques of various types of charting, Damelio, 1996 is useful reading.

The presented methods vary greatly in terms of analytical rigour, by conventional scientific criteria. Approaches in many evaluations of development programmes and projects tend not to fulfil main quality standards of the methodology that is promoted and even prescribed in textbooks on social science research. The scientifically most rigorous evaluations may usually be done by professionals and students in academic institutions—for instance, as thesis related research. However, this does not mean that such studies are always of a superior quality, in terms of clarifying matters relating to the main dimensions and variables of evaluation (spelt out in Part Two). Often, simpler and more down-to-earth approaches may be more useful. A common shortcoming of research based in academic institutions is little familiarity on the part of the researchers with day-to-day work realities of development planners and managers (relating to the programme or project and its context), with implications for the relevance and appropriateness of recommendations, for example. Another shortcoming in many instances is a tendency to emphasise method over subject-matter, and a related one to work within the confines of ‘normal professionalism’ (Chambers, 1993)—a main consequence of which may be undue emphasis on a quantitative methodology.<sup>3</sup>

One intention with this overview is, thus, to sensitise readers to differences that commonly exist between approaches in practical development work and many academic conventions about information gathering and processing.

Moreover, our emphasis is on methods for generating information in the field, through direct communication and/or observation. This will usually be followed by some further information analysis, more or less integrated with or detached from the fieldwork. As already indicated, relatively separate analysis of gathered ‘data’ (being an appropriate word here) is typical of studies with emphasis on quantification. With increasingly qualitative designs, any clear separation

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<sup>3</sup> A case in point is the student who is asked, after finalised fieldwork, what he/she has found out, and who answers: ‘I do not know yet; I have to analyse the data first’. I have heard this even from students whose research aim has been to evaluate a development scheme—and I have even seen the remark followed by an understanding nod by his/her research adviser. This is typical with highly standardised designs emphasising compilation of quantitative data. The student has probably neither ‘found’ much that would be considered useful by programme or project staff nor learnt much about societal structures and processes and realities of development work.

of 'data collection' and 'data analysis' becomes less and less possible. Recording, substantiating relations, explaining and writing become increasingly intertwined exercises.<sup>4</sup>

For familiarisation with tools of further analysis, reference is again made to books on research methodology, for instance, some of those listed in footnote 1 of this chapter.

## AN OVERVIEW OF METHODS

### Document Examination

In most instances, evaluators may draw information from existing documents of various kinds, usually referred to as secondary sources. The most important ones may usually be plan documents (sometimes along with preparatory documents for these) and monitoring reports. These may often be supplemented with other progress reports, reports from workshops or other special events, etc. Occasionally, documents outside the realm of the programme or project may be relevant and useful as well, for instance, census data and other statistical data produced by government agencies or reports by other development organisations in related fields.

### Evaluator's Observation and Measurement

#### *Informal and Formal Observation*

In our context, 'observation' means carefully looking at or listening to something or somebody, with the aim of gaining insight for sound assessment. A range of phenomena may be observed. A few examples of relevance here may be physical facilities, work done by some people and organisational performance.

Observation may be informal or more or less formalised. Informal observation may be more or less casual or regular. An unplanned assessment of the quality of a road by an evaluator as the person drives on it is an example of casual informal observation; a scheduled trip

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<sup>4</sup> For instance, see Box 11.1 to have this general argument substantiated. Explanation (or efforts at explanation) is here part and parcel of the presentation. Of course, the evaluator may also work further on this material, using the information generated through this story as an input into a more comprehensive analysis. Sometimes, an aim of the latter may be to seek patterns of wider applicability, that is, some degree of generalisation.

on the road by the person for the purpose of getting information about the road's quality is an example of formal observation.

Normally, in evaluations of development schemes, observation is used as a more or less important, sometimes even necessary, supplementary method to other methods.

### *Direct Measurement*

For assessing certain kinds of physical facilities, in particular, the evaluator may have to acquire information through measurement. When evaluating investments in home gardens, for instance, he or she may need to know such things as the size of the garden, various land features, area planted with certain species, the state of the plants, etc. To the extent such information has not already been acquired, or is not considered to be recent enough or reliable for other reasons, the evaluator will have to collect raw data, through appropriate methods of measurement, and process these data as needed.

In evaluations of development work, any direct physical measurement will almost always constitute only a specific and very limited part of the entire thrust.

### Participatory and Collective Analysis

#### *Meeting*

Arranging and conducting meetings is one of the most common methods of evaluating development work. The participants may be programme or project personnel, intended beneficiaries, and/or other stakeholders or resource persons. Often, separate meetings may be conducted with different groups. The proceedings may be more or less strictly steered or more softly facilitated.

A main limitation of many meetings as information-generating events is their formal nature, with evaluators very much in command. This may limit active participation to the most vocal persons, and may negatively influence the participants' willingness to disclose and share certain kinds of information. Therefore, meetings are hardly ever the best forums for open and free communication, particularly on sensitive matters and matters on which there may be substantial disagreement. Still, depending on the composition of the audience, the matters discussed and, not least, open-minded and inviting moderation by the evaluators, meetings may provide a lot of useful



information. Moreover, information and views may not flow in only one direction, from the audience to the evaluators, but the meetings may be forums for discussion among the participants as well. A more specific strength of meetings is that ideas and opinions often get widely disseminated and known, sometimes also through some kind of subsequent written report (minutes).

### *Informal Group Discussion*

Methodologically, this is largely an equivalent of informal observation: the evaluator comes into an unplanned group setting, in which a relevant discussion takes place, commonly more or less induced (and later possibly moderated) by the evaluator. For instance, this may happen in the course of a household survey, either at an interviewee's house or somewhere else. While such discussions may not be part of any explicitly formulated research design, they may often be events that the evaluator should welcome and seek to get the maximum benefit from. How the evaluator should behave to that end, may be largely situation-specific. Sometimes, he or she may benefit from being mostly silent; in other instances, active moderation may be useful.

### *Facilitated Group Discussion*

Group discussions may also be planned and arranged, and will then normally be moderated by the evaluator. In such discussions, the participants are expected to communicate actively on relatively equal terms, in an open and secure atmosphere. Such events are, therefore, facilitated rather than led by the person who has arranged them. To be effective, the groups should be relatively small, and the participants may be purposively chosen. Sometimes, separate groups of relative equals (for instance, female and male, long-term and new settlers, etc.) may address the same matter. Information may be generated for use by an organisation of the discussants or by outsiders. The duration may vary much, from an hour or two to perhaps a whole day.

If well planned and facilitated, group discussions are in many instances a particularly effective (and often underutilised) method of generating, within a relatively short time, much information of high relevance, significance and reliability. Under favourable circumstances, they may also have an empowering effect on the participants—through the very opportunity they get to communicate freely and the

evaluator's appreciation of their contribution, and also through augmentation of knowledge and understanding of discussed matters during the process.

### *Workshop-based Participatory Analysis*

This is a methodology that has often gone under another name: 'participatory rural appraisal (PRA)'. A more recently introduced term is 'participatory learning and action (PLA)'. The terms have come to be applied as a common denominator for an array of techniques by which non-professionals jointly explore problems, plan or evaluate in a workshop setting.

The persons who participate in the evaluation (in focus here) are usually the intended beneficiaries of the studied programme or project. Sometimes, other stakeholders may be included also. In any case, the exercise is virtually always organised and facilitated by an outside body, normally the organisation that is responsible for the development thrust or somebody engaged by that organisation.

Frequently used techniques of participatory analysis are: simple charting and mapping, various forms of ranking, grouping of phenomena (in simple tables, for instance) and—less frequently—storytelling or other oral accounts (see also later).

The main general justification for participatory evaluation is to involve the primary stakeholders—the people for whom the development scheme is supposed to be of most direct concern—in critical organised examination. Sometimes, the thrust may be explicitly founded on an ideology of democratic development and even an intention of empowering the participants.<sup>5</sup> A more specific justification may be to generate more valid and reliable information than one thinks may otherwise be possible.

Main limitations may be the organisation-intensive nature of such exercises and the long time that the participants are often expected to spend in the workshop. Moreover, in my experience, the purpose of some visual techniques (such as village mapping and listing of ranked phenomena) is often unclear, for both the moderators and the participants. This may lead to a discrepancy between the outcome of the workshop and the efforts that have gone into it, at least as perceived by many workshop participants.

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<sup>5</sup> For further elaboration, see the section on empowerment evaluation in Chapter 2.

Some further elaboration of and reflections on participatory analysis will follow in the next section of the present chapter.

### *Collective Brainstorming*

This is an intensive and open-minded communication event that a group of persons agrees to embark on in a specific situation. It may be a useful method for analysing problems—relating to a development programme or project, in our context—that is clearly recognised and often felt by all the participants. The method may be particularly effective if the problem occurs or is aggravated suddenly or unexpectedly, in which case the participants may feel an urge to solve or ameliorate it.

Collective brainstorming may be resorted to by organisations undertaking the development work or by the intended beneficiaries of it. In cases of mutual benefit membership organisations, the two will overlap. In other cases, intended beneficiaries of a scheme undertaken by others may themselves initiate and conduct a brainstorming of some problem relating to the scheme, based on which they may possibly even challenge the programme or project management.

### Interviewing

#### *Casual Purposive Communication*

This is similar to informal group discussion, that take place face to face between an evaluator and another person (or a couple of evaluators and such other persons). In order to be considered as a method of evaluation, the evaluator must view it as serving some purpose in that regard, in which case the latter will seek to guide the conversation accordingly. Often, the usefulness and purpose of the event may not initially be obvious, but may develop as the conversation proceeds. In some instances, a person may actively seek contact with the evaluator, in order to convey particular pieces of information or an opinion on a matter.

While hardly a recognised method in scientific research, casual purposive conversation is often an important means of generating information in evaluations, and evaluators should normally exploit opportunities they may get for useful conversations of this kind. In particular, such conversation may substantially augment the evaluator's understanding of the social environment they work in, but it may also provide useful information about the performance and achievements

of the scheme that is being evaluated. Simultaneously, there are obvious dangers of misuse of this method. If it is applied comprehensively or uncritically, it may provide a poorly representative and even distorted picture. Unfortunately, due to time constraints and possibly even convenience, the method has been misused in evaluations, sometimes under cover of the cloudy term 'key informant interview' (see also below).

### *Questionnaire Survey*

Several persons are here asked the same questions. The questions may be closed or more or less open. That is, they may require precise brief answers or they may invite some elaboration (for instance, a judgement) in the respondents' own words. Depending on its nature, the information is then further processed qualitatively or quantitatively.

This method is superior whenever one wants information of the same kind from large numbers of people. It also enables study of statistically representative samples of units. This extensive coverage may also be the method's main weakness, particularly if time is a constraint. The information that is generated may then be too shallow to provide adequate understanding—because of limited opportunities of exploring matters in depth, and often also because different persons may be employed to gather the information, restricting cumulative learning.

Surveys that comply with textbook requirements of representativity and rigour are, normally, comprehensive thrusts. They are therefore considered too time-consuming in most cases of programme and project evaluation. Whenever applied, they tend to be conducted by persons or research organisations specifically engaged for the purpose. This may sometimes involve both so-called baseline and follow-up studies (see Chapter 10). When 'main' evaluators conduct such surveys themselves, they tend to resort to simpler and more open versions. The simplest are often referred to as checklist surveys, that is, exploration guided by a set of pre-specified and fairly standardised broad questions. In fact, checklist surveys are one of the most commonly used methods in evaluations, particularly of aspects of benefits (relevance, effectiveness and impact).

Connecting to this, two interrelated features of questionnaires warrant further clarification and discussion. They are those of quantitative versus qualitative and closed- versus open-question formats. We shall address these features in the next section of this chapter.

*Standardised Key Informant Interviewing*

This is the application of a standard questionnaire for relatively few informants. Since fewer persons are interviewed, one may spend more time with each of them and analyse matters in greater depth. To that end, one normally asks primarily open-ended questions. Unlike with casual interviewing, the key informants are purposively selected (initially and/or in the course of the evaluation process). Along with the standardised questions, this may help ensure a degree of representativity of the information that is generated, being of particular importance if this method is used as a substitute for broader questionnaire surveys.

If conscientiously applied, this method may often be highly useful, and in some instances even the main one, for generating the information that one may be after, on virtually any evaluation matter.

*Oral Queries and Probing*

This may be a supplementary method for seeking adequate information on particularly difficult matters, being often also vague or unclear for the informant or informants. This may require active participation by the evaluator, for seeking joint clarification or understanding. For instance, in order to augment the informant's ability to reason and express facts or views, the evaluator may help define concepts, clarify connections between variables, or suggest analytical frameworks, and matters may have to be explored repeatedly and in different angles. Examples may be efforts to further clarify data that appear in some secondary source (for instance, a financial statement) or issues relating to such data.

In-depth Exploration*Community and Individual Stories*

One evaluation method that has been advocated and occasionally used (apparently mainly in primary health schemes) is the so-called *community story*. Building on the idea of different rationalities (clarified in Chapter 1), it honours lifeworld rationality and emphasises communal self-reflection. Normally, the method may be used as a means of exploration supplementary to other methods. Its core feature is a reflective account of community history, emphasising changes in aspects that are particularly important in the specific context. The story may be presented by one person, but more usefully by a group

of persons, making their individual contributions in a joint interactive process of analysis. In the latter case, the method may be seen as a specific variant of facilitated group discussion. It may be particularly appropriate in cases where whole communities have been or are being intended to benefit from a scheme in a similar manner.

*Individual stories* by intended beneficiaries, in particular, may also give good insights into the workings and achievements of certain development schemes or parts of them. We have already given an example of such a story, at the end of Chapter 11. This, as well, is normally used as a supplementary method. For example, a set of individual stories may usefully supplement information acquired through a household questionnaire survey. In that case, persons whom one wishes to tell such stories (and who are willing to do so) may be identified during that survey and visited later.

### *In-depth Case Study*

This is a thorough and often long-lasting exploration, normally of local communities, population groups or organisations, with emphasis on matters of relevance to the purpose at hand. It is normally a broad-focus approach, in which the evaluator may use several tools of analysis that we have earlier referred to as methods in their own right. They are mainly qualitative ones, such as observation, casual purposive communication, long formal interviews and group discussions.

A particularly intensive and 'deep' approach may be referred to as 'participant observation', which means that the evaluator participates in the social life of the community under study during the period of exploration. For instance, in studying some farmers' perceptions and behaviour relating to innovative agricultural practices being promoted under a project, the evaluator becomes a member of the rural community, as long as it may take to get a good enough insight. In its original sense, a participant observer was supposed to participate directly in the activities being the topic of study. Increasingly, however, participant observation is also used to encompass lengthy observations as a local resident, with only incidental or even no direct participation.

The in-depth case study may be particularly useful for studying the impact of development schemes on communities or groups among the community inhabitants. This is due to its potential for untangling complex relations in societal change and thereby also for providing



a good understanding of reasons for success or failure (see also Chapter 9). Through its ability to come to grips with complex structures and processes, it may also be useful for exploring institution-building and less overt aspects of organisation.

Still, while being a primary method in certain types of social science research, the in-depth case study has been rarely used in programme and project evaluation. This is primarily due to the amount of time (and sometimes other resources) that are required for it. However, in occasional instances, it may be a cost-effective method—particularly in open-ended process programmes or schemes that are intended to be replicated on a bigger scale.

### Systematic Rapid Assessment

This is the equivalent of what is more commonly called ‘rapid rural appraisal (RRA)’. I use this alternative term because the approach is applicable beyond ‘appraisal’ (as normally understood), and because it may be used in both rural and urban settings.

With rapid assessment is meant a composite thrust at generating information within a short period of time. That information may be all that one thinks one needs, or it may constitute part of that information.

The approach may involve use of a range of methods. Normally, the main ones are: quick observation; casual purposive communication; brief standardised key informant interviews; brief group discussion; and, sometimes, a checklist survey.

Normally, the assessment is undertaken by a team of persons, each of whom may have different professional backgrounds and a prime responsibility for exploring specific matters. Broader judgements and conclusions are then arrived at through frequent communication among the team members, by which synergies of knowledge-generation may be achieved. For this reason and due to the simple techniques used, the approach may be particularly cost-effective. It is not surprising, then, that rapid assessment by a team of evaluators has been the overall most frequently used methodology in donor-commissioned or -promoted evaluations of development programmes and projects.

A common weakness of rapid assessment is that the generated information may not be as representative as is desirable. Even more importantly, if one is not careful, important issues may be left unattended or inadequately analysed.



Aspects of rapid assessment will be further explored a few pages ahead.

## A FURTHER ELABORATION OF SOME TOPICS

### Questionnaire Construction

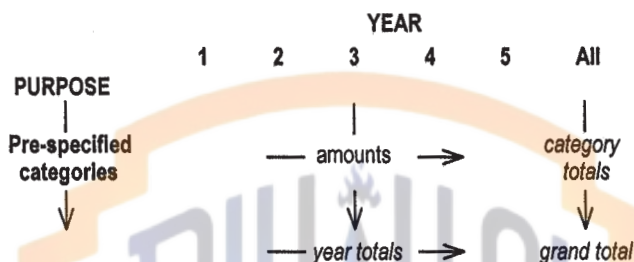
In view of the widespread use of questionnaires in much evaluation, we shall here briefly address questionnaire construction, exploring the crucial dual issue of quantitative versus qualitative format and closed versus open questions. We shall do so with reference to three alternative sets of questions about income effects of loans issued under a wider programme, for instance, a community-focused scheme with financial services as one component. Thus, we assume that our questions constitute only a part of a more comprehensive questionnaire. The latter may also include other questions about aspects of the loan scheme, exploring this more comprehensively than is endeavoured here. Note that we here address loans that are taken for one or more production purposes only. In the present context, we do not need to be concerned with the design features of the wider programme, including more specific features of the loan facility.

The examples are presented in Box 12.1.

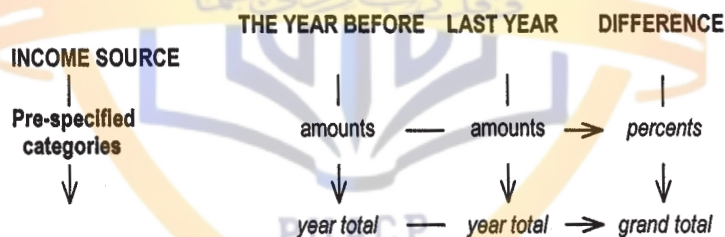
Alternative 1 is a typical quantitative design, requiring a set of closed questions. First, the evaluator aims at getting a detailed account of the loans taken, by year, purpose and amount. Note that the purpose is structured as a set of pre-specified categories (fields of investment)—for instance, crop cultivation, animal husbandry, types of manufacturing industries, etc. Data will then be entered only in the categories that are applicable for the respective interviewees. This standardisation is necessary to obtain consistency and comparability of the data for later statistical treatment. Next, in order to check on any association between borrowing (assumed to accrue as investment) and income, the evaluator inquires about household income, for the year before the programme was launched and the year before the evaluation is conducted. For the sake of direct linkage with the data on borrowing, the data are entered into the same set of pre-specified categories (being here income categories). Third, in order to explore further, and more directly, relations between programme-induced investment and income generation, a question is asked about the contribution of the former to the latter during the last year—also

**Box 12.1****EXAMPLE OF QUESTIONNAIRE CONSTRUCTION:  
INCOME EFFECT OF LOANS****ALTERNATIVE 1**

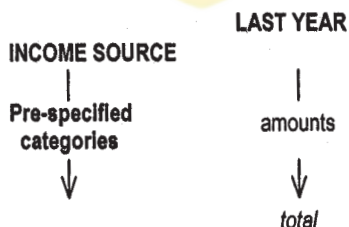
1. Specify the loans you have taken for investment in production, from the start of the programme till now:



2. State the annual income of your household, the year before the programme started and last year:



3. a) State the income (or loss) accrued last year from your investment(s) using borrowed money from the programme:



- b) Give a brief explanation \_\_\_\_\_

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(Box 12.1 contd.)

ALTERNATIVE 2

1. a) Have you taken any loans from the programme for investment in production?

Yes \_\_\_\_ No \_\_\_\_

- b) If 'yes': For what purpose(s)? \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_

2. a) Have you got any additional income from these investments for your household?

Less \_\_\_\_ None \_\_\_\_ A little \_\_\_\_ Much \_\_\_\_ Very much \_\_\_\_

- b) Why have you got less / none / a little more / much more / very much more income? \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_

ALTERNATIVE 3

1. a) Have you taken any loans from the programme for investment in production?

Yes \_\_\_\_ No \_\_\_\_

- b) If 'yes': Specify the purpose(s)

← Pre-specified categories →

Amount(s) borrowed -----

2. a) What were the most important sources of income (maximum three) of your household the year before the programme started? If more than one, give them in ranked order: 1, 2, 3.

← Pre-specified categories →

Ranked sources -----

- b) What were the most important sources of income (maximum three) of your household last year? If more than one, give them in ranked order: 1, 2, 3.

← Pre-specified categories →

Ranked sources -----

(Box 12.1 contd.)

(Box 12.1 contd.)

3. If any differences between 2 a) and 2 b):

a) What is the reason / are the reasons for this change / these changes? \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_

b) If loans from the programme: Have the loans from the programme caused or contributed to the change / the changes?  
Yes \_\_\_\_ No \_\_\_\_

c) If yes: Elaborate \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
If no: Why not? \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_

4. a) How much can your household afford to consume now, compared to the situation before the programme started?  
Less \_\_\_\_ About the same \_\_\_\_ More \_\_\_\_

b) Why? \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_

c) Have loans from the programme played any role?  
Yes \_\_\_\_ No \_\_\_\_

d) If yes: Elaborate \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
If no: Why not? \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_

enabling direct comparison with the last-column data of the previous table. Finally, an open question is added, to elicit some qualitative information for explanation.

Thus, by comparing the three tables or parts of them, in various ways, the evaluator should, in principle, be able to provide a fairly detailed account of the role of the evaluated loan facility on household income—for individual households and, more significantly, the whole sample of interviewed households.

However, this is a rather mechanistic perspective on data generation, in which the evaluator makes assumptions that may be more or less questionable and troublesome. They pertain to the respondents' conception and understanding of terms and relationships that are to be explored as well as their ability to provide the numbers that are asked for. In particular, difficulties may arise in getting reliable data on aspects of income and the contributions to the household income of loans taken. The questions assume a 'business-like' attitude and behaviour on the part of the interviewees that may be beyond reality, not least for poorly educated persons involved in small-scale enterprises.<sup>6</sup> Obviously, the basic concept of 'income', in the context of enterprises, needs to be well defined and what is asked for well clarified. But, for reliable data to be generated, the definitions will have to be understood and tally with the interviewees' own conception and use in practice.

Alternative 2 is a much simpler approach for generating information about any contributions of the loan facility to the household economy. No quantitative data are recorded. Instead, the evaluator requests only the very basic information about loan-taking for investment, and then directly seeks the interviewee's judgement about the effect of any loan-based investments on the household economy. The information is presented in two forms: in pre-specified categories on a nominal and an ordinal measurement scale, and in verbal form, reflecting the interviewees' free oral presentation. This is frequently a good combination for managing qualitative information. The former

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<sup>6</sup> The main aspects of this may be an ability to sort clearly between various sources of income and various components of the household economy, familiarity with basic business concepts, and the keeping of proper accounts. These are intricate questions that we have to leave here. For some further exploration of the issue in the context of micro-finance programmes, see, for instance, Dale, 2002a and some of the literature referred to in that book.

enables direct comparison across study units, and therewith also simple statistical treatment of the qualitative information thus standardised. The latter enables generation of a lot of information that may be very useful and may provide much more insight than any quantitative or quantified data—while posing its own challenges for further processing and presentation.

The pertinent questions are whether the information that is generated through this much simpler approach may still be useful enough and how it compares with the above-presented quantitative information, in terms of significance and reliability. In many instances, in my experience, it may be superior.

Alternative 3, as well, is a basically qualitative thrust, with no effort to record directly quantitative income data (or any other quantitative data). The only form of quantification is direct ranking, based on the interviewees' judgement. The main difference between this alternative and the previous one is that the subject-matter is broken down into more specific topics for inquiry, being also explored in greater detail—particularly through more guided inducements for the interviewees to reflect freely. Generally, this would be the direction in which I would want to develop a questionnaire on this matter, at least in typical scenarios of community based or—focused programmes.

The reader is requested to reflect further on the issues involved, with reference to related presentations and reflections earlier in the book. While these examples pertain to a specific kind of development intervention, the illustrated issues are relevant and much of the argumentation is applicable in evaluation of all kinds of development programmes and projects.

### Participatory Analysis

Guba and Lincoln (1989) state that evaluations should be conducted in such a way that 'each [stakeholder] group must confront and deal with the constructions of all the others', that is, with the other groups' perceptions of factors and issues to be evaluated. This promotes learning by everybody: 'As each group copes with the constructions posed by others, their own constructions alter by virtue of becoming better informed and more sophisticated' (ibid.: 41). The reason for this is that different groups emphasise different values in life and may have different needs and relevant experiences. This perspective links on to earlier discussed aspects of rationality.

Development programmes and projects usually involve many kinds of *stakeholders*.<sup>7</sup> Some tend to exert more influence than others, also in evaluations. The ideological foundation of much participatory analysis is, we have noted, a perceived need to incorporate the voices of intended beneficiaries. In many instances, these are also particularly deprived groups in society (in one or more senses), in which case *empowerment* may be a related aim. There may also be substantial differences of perception and interest within the population of intended beneficiaries, which require attention. Empowerment and mediation of interests, involving complex interrelations between people (individuals and groups), may only be endeavoured through *interactive communication* of the above-mentioned kind.

However, the forms and meanings of participation and empowerment may vary substantially between types of development schemes. People may evaluate work that is done by their own organisation or organisations—having earlier been referred to as *internal* evaluation. Of particular relevance in the present context is assessment within mutual benefit organisations, that is, organisations that aim at generating benefits for their membership. Most such assessments will be done fairly currently, for instance, through reporting in member meetings, being most appropriately referred to as monitoring. But the organisations may also decide to undertake more specific assessments—evaluations—of performance. Such assessments will normally be simple in terms of both organisation and technology, but may under favourable circumstances be effective.<sup>8</sup>

In evaluations of *externally* (or basically *externally*) planned and managed schemes, systematic participation has mainly sought to be enlisted through workshop-based exercises. Some additional facts and reflections to those already presented in the previous section are:

In the workshops, more or less standardised *techniques* of participatory analysis have tended to be applied. The main ones have been:

- livelihood analysis, comparing factors such as means of livelihood, food security, indebtedness, etc., before and after a development scheme, possibly for various groups;
- wealth grouping and ranking, of individuals, households and other social groups, and any changes in ranks and structures;

<sup>7</sup> For elaboration and discussion, see Dale, 2004 (several chapters).

<sup>8</sup> An example of such an evaluation will be presented in Chapter 15.



- time use analysis, usually comparing different people's use of time before and after a development scheme;
- mobility analysis, by way of mapping and explaining changes in movements, possibly for different groups;
- organisational context [for instance, Political, Economic, Social and Technical (PEST)] and portfolio analysis, relating to the strategy of one or more organisations (particularly, people's own organisations that may have been formed);
- organisational process analysis, by drawing workflow and task-actor-role diagrams (pertaining to ongoing or done development work, by all or some involved bodies);
- presentation of life histories, with focus on phenomena under assessment;
- exploration of specific phenomena of relevance (natural, cultural, economic, etc.), with emphasis on change during a relevant period;
- conceptualising and judging future scenarios.

Usually, such workshop-based exercises may be most effective for assessing benefits and related matters as well as aspects of organisational performance. But virtually any issue of concern in evaluations may be addressed using some techniques.<sup>9</sup>

The workshop exercises may be done jointly by all the participants and/or by sub-groups that are formed according to specific criteria. The more heterogeneous the workshop body is, the more important will it normally be to form such sub-groups for analysis. The conclusions of the various groups will then normally be presented and discussed in the full forum. Specific challenges may arise in instances where one wants to include both intended beneficiaries and programme or project staff in the workshop, particularly to avoid dominance by the latter over the former. One arrangement that has been resorted to for reducing this problem has been to have the local population finalise their proceedings first and then invite the officials to a subsequent plenary session.

The *feasibility* of undertaking a constructive participatory evaluation may depend on several factors. Main ones may be: local social structures, influencing the ability to include all relevant social sections

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<sup>9</sup> For further elaboration of tools of participatory analysis, see, for instance: Mukherjee, 1993; Chambers, 1994a; 1994b; 1994c; and Mikkelsen, 1995.

in open and relatively egalitarian discussion; the extent to which people feel they have benefited from the programme or project to be evaluated; and, commonly, any prospect for the exercise to trigger additional activities and benefits (in which case the evaluation will be of a more or less formative nature).

As already alluded to, workshop-based participatory evaluations may easily become rather mechanistic exercises, in which the application of a portfolio of techniques may receive undue attention and appear to be an aim in itself. While well-intentioned, too many exercises have left the participants disappointed and even frustrated: they may have felt that the workshop itself was aimless or confusing, or they may not have seen any result of the work they did there. Such thrusts may have done more harm than good, negatively affecting people's attitudes and morale. This is not to say that such workshops should be done away with altogether. But managers and evaluators need to think carefully about the purpose of the exercises and what they may achieve, and try to match purpose and intended outcomes with the efforts they expect people to make.

### Rapid Assessment

We have already mentioned that systematically conducted rapid assessment is a composite approach for generating information within a short period of time, through application of methods such as quick observation, casual purposive communication, brief standardised key informant interview, brief group discussion, and checklist survey. We have also clarified that the assessment is normally undertaken by a team of persons, each of whom may have different formalised roles, and who share (or ought to share) information and views frequently and go through rounds of internal discussions.

Some brief further reflections about this methodology are as follows:

The main strengths and weaknesses of the approach are fairly obvious. The main *strengths* are its applicability in situations of time constraint (that is, when the evaluators have little time for their investigation), the unsophisticated nature of the techniques used, and its invitation to teamwork. In addition, the approach may be used for addressing virtually any evaluation concern. Its overriding *weaknesses* are that information may not be widely representative and that one may very possibly wind up the evaluation with only a superficial understanding of matters and issues that have been studied.

An essential point is that this method is particularly sensitive to the *competence* of the evaluators, in terms of technical knowledge in respective fields and prior knowledge and understanding of the society in which the evaluation is undertaken. This assumes particular importance if the method is the only or the main evaluation tool. Stated rather bluntly, an evaluation through rapid assessment may yield little information or even give misleading conclusions if it is done by persons without the required knowledge and skills, while it may give fully adequate information highly cost-effectively if it is done by people with much knowledge and adequate skills.

Rapid assessment may also be used by evaluators for *familiarising* themselves with a *development scheme* or its environment before the main part of the evaluation starts. This may be a highly effective approach for *augmenting* the quality of the full evaluation, particularly if it is to be done by evaluators with less-than-desired contextual knowledge.

Moreover, rapid assessment should frequently be considered a useful *supplement* to other methods for other purposes, such as:

- to get a *preliminary assessment* of possible benefits or of issues that need particular attention, in order to help design the subsequent investigation better;
- to get *some general information* in the course of the evaluation about issues that are considered to be of secondary importance in themselves while still connected to main issues of concern;
- to consult *certain people* who might otherwise not be consulted (for instance, *non-target groups* who may have been affected indirectly, positively or negatively);
- to get some general *information* about a comparable programme or project.

For instance, a rapid assessment may be the only feasible approach for getting any comparable information as a basis for a cost-effectiveness assessment, as evaluators may not otherwise possess or get access to usable information from other development schemes with which the evaluated scheme may be compared.

In broad *conclusion*, then, rapid assessment may be an adequate evaluation methodology in itself in certain instances on specific conditions, and may in many other instances be a highly useful supplementary tool.

## A NOTE ON SAMPLING

*Sampling* is the process of deciding on units for analysis, out of a larger number of similar units. That is, one selects a *sample* of such units, being a portion of all the units of the same type that the study relates to and for which conclusions are normally intended to be drawn. The latter are referred to as the study *population*. The units of study may be villages, households, persons, fields, etc.

The *rationale* for sampling is that the whole set of units being subject to study (the study population) is commonly too large to be covered in full in the investigation. And even if that might have been feasible, it would usually not be necessary, as reasonably reliable conclusions may be drawn for the whole population from findings relating to some proportion of it.

In evaluations of development work, samples are most commonly selected for the purpose of interviewing people about the respective programme or project and related issues, but may also be chosen for observation or some kind of in-depth exploration. The units for such purposes are most often households, but may also be individuals or groups of some kind (for example, women's groups or business enterprises). Sampling units for observation may also be physical entities, such as houses or agricultural fields, and even events, such as work operations or periodic markets. Some such units may also be chosen for some kind of measurement.

A basic distinction is usually made between 'random' sampling and 'non-random' sampling. Some kinds of non-random sampling are sometimes called 'informal' sampling.

### Random Sampling

For statistical analysis, in which one endeavours to draw firm conclusions for the whole population from which the sample is drawn, the primary requirement of the sample is that it be *representative* of that population. That means that it should have the same characteristics as the study population, at acceptable levels of certainty, with regard to the relevant characteristics.

To work with representative samples is particularly important in cases where one wants to obtain well verified conclusions about effects and impact of a scheme for its intended beneficiaries.

The sampling has to be especially rigorous if one wants to statistically compare changes pertaining to different groups of beneficiaries

of a scheme, or compare changes for beneficiaries with those for some control group—that is, when applying an experimental design. An example may be an evaluation of a credit programme implemented among some thousand farmers, the effectiveness of which one wants to assess by comparing changes in income, indebtedness, etc., for these people with changes on the same variables for some other people. In this case, those other people (the control group) may be non-supported farmers in other areas of the district, who are assumed to have been in the same situation as the target farmers prior to the implementation of the credit programme.

However, we have argued, such designs are exceptional. But the usefulness of representative samples does not end here. Such samples may be a requirement with other quantitative designs as well, and may also be useful in many cases of basically qualitative design, especially for quantification that may be endeavoured on specific variables (such as frequency distributions and any comparison between sub-samples).

Representativity requires, among other things, that the sample be of a minimum size. The number of units that should be included in the study sample increases with the increasing size of the population, although far from proportionally.<sup>10</sup>

There are statistical methods for calculating the minimum size of representative samples, within stated margins of error. However, evaluators may instead make use of existing tables, commonly included in textbooks, showing required sample sizes for different sizes of populations under various assumptions (see, for instance, Salant and Dillman, 1994: 55). In most instances, even the following simple rules-of-thumb may be good enough:

- Highly representative samples with low uncertainty will under almost any realistic circumstances be: 50–70 units for populations between 100 and 300; 70–90 units for populations between 300 and 1,000; and 90–100 units for populations over 1,000;<sup>11</sup>

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<sup>10</sup> In fact, with population sizes from a couple of thousands upwards, the required sample size does not change much, unless one aims at unusually high levels of certainty and precision (high confidence level and low sampling error).

<sup>11</sup> These are sample sizes for highly varied populations with ( $\pm$ ) 10 per cent sampling error at the 95 per cent confidence level.

- Even if one accepts higher uncertainty about the representativity of the sample, the latter should not be much smaller than 30 units, as this is the approximate minimum size at which basic statistical manipulations of the sample (for instance, calculations of averages and some simple measures of spread) may be done with reasonable confidence;<sup>12</sup>
- When comparing groups within a population statistically, samples with acceptable representativity must be drawn for each of the groups that one compares.

Samples are obtained by repeatedly selecting sampling units, until one has got a sample of the size that one wants. The selection process requires a complete list of numbered units, called a *sampling frame*. One can either draw the units entirely at random (by pure chance) or select units at a fixed interval (say, every fifth unit) from a randomly selected starting point (say, from the third unit onwards).

One may also do *stratified random sampling*. Here, one first divides the population into sub-groups (strata) and then draws random samples from each of the strata. Examples of strata may be: education groups in a population; settlement clusters in a village; or the population within different distance intervals from a main road. This kind of sampling may help ensure that the evaluator gets included in the total sample an adequate number of units in each of the categories that should be represented. This may be particularly important when the total sample is small and/or when there are few units in some category or categories of the population.

Another method is the *random walk*, used for sampling houses, plots and similar physical units. The researcher then follows a set route according to precise instructions, selecting units at regular, pre-decided intervals. This is often the most convenient method in situations when one cannot establish a proper sampling frame.<sup>13</sup>

It is also common with *two-stage sampling*, and even sampling in more than two stages may be done. For instance, one may first draw a random sample of villages and then draw random samples of households within each of these.

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<sup>12</sup> This applies to variables the values on which tend to approach a 'normal' distribution.

<sup>13</sup> As the method may be applied without a sampling frame and because it relies much on the thoughtfulness and judgement of the researcher, the random walk is not an entirely random method.



## Non-random Sampling

Random sampling has in theory large advantages. In practice, it can often not be applied, or applied in full, due to lack of an adequate sampling frame or because of insufficient time and money to undertake a study based on random-selection principles.

There is virtually always a choice to be made between how many units one may cover and how deeply one may explore. Covering many units may give reliable data for the whole study population but little understanding of phenomena (such as changes, problems and opportunities). This is because one may be able to collect only few pieces of information, usually also of a mainly quantitative kind. In particular, this may be the case when one relies on assistants as interviewers. On the other hand, low coverage may give less representative information but better understanding of phenomena. In other words, one may better explain changes, problems, etc., pertaining to the studied units, because one has more time to explore them, usually through more qualitative methods.

In many evaluations, broad and shallow surveys may be little useful, because of their low ability to provide explanations and generate adequate understanding. In particular, their value may be limited for formative (learning orientated) evaluations.

A better approach to sampling will then normally be *purposive sampling* of a much smaller number of units. Based on prior knowledge of the population, the evaluator then selects units for study that he or she thinks will provide particularly relevant information. For instance, one may select persons for in-depth interviews or structured discussions who are believed to be particularly reflective, who are expected to have more knowledge about a matter than others, or who are particularly directly or strongly affected by a problem that one wants to explore. If the evaluator acquires substantial information in advance about potential study units, possibly consults others on the issue, and uses sound judgement, this is frequently the best method of sampling in evaluations of development work.

There are also other more formal methods of non-random sampling, by which one may try to retain some of the qualities of random sampling.

One such method is *quota sampling*. The evaluator may then interview a pre-determined number of persons or households in



an area (say, a village) who all have some common characteristic or combination of characteristics (say, households of more than seven members possessing below 1/2 acre of agricultural land), without specifying the persons or households in advance. The interviewer finds the interviewees by initially asking persons whom he or she meets whether they belong to the desired category, or by asking interviewees or others about people of this category whom they may be aware of. This eliminates the need for a sampling frame.

A related method is *chain sampling* (also called 'snowball sampling'). This involves incrementally tracing people who have some common attribute, without fixing in advance the number of people to be interviewed: one first finds one such person, interviews him or her, and then asks the person for others (if any) with the same attribute, to be interviewed next. This may be a good method for relatively rare units.<sup>14</sup>

Sampling of units for acquisition of information may also be a less premeditated act and may even be totally unplanned. The evaluator may observe something of importance that requires investigation because he or she 'happens' to be at the right spot at the right time, or the evaluator may learn something new because he or she 'occasionally' meets with somebody who is well informed about something important and may be keen to speak about it. The evaluator may also decide to arrange a meeting with some informants 'on the spot', because the situation turns out to be favourable for it there and then. The reader will see the connection between these means of selection and some of the methods of study that we have presented.

These are opportunities which evaluators should utilise for learning, while being conscious about getting, by the end of the information collection exercise, a reasonable amount of relevant, significant and reliable information from all important sources.

## Conclusion

In many situations, if the time and resources allow, the best approach may be to use a combination of a random sampling method and at least one non-random sampling method. The former may allow the

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<sup>14</sup> For a more detailed discussion of non-random methods of sampling in qualitative enquiry, see, for instance, the contribution by Anton J. Kuzel in Crabtree and Miller, 1992.

evaluator to draw certain conclusions which he or she can confidently say are representative of a bigger population, while the latter may permit in-depth investigation of selected units or issues.

If a combination of the two is not feasible, random sampling may have preference in most summative evaluations that emphasise general effects and impact, while purposive sampling or related non-random sampling methods should have preference in virtually all other instances.



## Chapter 13

# ECONOMIC TOOLS OF ASSESSMENT

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### INTRODUCTION

In Chapter 11 mention was made of main economic tools of evaluation, namely, benefit–cost and cost-effectiveness analysis. The preceding overview and discussion of perspectives in and methods of evaluation should have clarified that purely quantitative measures have limited applicability in evaluation of development programmes and projects. Still, I shall include in this book a brief chapter on the mentioned economic tools, for the following reasons:

First, benefit–cost analysis, in particular, has been an emphasised tool in literature on both planning and evaluation, and managers and donors have nurtured expectations of such analysis in many projects they have been responsible for, financed or evaluated. Consequently, planners and evaluators have often sought to incorporate such analysis in their wider exercises, even in the face of questionable appropriateness and/or doubtful competence in such analysis.

Second, we must duly recognise that benefit–cost and cost-effectiveness analysis do have their delimited fields of application, and may even be required in specific kinds of projects or parts of them.

Third, given (a) the strictly limited applicability of these tools and (b) the frequent emphasis on them (and the aura that has tended to surround them), I see a need for a critical examination of them in the context of evaluation of development work. Thus, a main aim of this chapter is to sensitise the reader about the restricted and, usually, subordinate role such analysis may play in most programme and project evaluation, if they are at all applicable.

The following presentation builds substantially on a presentation in Dale, 2004 (part of Chapter 9).

## BENEFIT–COST ANALYSIS

Benefit–cost analysis, as conventionally understood and normally used by economists, is a quantitative method for estimating the economic soundness of investments and/or current economic operations. Both the benefits and the costs need to be expressed in comparable monetary values.

Let us start with an example of how the method, in its most simple form, may be used for comparison of effectiveness in the development sphere. We shall here compare the profitability of cultivating alternative crops. For instance, such an exercise may be done in order to provide information to agricultural extension personnel, to help them guide the farmers in their crop selection in a relatively homogeneous environment (such as a new settlement area). This may have to be based on some evaluation of actual profitability—not just theoretical assumptions during planning. For example, the project may itself have promoted alternative crops in a pilot phase, the profitability of which may then be evaluated in order to provide inputs into subsequent planning. Or, the assessment of profitability may be based on experiences elsewhere.

The calculations are presented in Table 13.1. The table shows income and costs for a specific period (say, a season) for a specific unit of land (say, an acre).

This is a case in which benefits and costs can be relatively easily quantified. Still, upon closer examination, we find that even this simple case reveals limitations of quantitative benefit–cost analysis in the context of development work. The method requires simplifications that may be more or less acceptable or unacceptable. Thus, the benefits are considered to be equal to the income derived from the cultivation, measured in market prices. In the present example, that may be acceptable. There may, however, be other aspects of benefit that reduce the appropriateness of this measure. For instance, the households may assign an additional food security value to one or more of the crops, or one of them may have a valued soil-enriching property. Conversely, any soil-depleting effect of cultivating a crop may be considered a disadvantage (which may be viewed as a cost in a wider sense than a directly financial one). Moreover, work that has gone into the cultivation by household members has not been considered. This might have been done, but estimates of the economic value of own labour might be indicative only, as they would need to

**Table 13.1****INCOME PER HOUSEHOLD FROM AND BENEFIT-COST RATIO OF ALTERNATIVE CROPS**

|                 | Crop 1             | Crop 2 | Crop 3 |
|-----------------|--------------------|--------|--------|
|                 | Gross income 1)    |        |        |
| Market value 2) | 1000               | 1400   | 850    |
|                 | Costs 1)           |        |        |
| Hired labour    | 200                | 200    | 250    |
| Machinery 3)    | 250                | 600    | 100    |
| Fertiliser      | 150                | 150    | 100    |
| Pesticides      | 100                | 200    | 100    |
| Other           | 50                 | 50     | 0      |
| Total costs     | 750                | 1200   | 550    |
|                 | Net income         |        |        |
|                 | 250                | 200    | 300    |
|                 | Benefit-cost ratio |        |        |
|                 | 1.34               | 1.17   | 1.55   |

- 1) in a given currency, per season and per specified land unit
- 2) based on estimated yield and market price
- 3) based on estimated working hours, by type of machinery

be based on an assessed opportunity cost of labour that might be highly uncertain.<sup>1</sup>

In the presented example, only costs involved in the actual cultivation process are included, normally referred to as operating costs. The costs of any initial investment are not considered. Commonly, in development schemes, such investments are involved, posing additional challenges for benefit-cost analysis.

Moreover, development projects aim at generating long-lasting benefits. For this to happen, facilities of many kinds may need to be

<sup>1</sup> In planning, there are also other estimations and assumptions to be made, some examples of which may be, in this case: quality of the land; rainfall; marketing opportunities; and, attitude and behaviour of individual farmers. In evaluation, manifestations on these variables may become explanatory factors for findings.

maintained and most physical facilities will at some stage have to be replaced, involving additional expenses. There may also be other current or recurrent expenses, for instance, taxes and insurance payments.

Additionally, in our example, the analysis of economic performance is limited to one season only. Frequently, one season or year may not be representative for the performance over a longer period of time, since both costs and income may change or fluctuate. For instance, planting of fruit trees will involve an initial investment cost, while the trees will start to generate income after some years only.

A further important point is that we need to convert the values of costs and monetary benefits beyond the year of initiation into a common base of values at that initial time (referred to in planning as present values). Future costs and earnings become less and less worth, when considered at a given time (a point that will be readily understood by considering interest received on a deposit in a bank). This process is referred to as discounting and the rate at which the value of an item is reduced is called the discount rate. The basic principles are illustrated in Table 13.2, for another imagined project.<sup>2</sup>

| <b>Table 13.2</b><br><b>EARNINGS AND COSTS OF AN INCOME-GENERATING PROJECT</b> |                        |              |                                   |                                |                                                    |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------|--------------|-----------------------------------|--------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|
| (1)<br>Year                                                                    | (2)<br>Gross<br>income | (3)<br>Costs | (4)<br>Net<br>income<br>(2) - (3) | (5)<br>Discount<br>factors (x) | (6)<br>Present value<br>of net income<br>(4) × (5) |
| 1                                                                              | 0                      | 22145        | -22145                            | 0.893                          | -19775                                             |
| 2                                                                              | 8500                   | 4915         | 3585                              | 0.797                          | 2857                                               |
| 3                                                                              | 10500                  | 4915         | 5585                              | 0.712                          | 3977                                               |
| .                                                                              | .                      | .            | .                                 | .                              | .                                                  |
| .                                                                              | .                      | .            | .                                 | .                              | .                                                  |
| .                                                                              | .                      | .            | .                                 | .                              | .                                                  |
| 9                                                                              | 10500                  | 4915         | 5585                              | 0.361                          | 2016                                               |
| 10                                                                             | 10500                  | 4915         | 5585                              | 0.322                          | 1798                                               |
| Total of positive values                                                       |                        |              |                                   |                                | 24979                                              |
| Total of negative values                                                       |                        |              |                                   |                                | -19775                                             |
| x) at 12% discount rate                                                        |                        |              |                                   |                                |                                                    |

<sup>2</sup> The numbers in the table are borrowed, with kind permission, from Wickramanayake, 1994: 56.

The information in the table may be most easily understood when viewed at the stage of planning. In this perspective of assessed performance, the estimated lifetime (being the conventional economic term) of this project is 10 years. That may commonly mean that production is estimated to be possible over this period without any new investments, or that this is the period for which one thinks one may plan without an undue degree of uncertainty (although the facilities provided or parts of them may last longer). In this case, then, the expenses for Year 1 are for investments (for instance, in buildings, machinery and/or other equipment), while the expenses for the subsequent years are recurrent costs.

We see that identical estimated net annual incomes over Years 2–10 (at fixed prices) are calculated to have decreasing present value, based on a discount rate of 12 per cent.

The numbers in such a table may be used to calculate alternative measures of profitability. The three common ones are: the net present value (NPV); the benefit–cost ratio (B/C); and the internal rate of return (IRR).

The NPV is the difference between the total positive and negative present values. For this project, it is  $24,979 - 19,775 = 5,204$ .

A related concept is the break-even point, being the point in time at which the accumulated earnings equal the accumulated costs. In this case, the break-even point is estimated to be reached in Year 8.

The B/C (also shown in Table 13.1) is obtained by dividing the total present value of benefits (in this case, gross income) by the total present value of costs. In our example, these values are 48,367 and 43,161 respectively (not appearing in the table), and the B/C is 1.12 over the 10-year period.

The IRR is an expression of the financial return on an investment, similar to the return one may get as interest on a bank deposit, for example. It is calculated from the net income figures and may be compared with returns on alternative usage of the invested capital.<sup>3</sup>

In Table 13.3, a comparison is made of the profitability of cultivating three alternative crops. Both initial investment costs and other costs differ, and we may assume a cultivation period of four–five years.

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<sup>3</sup> The calculation will not be shown here. See Wickramanayake, 1994 for a simple clarification and Nas, 1996 for a more elaborate analysis of the concept of IRR. The former considers Actual Rate of Return (ARR) to be a more informative term.



**Table 13.3****COMPARING THE PROFITABILITY OF THREE CROPS**

|                                                                | Present value of:  |             |              |      |      |
|----------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------|-------------|--------------|------|------|
|                                                                | Initial investment | Other costs | Gross income | NPV  | B/C  |
| Crop 1                                                         | 900                | 3300        | 4100         | -100 | 0.98 |
| Crop 2                                                         | 1000               | 4800        | 6000         | 200  | 1.04 |
| Crop 3                                                         | 400                | 2400        | 3500         | 700  | 1.25 |
| NPV = <i>Net present value</i> B/C = <i>Benefit-cost ratio</i> |                    |             |              |      |      |

For the given period of cultivation, the profitability differs much. For Crop 1, the NPV is negative and the B/C is below 1. Thus, the investor would earn less from this pursuit than from saving the money at the prevailing interest rate (being also the discount rate). Crop 3 is by far the most profitable one. The result may, of course, change if we alter the cultivation period under consideration.

Limitations of the kinds that we mentioned in relation to Table 13.1 apply here as well. Still, if good information about aspects of feasibility has been acquired, financial benefit-cost analysis may be useful or even necessary for such projects as we have addressed, directly aiming at generating income.

By and large, however, the applicability for development schemes of benefit-cost analysis, in its rigorous quantitative sense, stops here. Even for income-generating projects, where financial profitability may be the core aim, financial return usually needs to be viewed in a broader context. This may include assessment of and choices between beneficiary groups of the particular scheme, any wider economic or social multiplier effects, and a range of other social, institutional, cultural and/or ecological variables.

In some instances, one may try to quantify wider economic benefits (beyond financial ones). One example may be economic multiplier effects in a local community of an increase in income from some agricultural project. Generally, however, more qualitative methods are needed to analyse broader economic changes and, more obviously, changes of a social, cultural, institutional and ecological nature. Achievements of many kinds of development schemes may just not

sensibly be given any monetary value. A few among a large number of examples may be increased consciousness and understanding, greater gender equality, enhanced organisational ability, and improved quality of a natural habitat.

## COST-EFFECTIVENESS ANALYSIS

The concept of 'cost-effectiveness' denotes the efficiency of resource use; that is, it expresses the relationship between the outcome of a thrust—in this case some development work—and the total effort by which the outcome has been attained. In the development field, the outcome may be specified as outputs, effects or impact, and the total effort may be expressed as the sum of the costs of creating those outputs or benefits. Thus far, cost-effectiveness analysis resembles benefit-cost analysis.

However, the specific question addressed in cost-effectiveness analysis is how (by what approach) one may obtain a given output or benefit (or, a set of outputs or benefits). In other words, one assumes that what one creates, through such alternative approaches, are identical facilities or qualities.

Widely understood, considerations of cost-effectiveness are crucial in development work (as in other resource-expending efforts). In any rationally conceived development thrust, one wants to achieve as much as possible with the least possible use of resources, of whatever kind. By implication, we should always carefully examine and compare the efficiency of alternative approaches, to the extent such alternatives may exist or may be created. The approaches encompass the magnitude and composition of various kinds of inputs as well as a range of activity variables, that is, by what arrangements and processes the inputs are converted into outputs and may generate benefits.

As normally defined by economists and frequently understood, cost-effectiveness analysis is a more specific and narrow pursuit, restricted to the technology by which an output (or, a set of outputs) of well-specified, unambiguous and standardised nature is produced. An example, mentioned by Cracknell (2000), is an evaluation that was undertaken of alternative technologies of bagging fertilisers at a donor-assisted fertiliser plant, basically to quantify cost differences between labour-intensive and more capital-intensive methods.

In cost-effectiveness analysis, there is no need to specify a monetary value of outputs or benefits. This is often stated to make

cost-effectiveness analysis more widely applicable and more useful in much development work than benefit–cost analysis. This is a highly questionable proposition. Used conventionally (as just clarified), cost-effectiveness analysis has very limited applicability in development work. The main reasons are:

First, although the monetary value of the outputs or benefits do not have to be estimated, what is achieved will have to be verified by some other quantitative measure (examples of which may be number of items, weight, years of intended usage, etc.). This is needed for any assumption of identical outcomes to be made at all: quantification is the only way by which standards of this nature may be established and objectively verified. This limits such analysis to, at most, only small parts of benefits that development programmes and projects normally aim at creating.

Second, even in cases where such quantitative measures may be applied, the outputs or benefits that are generated through different approaches may only rarely be identical or even close to that.

This may be a serious constraint even for clear-cut technical projects. Take, for example, alternative technologies for constructing a road. Would we expect the road's quality to be identical (*a*) when it is constructed by a large number of labourers using hand tools and (*b*) when it is built with the use of bulldozers, scrapers and compacting machines? If not, conventional cost-effectiveness analysis would here only make sense to the extent differences in quality could also be quantified, that is, to the extent the costs incurred with each technology may be related to comparable monetary values of the benefits. One would then be 'back to' benefit–cost analysis.

For more normative and broader development programmes and projects, assumptions of identical benefits would be even more problematic than in the mentioned case—even if we were able to identify clearly distinguishable alternative approaches for achieving intended benefits.

In conclusion, overall, then, effectiveness and efficiency of approaches in development work will virtually always have to be assessed more broadly than is possible through the addressed conventional tools of analysing costs and benefits.

## Chapter 14

# INDICATORS OF ACHIEVEMENT

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### THE CONCEPT OF INDICATOR AND ITS APPLICATION

The issue to be addressed in this chapter is how we may substantiate the achievements of the development work, through meaningful and trustworthy statements about what is created and the benefits of that. Such statements may vary vastly, from brief quantitative measures (even one number only) to elaborate verbal descriptions.

We shall here examine brief statements in quantitative, semi-quantitative and concise qualitative form. Moreover, the statements are simplified approximations of the phenomena that are examined. In line with common terminology, we shall refer to such statements as 'indicators'.<sup>1</sup>

Indicators may be used for two general purposes: (a) to evaluate something that has been done or changes that have taken place, and (b) to assess a future state.

In our daily lives, we use indicators for both purposes. For instance, we may express the benefit of the purchase of a new sewing machine by the quality of buttonholes we have stitched using it, and we may develop an opinion about the amount of fruits we may expect on our fruit trees in the autumn by the amount of blossoms on them in the spring.

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<sup>1</sup> For efforts to clarify 'indicator' in the development field, see Kuik and Verbruggen, 1991; Pratt and Loizos, 1992; Mikkelsen, 1995; Rubin, 1995; and NORAD, 1990; 1992; 1996. In this chapter, I shall discuss theoretical and practical aspects of indicators more comprehensively and in a more coherent manner than has been done in any of the above mentioned publications. While I draw on their contributions, the presentation and discussion is more influenced by my own experiences, largely generated through involvement in practical development work.

In science, indicators may be used similarly. For instance, in the development field, we may indicate the benefit of an investment on a road by the change of traffic on the road, and we may predict the amount of erosion in a drainage area five years later by changes that are presently occurring in the vegetative cover of the area.<sup>2</sup>

Here, we are concerned with indicators for assessing achievements of development work, that is, indicators in their retrospective sense. In evaluation, indicators are used as approximate measures of what is being or has been created during implementation, and/or what benefits are being or have been obtained by the assessed programme or project. A set of indicators for subsequent monitoring and evaluation may have been formulated at the stage of planning.<sup>3</sup> If not, or if the pre-specified indicators are considered to be inappropriate or insufficient, the evaluators may have to specify their own.

If well designed and conscientiously used, indicators are important in development work in two respects: (a) they induce planners to focus and operationalise the development scheme, and help monitoring and evaluating personnel to maintain focus in their pursuits; (b) the information provided on the indicators constitutes a concise summary of main achievements.

Normally, indicators are most comprehensively used at the highest levels of means–ends structures of development programmes and projects, that is, as approximations of benefits for people (effects and impact). Sometimes, they may also be useful, or necessary, at the level of outputs and even for expressing aspects of implementation. In addition, one may use indicators for exploring phenomena in the scheme's environment. A few examples may be:

- a teacher's brief written statement (say, a few lines per child) of changes in the children's learning capability, as an indication

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<sup>2</sup> I have also seen 'indicator' used for measures to guide decisions to be taken. For example, in the development field, a population projection might be viewed as an indicator for a decision about schools to be built. However, this usage is qualitatively different from the others, and the concept might thereby be watered down too much.

<sup>3</sup> Formulation of indicators is commonly regarded as a requirement in planning. For instance, in the logical framework—being these days a main planning tool—indicators are one of three main types of information to be provided. See Part One for a brief further clarification and Dale, 2004 for a comprehensive analysis of the logical framework.

of the effectiveness of a pilot project on innovative learning methods;

- certain stakeholders' perception of decision-making in a programme (for instance, as documented in a questionnaire survey), as an indication of the quality of management of the scheme;
- any change in the number of logging concessions awarded by a responsible government agency, as an indication of any increase in environmental awareness in the government (which may be an important assumption for a reforestation project, for instance).

More examples will be provided and discussed later in this chapter.

We have on several occasions drawn attention to the core question in development evaluation of *qualitative versus quantitative* statements. This is a highly important dimension of indicators as well.

In the natural sciences, only quantitative measures are normally considered to qualify as indicators. Some advocate this limitation for indicators when used in the social sciences also. However, if this restriction is imposed in fields where qualitative analysis is essential, it will normally mean that the indicators will not provide much information. We have repeatedly stressed the need for predominantly qualitative analysis in most development work. Consequently, if only quantitative statements are accepted here, one may end up with a poor set of measures for assessing the achievements of such work.

Therefore, we shall include statements in qualitative form in our repertoire of indicators of achievements of development programmes and projects. Among the examples given above, the teacher's verbal summary of children's performance is a qualitative indicator, while the stakeholders' perception of decision-making may be formulated qualitatively or quantitatively, depending on how the information is gathered and processed.

To the extent appropriate and useful quantitative indicators may be found, one should commonly utilise them. This is due to the brief, clear and unambiguous nature of quantitative expressions (at least those that may serve the purpose of indicators), being qualities of indicators that we are normally looking for.

The conceptualisation and use of qualitative indicators is normally a more complex matter. A basic point is that only brief and concise verbal statements may be considered as indicators. How brief and concise a statement should be to qualify will then be a matter of some judgement. This injects an amount of ambiguity into the concept,



which we may have to live with. Generally, an analysis of a number of pages would, presumably, not be considered as an indicator by anybody, while a good summary statement of one or a couple of sentences may definitely be an indicator. For instance, I would consider the following summary statement from a group discussion an indicator statement, in this case of benefits obtained from a project:

The majority of the participants said that they had got increased catches of [a fish species], by which their household's annual net income had increased, in some cases up to 50%. Many fishermen who had only small boats said that their catches had not increased, because they had to fish close to the shore.

Moreover, we have earlier mentioned that some qualitative information may not only be presented in words and sentences, but may be transformed into numerical form. This may be referred to as category-level measurement. For instance, people's answers to an open question in a survey may afterwards be grouped into a set of suitable categories—for example, 'very poor', 'poor', 'just adequate', 'good' and 'very good'. The distribution of answers across these categories may then be used as an expression (an indicator) of the performance on the variable that is examined. Through this transformation, then, information of originally complex, purely qualitative kind has been assigned the above-mentioned desired qualities of an indicator (brevity, specificity and absence of ambiguity).

Any such transformation of qualitative information into a form that we may consider an indicator is bound to render the information less comprehensive. And, considering the complex nature of most qualitative information, much of such information may not be sufficiently compressed without losing much of its analytical power.

The above restrictions constitute limitations for the construction and use of indicators, which any evaluator must be highly conscious of and carefully consider. Given (a) that good quantitative indicators of achievements of development programmes and projects are relatively rare and, (b) that only certain pieces of qualitative information may be presented in indicator form, we must conclude that indicators may usually provide only strictly limited parts of the information that needs to be generated and conveyed in evaluations.

Beside the limited amount of information contained in such statements, the main constraint of indicators is that they provide no or, at best, very limited explanations of the phenomena that are addressed. Quantitative indicators contain, in themselves, no explanation, while



any explanatory part of qualitative indicators may have to be highly general or strictly limited, similar to the formulation ‘...because they had to fish close to the shore’ in the indicator statement above. Seeking explanations for documented changes invariably involves exploration of cause–effect relations of different pattern complexities, strengths, clarity, variability, etc., which may only be possible through relatively elaborate verbal analysis.

If we do not explore well beyond indicators, we may easily fall into the trap of assuming that any changes we may find are caused by the studied programme or project. This is a feature of much evaluation that merits criticism, particularly at higher levels of means–ends structures, that is, in assessments of changes in aspects of people’s life situation.

Nevertheless, if we keep the above considerations firmly in mind, well conceptualised, and formulated and appropriately used indicators may be helpful tools in many evaluations—for the mentioned reasons of sharpening one’s focus, clarifying certain matters and, not least, making parts of complex information more readily accessible to its users.

There are close relations between types of indicators that we may decide to use, and *methods* that may be applied for generating information on them. Quantitative measures are normally considered objectively verifiable; that is, by following a clearly prescribed procedure, any qualified person should arrive at exactly the same result. The more qualitative the indicators are, the more difficult and even unrealistic this becomes. Consequently, in the development field, objective verification will be the exception rather than the rule. In such instances, we will, then, need to substantiate our findings as well as may be possible through *methods* that involve greater or lesser amounts of subjective judgement. If we want to address core issues and obtain a reasonably good understanding, there is frequently no alternative. All normal rules of good qualitative analysis will, of course, apply. Compressing findings into indicators will be a related challenge. To that end, one will need skills in synthesising information and the ability of succinct verbal formulation.

## CHARACTERISTICS OF GOOD INDICATORS

For indicators to serve their intended purpose, they should, to a reasonable extent, meet certain quality criteria. In addition to the

general ones that we have already mentioned, the main more specific criteria are: relevance; significance; reliability and convenience.

The *relevance* of an indicator denotes whether, or to what extent, the indicator reflects (is an expression of) the phenomenon that it is intended to substantiate. Embedded in this may be how direct an expression it is of the phenomenon and whether it relates to the whole phenomenon or only to some part of it (that is, its coverage).

An indicator's *significance* means how important an expression the indicator is of the phenomenon it aims at substantiating. Core questions are whether it needs or ought to be supplemented with other indicators of the same phenomenon, and whether it says more or less about the phenomenon than other indicators that may be used.

An indicator's *reliability* expresses the trustworthiness of the information that is generated on it. High reliability normally means that the same information may be acquired by different competent persons, independently of each other, and often also that comparable information may be collected at different points in time (for instance, immediately after the completion of a project and during subsequent years). Moreover—connecting to the presented defining features of indicators—the information that is generated on the indicator must be unambiguous, and it should be possible to present the information terms that are so clear that it is taken to mean the same by all who use it.

The *convenience* of an indicator denotes how easy or difficult it is to work with. In other words, it expresses the effort that goes into generating the intended information, being closely related to the method or methods that may be used for that. The effort may be measured in monetary terms (by the cost involved), or it may constitute some combination of financial resources, expertise, and time that is required.

'Reliability' and 'convenience' relate to the means by which information on the respective indicators is generated; that is, they are directly interfaced with aspects of methodology. Some indicators are tied to one method of study, while others may be studied using one among several alternative methods or a combination of methods.

The feasibility of generating adequate information on specified indicators may differ greatly between the method or methods used. The quality of the information may also depend on, or be influenced by, a range of other factors, such as the amount of resources deployed

for analysis and the analysts' qualification, interest and sincerity. It may also vary substantially between societies.

## EXAMPLES OF INDICATORS

We shall clarify the formulation and use of indicators further through some examples of proposed indicators (among many more that could have been proposed), relating to three intended achievements. These are presented in Table 14.1.<sup>4</sup> For each indicator, appropriateness or adequacy is suggested, on each of the quality criteria we have specified. A simple four-level rating scale is used, where 3 signifies the highest score and 0 no score (meaning entirely inappropriate or inadequate).

Note that the scores under 'relevance' and 'significance' are given under the assumption that reasonably reliable information is provided.

| <p><b>Table 14.1</b></p> <p><b>ASSESSED QUALITY OF SELECTED INDICATORS</b></p>   |                  |                     |                    |                    |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------|---------------------|--------------------|--------------------|
| <b>Intended achievement<br/>Indicator</b>                                        | <b>Relevance</b> | <b>Significance</b> | <b>Reliability</b> | <b>Convenience</b> |
| <i>The nutrition level of children below 6 years is improved</i>                 |                  |                     |                    |                    |
| Upper arm circumference                                                          | 3                | 2                   | 3                  | 3                  |
| Number of meals per day                                                          | 1–2              | 1–2                 | 2                  | 2–3                |
| <i>Women's consciousness about gender relations in their society is enhanced</i> |                  |                     |                    |                    |
| Analyst's judgement from group discussion                                        | 3                | 2                   | 1–2                | 1–2                |
| Women's answers to pre-specified questions                                       | 3                | 2                   | 2                  | 2–3                |
| <i>People's organisations are functioning well</i>                               |                  |                     |                    |                    |
| Analyst's judgement of observed practice                                         | 3                | 3                   | 1–3                | 2                  |
| Attendance at member meetings                                                    | 0–3              | 0–2                 | 3                  | 3                  |

<sup>4</sup> The examples are borrowed from Dale, 2004 (Chapter 7).

## Nutrition Status

Upper arm circumference is a scientifically well-recognised measure of the nutrition status of young children. The indicator is therefore highly *relevant*. On *significance*, a score of 2 (rather than 3) is given because the indicator still ought to be supplemented with other measures (such as weight and height by age and, if possible, changes in nutrition-related illnesses), for fuller information. The circumference is arrived at through simple direct quantitative measurement, and this may be repeated endlessly by persons who know how to measure. Therefore, under normal circumstances, we would consider the information on this indicator as highly *reliable*. Assuming that the children may be reached relatively easily, and that the work is well organised, the information may also be acquired fairly quickly and at a low cost for large numbers of children. Consequently, this will normally be a highly *convenient* indicator as well.

The number of meals per day is normally of some *relevance* and *significance* for assessing changes in nutrition level, since eating is necessary for consuming nutrients. However, the relation between eating habits and nutrition may vary substantially, between societies and even between households in the same society, for a range of reasons. The relevance and the significance of the indicator will thus vary accordingly. In most contexts, this measure may at best be used as a supplement to other indicators. The *convenience* of the indicator may vary with the methods used for generating information on it. With a questionnaire survey, the information may be collected relatively quickly and easily; if one in addition includes observation (which may be appropriate in this case), more time will normally be needed. The *reliability* of the information may normally be acceptable, but in most cases hardly very high, due to factors such as different perceptions of what a meal is or, sometimes, people's reluctance to give correct answers.

## Women's Consciousness about Gender Relations

An analyst's judgement from group discussions<sup>5</sup> must be considered as highly *relevant*, under the assumptions that the judgement is made

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<sup>5</sup> To be termed an indicator, we assume that the judgement is presented in a summarised form.

by a competent person and that it is based on a substantial discussion in the groups about the issue to be analysed. The information will then also be *significant*. However, when using such highly qualitative indicators, information ought to be generated through more than one method, and if possible also by more than one person, for the matter to be considered as being well explored.<sup>6</sup> For that reason, we have indicated a score of 2 (rather than 3) on the 'significance' criterion. If only one group discussion is conducted, the *reliability* of the information on such a complex matter may be rather low; if several discussions are arranged, it may increase substantially. The reliability also tends to depend substantially on aspects of design and implementation, such as the composition of the group of participants and the facilitation of the discussion. If applied on a large scale, this method of information generation may be rather inconvenient (its *convenience* may be low): usually, it is time-consuming to organise such exercises and to generate substantial information from them. Often, therefore, the method may be most suitable as a supplement to other methods, for exploring relatively specific issues deeper.

Changes in women's awareness may also be traced through pre-formulated questions to the women, in a questionnaire survey. The answers to the pre-specified questions may then be presented as a frequency distribution on an ordinal measurement scale (by category-level measurement—see earlier). If the questionnaire is well focused and the survey is properly conducted, the women's answers will be highly *relevant*. Simultaneously, the information from a survey may not be considered *sufficient*, that is, *significant* enough: although the questions may address relevant matters, the information may be relatively shallow, since issues tend not to be explored comprehensively in such surveys. Question-based information may be more *reliable* than that from a group discussion, since it is, normally, more representative for various groups and often also more clearly expressed. Moreover, questionnaire surveys are usually a more *convenient* method than group discussions. However, the intricate nature of the presently explored matter may complicate the survey substantially, compared with a survey of more overt and more clearly delimited variables.

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<sup>6</sup> As mentioned earlier as well, such multi-method approaches are often referred to as 'triangulation'.

## Functioning of People's Organisations

For assessing the functioning of people's organisations, one indicator may be professional judgement of observed practice. Well planned and conducted observations by competent persons are often an effective method of generating both highly *relevant* and *significant* information about organisational performance. Consequently, we have given this indicator the top score on both these criteria. The *reliability*, though, may vary greatly. Like for other qualitative indicators (such as the above-mentioned 'analyst's judgement from group discussions'), the trustworthiness of the generated information will be highly sensitive to aspects of design and implementation. The *convenience* of the indicator may be intermediate, considering alternative methods that may be used.

Attendance at meetings by the membership is a frequently used indicator of the performance of member organisations. This is largely because one may quantify meeting attendance easily, quickly and in unambiguous terms. Consequently, under normal circumstances, this indicator scores high on *reliability* and *convenience*. When participation in the meetings is entirely or primarily driven by a genuine sense of purpose and high interest in the organisation's affairs, this indicator is also highly *relevant* and in addition clearly *significant*. However, it may hardly ever be significant enough to be given the highest score on this criterion, since there will always be numerous aspects of performance that attendance at meetings may not reflect, at all or adequately. Moreover, if the attendance is entirely or primarily driven by other motives than those just mentioned (for instance, to receive some short-term personal benefit, such as a loan), this indicator may even convey distorted or misleading information regarding an organisation's performance. Thus, in such extreme situations, it might be entirely irrelevant and insignificant.



## Chapter 15

# MANAGEMENT OF EVALUATIONS

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### A CONVENTIONAL DONOR APPROACH

Systematic evaluation of development work was introduced by donor agencies for projects that they supported in developing countries. The evaluations were entirely or mainly organised by these agencies as well. This has tended to remain so, for much development work in these countries.

Box 15.1 provides an example of how evaluations of projects supported by foreign government or government-linked organisations have tended to be planned and co-ordinated.

#### **Box 15.1**

##### **EVALUATION MANAGEMENT: A CONVENTIONAL STATE DONOR APPROACH**

- An article on evaluation, proposed by the donor, is incorporated into the agreement for a project between the overall responsible ministry in the project country and the donor. The article specifies one mid-term and one final evaluation of the project. Both exercises are stated to be the joint responsibility of the mentioned ministry and the donor.
- In due course, the donor reminds the ministry of the joint commitment to the mid-term evaluation and the need to start planning for it.
- The donor—through its technical department and the respective country unit in the head office and the development co-operation unit of the embassy in the project country—then works out a proposal for terms of reference for the evaluation and forwards

(Box 15.1 contd.)



(Box 15.1 contd.)

this to the ministry. The latter circulates the proposal and deals with it in accordance with its own procedures, and then returns it to the donor with any comments it may have.

- In the meantime, the donor has inquired with consultants about the possibility of their serving on the evaluation team.
- The donor makes any modifications to the terms of reference and sends it once more to the other party, reminding them to recruit their representative to the evaluation team and proposing a joint signing of the terms of reference, should there be no further comments to the revised version of it.
- The director of the appropriate ministry then signs the agreement on behalf of the ministry and returns it to the donor for signature by the appropriate person of the appropriate body on the donor side.
- Team members are simultaneously recruited by both parties and their curricula vitae are forwarded to the other party for mutual information.
- In due course, the donor receives a draft of the evaluation report from the evaluation team, conveys any comments it may have to the evaluators, and requests its partner to do the same.
- Any such comments are dealt with by the evaluation team, after which a final evaluation report is submitted to the donor, which subsequently forwards copies of the report to the partner ministry.
- While the procedure for commissioning and organising the evaluation is elaborate and highly formalised, there are no corresponding provisions for follow-up of the evaluation towards any agreed actions linked to its conclusions and recommendations. Reference is made to the evaluation report in subsequent partner meetings, but little specific action is taken that is clearly linked to the report.
- Before long, the report is physically and mentally shelved, even by the donor. And soon, a similar process is started for the final evaluation.

The official inter-governmental character of such development schemes makes for an elaborate legal and organisational framework. It also creates an amount of formal distance communication that may take a long time and consume substantial administrative resources. While

the management of our case may seem complex, that scenario does assume a fairly uninterrupted flow of information and documents and timely attention to matters. That assumption rarely holds. In practice, there tend to be delays in initiatives and responses, formal reminders are issued, actions are sought to be expedited through informal contacts, and various queries may be raised and additional discussions held. Delays of evaluations are, therefore, common.

Sometimes, in order to have evaluations done as scheduled, procedural shortcuts may be resorted to. Since the initiative tends to be mainly with the donor and most preparatory work is done by that agency, such shortcuts tend to leave the donor in even greater command.

Comparable private development support organisations—usually referred to as non-governmental organisations (NGOs)—may apply less elaborate procedures. This may be because they are commonly more directly involved in the schemes to be evaluated and because they normally have simpler administrative routines—internally as well as in interaction with their partners. While larger international NGOs, at least, tend to apply the same basic principles of and perspectives on evaluation as government agencies do, the management of the evaluations is usually simpler.

Commonly, work programmes and other practical arrangements that the commissioning partners prepare for the evaluators, once they are able to start their work, are rather formal, and may also be constraining in many ways. Most problematic may be a frequent bias towards communication with top administrators and managers. Thereby, crucial issues at the field or beneficiary level may remain unexposed or may even be clouded or misrepresented by these main informants and discussion partners. This bias is often reinforced by little time for information generation, often leading to meetings with large groups of diverse stakeholders, hasty field visits for observation, and little opportunity of applying other methods of inquiry. A further criticism-worthy feature has sometimes been a tendency on the part of the donor, in particular, to interfere with the final conclusions, through a provision (mentioned in the box) of providing comments to a draft of the evaluation report, which the evaluators may feel obliged to accept in the final version of their report.

Still, of course, many evaluations that have been conducted in conformity with the mentioned principles and routines have been useful. In spite of arrangements that may have been constraining,

evaluators have done good work and submitted insightful reports. In many cases, the usefulness of evaluation reports has most of all depended on the extent to which and how conclusions and recommendations have been addressed and, if warranted, acted upon in practical work. That has varied tremendously. Often, of course, there has been more constructive follow-up than in the case presented in our box.

Nevertheless, a main impression I am left with, after several years in this field, is that many evaluations have tended to be seen basically as an administrative requirement, to be fulfilled through a set of highly formalised provisions and procedures. Thereby, questions pertaining to usefulness and use may have been of secondary concern, at most. Often, the assessments have appeared to be largely a ritual that one has felt obliged to observe, for some obscure purpose of maintaining one's organisation's accountability.

## OPTIONS FOR IMPROVEMENT

There is a need to broaden perspectives on how evaluation of development work may be organised and managed. In developing countries, the donor domination and the 'officialdom' characterising most programme and project evaluations—particularly assessments initiated and administered by government-based agencies—tends to be restricting in many ways. Restrictions include the number of evaluations that may be undertaken (due to the cumbersome administration of them and often also their high cost), persons who may be involved, methods that may be applied and the way the evaluations are followed up.

First, development organisations in developing countries should themselves consider evaluations to be an important *supplementary tool to monitoring*, for learning as well as for ensuring accountability, primarily vis-à-vis the population whom they are mandated to serve or have chosen to assist.

Second, and closely related, there are in many instances good arguments for *simpler organisation* of evaluations. It may often be fruitful to distinguish between highly formal exercises primarily serving the above-mentioned needs of bureaucracies, and exercises that are decided on and conducted through simpler mechanisms. The latter may provide important supplementary information to that which is generated by the former. These more flexible and organisationally simpler evaluations may even partly or wholly replace the more

conventional ones, because they may be more effective in generating information that even ministries and donor agencies need. In the case of donor assisted schemes, provisions may have to be made for such alternative forms of evaluation in the respective programme or project agreements.

In this category of more flexible and less formal evaluations may fall:

- evaluations that the programme or project management or any donor (usually in consultation with the management) may decide on quickly and at any time, in order to investigate, in principle, any identified issue;
- evaluations, of various components or issues, that the management may plan for at regular intervals, say, at annual planning events of programmes with process planning, and which are then conducted in the course of a specified period, say, the following year;<sup>1</sup>
- regularly recurrent (say, annual) assessments, primarily involving programme or project staff.

Exercises of this nature are sometimes called reviews rather than evaluations. They are primarily formative: their main purpose being usually to learn in order to improve subsequent performance of the evaluated scheme. They are therefore particularly well suited to use in a variety of programmes (such as 'regular' departmental schemes in various fields, multi-sectoral area based programmes, community development programmes, etc.) and for assessing institutional performance in programmes and projects that aim at institution-building.

Furthermore, in order to institutionalise evaluations properly, it may in some development schemes be advantageous to employ an *evaluation co-ordinator*. The main direct purpose may be to have the co-ordinator initiate and organise such flexible or recurrent evaluations that we have just mentioned. A separate evaluation co-ordinator may be most applicable in flexible programmes and big phased projects. In some such schemes the co-ordinator may even lead an *evaluation unit*. Such arrangements may also help connect evaluations to current monitoring of the respective programme or project. One

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<sup>1</sup> A case of a programme with such a mechanism built into it was presented in Chapter 2 (Box 2.1).

unit may even be placed in overall charge of both monitoring and evaluation, which will imply a more direct current operational role of this unit (and a concomitant change of name).

Moreover, whenever the learning aspect is important, it may be highly beneficial to secure *involvement of programme or project responsible persons* in the evaluation, other than any evaluation co-ordinator. Simultaneously, however, responsible agencies may benefit from perspectives and insights of competent outside persons. Outsiders will in addition bring in an amount of independent judgement, which may also be highly important also in evaluations whose main aim is to help improve the performance of the evaluated scheme. It may therefore often be fruitful to have evaluation teams consisting of *both insiders and outsiders*.

Additionally, intended beneficiaries may often have important information to give, even for programmes and projects that are basically planned from above (that is, without any or much involvement on their part). *Direct participation by beneficiaries* may therefore be advantageous in many evaluations. Of course, intended beneficiaries are usually interviewed or consulted in other ways in evaluations, particularly for assessing effects and impact. But if sufficient time is allocated for it and their participation is well organised, people may often contribute more comprehensively with their own analysis. This has methodological implications, which we have already examined.

Development work that is undertaken by local community organisations and any other member organisations (people's organisations) may also benefit from formalised evaluations. These may take the form of *self-assessments* (sometimes referred to as 'internal evaluations'), possibly with the engagement of a co-ordinator for the purpose, who may in such contexts be referred to as a *facilitator*. We shall, in the following section, provide an example of such a self-assessment.

Such direct involvement in evaluation by primary stakeholders may be an important mechanism for organisational learning. Additionally, it may help ensure that the evaluation addresses relevant and important matters. For community-based and other institution-building schemes, in particular, this links onto our earlier discussion of rationalities (in Chapter 1): community-led work may, we remember, be more or less underpinned by a different kind of rationality than other development thrusts, referred to as 'lifeworld rationality'. This

rationality may have to be expressed by those who are familiar with it, that is, the local inhabitants or organisations' members themselves—although, to be accessible to an audience of outsiders, the reasoning and conclusions may have to be mediated and finally formulated by a 'professional' analyst.

In fact, from the point of view of actors and actor constellations, evaluations may be viewed as located on a continuum from entirely externally managed to entirely internally managed exercises.

Finally, in evaluations involving external expertise, there may be room for *more significant roles of scholars* from universities and similar institutions (both staff and students) in evaluating development work. In fact, much so-called development research is evaluative, but most of it is considered by development planners and managers to be of little importance to the work that they do. For university researchers to play a more important role, two major conditions must be fulfilled to a greater extent than they tend to be at present:

- recognition by researchers and practitioners of each other's requirements and capabilities;
- a concern in universities, particularly within the social sciences, about the relevance of their work for societal development and development practice.

An important aspect of the second point is to view professionalism not primarily as a command over research conventions (including methods and techniques), but even more as an ability to conceptualise, sort, combine and reflect on the real problems of people and on development issues and measures of concern to them. A related, highly important point is that, through relevant exposure and training in their study days, university students may become motivated and more capable of helping introduce appropriate evaluation systems in development organisations in which many of them will be working later. Immediately below, a perspective on research-linked evaluation of development schemes will be presented, through documentation of one case.

## TWO ALTERNATIVE SCENARIOS

We shall now outline two alternative management scenarios of evaluation of development work. This will be done through two cases,



briefly described in Boxes 15.2 and 15.3). Both case programmes are community-focused thrusts, with emphasis on institution-building. I have chosen this kind of programme (as I have done in other contexts as well) because it raises pertinent questions of approach and management, including management of evaluations. But matters and issues that are illustrated have much wider applicability, particularly in other kinds of institution-building schemes but also other types of development work.

### An Action Research Scenario

Box 15.2 provides a case of action-oriented evaluatory research by a university professional. Conceived as a formative evaluation of a development programme, the researcher seeks to employ an approach that should make the study as directly useful as possible for the stakeholders of that programme. An overall intention—expressed in the initial research proposal and elsewhere—is to try to bridge the gaps that tend to exist between study approaches of practitioners and those of academicians, in accordance with ingrained academic conventions. Additionally, the research seeks to challenge a weakness of both: the short time horizons that tend to dominate in studies of development processes and societal changes. The nature of the studied programme—a complex, long-term and changing community institution-building thrust—calls for a much longer time perspective for assessing achievements. It also calls for substantial deviations from much conventional academic practice, in terms of a basically qualitative and flexible approach and an interactive mode of communication with programme stakeholders. Simultaneously, sound academic principles and practices are sought to be adhered to, including use of study methods with proven qualities.

The box text should be self-explanatory, and it should require no further elaboration for fulfilling its intended function, namely, sensitising the reader to one alternative perspective on evaluation, with a range of practical implications.

### A Self-Assessment Scenario

Box 15.3 provides an example of a self-assessment (internal evaluation) by members of externally promoted community organisations of development work that they are doing.



### **Box 15.2**

#### **EVALUATION MANAGEMENT: AN ACTION RESEARCH SCENARIO**

- A university professional conceptualises evaluatory research of a donor assisted development programme. The programme aims at building local community organisations that are to work for improving the living conditions of their members. The research is intended to be long-term and action oriented, providing information about performance of the membership organisations as well as effects and impact for the membership, and using that information for inducing improved performance whenever warranted.
- Accordingly, in consultation with the programme management, the researcher works out a proposal for an open-ended study, with a work plan and budget for the first three years. This is then submitted to the programme donor with a request for funding of the fieldwork, information analysis and report writing.
- In fulfilment of the purpose of the research, the researcher decides to study a fixed set (a panel) of people's organisations and members over many years. Interviews and discussions are to be conducted with office-bearers and members of the sampled organisations and with programme staff. Much time is also intended to be used for observation—of organisational proceedings, members' activities, etc. Additionally, unscheduled exploration may be undertaken anywhere of any matter whenever this may be important for gaining insight. For the sake of effective long-term accumulation of knowledge and understanding, the researcher decides to do all the fieldwork himself, that is, not relying on others to 'gather data' for further processing. (Simultaneously, students of the researcher are invited to study specific aspects of the programme, with the aim of providing complementary information.)
- Equipped with a research grant for a three-year period, the researcher starts his fieldwork. In spite of earlier familiarisation, he realises that he needs much time initially to informally explore aspects of the programme, as a basis for the final selection of the panel of study units, formulating the questionnaires, etc. For this reason, and because he may devote only relatively short periods at a time for this research, he is able to start formal interviewing and related activities with the fixed sample of study units only half a year after he had originally thought to do so.

(Box 15.2 contd.)

(Box 15.2 contd.)

- In the course of the study, the researcher generates information about so many issues (including problems) of support strategy, organisation, member perceptions, member activities, etc., and gets so entangled in discussing and analysing them that he decides to become even more action oriented. To this end, he starts writing informal feedback reports (called notes) to the programme management; undertakes a couple of additional unscheduled visits to the programme area, primarily for informal further exploration and discussion of matters; and explicitly performs the role of an engaged stakeholder.
- During the study process, the attitude of most programme staff vis-à-vis the researcher changes from rather shallow politeness (like the one commonly displayed in front of formal evaluation teams) to enthusiastic collaboration, with a view to sharing and discussing knowledge and experiences for the sake of programme improvement. The members of the community organisations are positive and keen to provide information and discuss throughout.
- At the end of the three-year study period, the researcher writes a full research report, which is published as a booklet and distributed widely—within the programme, to other organisations and individuals involved in similar programmes, among students in the researcher's university, and some others.
- The researcher also collates much of the information (both quantitative and qualitative) that has been generated from each study unit in standardised information forms, intended to be built on in subsequent rounds of study.
- While most of the donor's support to the programme had stopped by the end of the three-year study period, the programme itself is evolving and grappling with crucial questions of organisation and financial sustainability. The researcher thinks he has acquired a good knowledge and information basis for continuing to provide inputs into the development of a more effective and sustainable programme. To that end, he is eager to continue his study, building on his systematised material from the first rounds of study. The challenge may be to get more financial support for this from the long-time donor agency. If not, the opportunity for exploiting this innovative thrust to gain further insight into programme matters and help secure the programme's relevance, effectiveness and sustainability may be lost as also its potential significance for similar programmes elsewhere.

**Box 15.3****EVALUATION MANAGEMENT:  
A SELF-ASSESSMENT SCENARIO**

- Over a number of years, a department of the country's government has been implementing a country-wide institution-building programme, aiming at establishing local community societies for the economic improvement of the societies' members. The main mechanism for this has been accumulation of society funds, from which money has been lent to the members for investment in production assets and inputs. The major support facilities of the programme have been deployment of community organisers and provision of capital to the societies' fund, intended to supplement the members' own savings into their fund.
- A reasonably good financial monitoring system has been in place, and in addition a rudimentary and largely fictitious system for reporting on investment profiles, etc., and even changes in income of the members' households. The department has primarily considered these measures as control mechanisms, while the societies have viewed the reporting basically as a burden—for which reason they have also tended to put as little effort into it as possible.
- A couple of years earlier, a fairly comprehensive evaluation of the programme was also done by a national research institution, commissioned by the department. This had the same quantitative bias as the monitoring system, and it extracted and processed data primarily for the department. However, the team's report seems to have been quickly shelved, and it remains unclear whether it has ever been used much for programme-related purposes.
- At a meeting of one district association of societies, a member asks whether the societies could not generate information about performance and benefits that would be useful to themselves, rather than spending so much time on 'useless' reporting to the department. While most meeting participants consider the latter as unavoidable, the idea of some kind of self-assessment arouses wider interest, and it is subsequently decided to take an initiative to that end.
- As a first step, the community organiser is consulted. He is positive, and consults a former education director on the matter.

(Box 15.3 contd.)

(Box 15.3 contd.)

She expresses a willingness to help organise and conduct (co-ordinate) a study, along the lines the members want, against a very modest remuneration. After further discussion, it is decided to undertake a 'progress evaluation' focusing on central programme matters, with inputs for and by the membership. All except a couple of largely defunct societies agree to participate.

- A simple questionnaire is constructed by the hired co-ordinator and association representatives. Within each society, the exercise is then conducted through the following main steps: (a) a survey, using this questionnaire, is undertaken by one selected member (having also been briefly trained for the task by the co-ordinator); (b) the results of the survey are compiled in a simple standard form by the mentioned member, assisted by the finance officer of the respective societies and the co-ordinator; (c) this roughly processed information is presented for and discussed by the full forum of society members, in a half-day workshop; (d) in most societies, groups of interested members are formed to follow up specific matters emanating from the forum discussion; (e) following these group discussions, a second forum meeting is arranged, in which the groups present their recommendations, being then further discussed and in some cases modified.
- After some time, a workshop is organised by the district association of societies, in which the core members of the exercise in the individual societies participate. Matters are further discussed, and the co-ordinator (who has participated in all organised events) is entrusted with the task of summing up the main conclusions and recommendations of the entire exercise.
- The brief report that follows is then provided in three copies to each of the participating societies, with a general request for them to follow-up matters of concern to themselves, in subsequent meetings and other forums of the respective societies. More specifically, the societies are requested to undertake formal quarterly or semi-annual reviews in relation to matters in the report, the outcome of which are also intended to be brought to and discussed by the society association.

There are some matters of general significance that should be noted:

In this case, the assessment is initiated from within the membership, in reaction to a top-down approach to information generation

and a perceived ‘uselessness’ of that approach for the member organisations themselves. That may often be the ideal starting point. In other instances, the organisations may be sensitised and induced to evaluate what they do by an external person, such as a programme facilitator.

In this case also, an external person is brought in subsequently, to help the societies organise and conduct the assessment. We may refer to such facilitation as ‘co-ordination’ in the broad sense of the term.<sup>2</sup> If this person plays a genuine facilitation role, his or her involvement will not undermine the self-assessment character of the exercise, but will, instead, help empower the members for the thrust (and possibly also additional similar and even other activities of their organisations).

Additionally, evaluation by non-professionals requires clarity and simplicity of the approach and methods used. These qualities will also facilitate effective internal communication. In fact, this calls for maximum use of simple quantitative measures of performance and achievements. Limitations of such measures, emphasised in Chapter 14, may also be of much less concern in such cases of self-assessment: for the members, these measures are just simple, easily understood and communication-promoting indicators of a context-rich reality of directly lived experiences—being, of course, of a profoundly qualitative nature. The indicators are, thus, unlikely to be allowed to ‘live their own life’, as they may do for a professional researcher who may base his or her whole analysis on them.

Finally, in our case, we see that arrangements are proposed for systematic follow-up of the assessment—again, by the member organisations themselves. We have earlier argued that little attention to follow-up has often been a major shortcoming in programme and project evaluation. Our remaining concern, then, is that the proposed follow-up measures are actually implemented.<sup>3</sup>

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<sup>2</sup> Dale (2000) operationalises such a broad perspective on co-ordination, in terms of a set of alternative or complementary mechanisms implemented through one or more tasks.

<sup>3</sup> The two cases of alternative approaches that have been presented in this section may be supplemented with three other cases that we have presented earlier, to primarily illuminate other issues in other contexts. They are a case of a formalised system of formative evaluations in a programme with process planning (Box 2.1) and two cases of participatory monitoring/evaluation (Box 3.1), quite different from the one we have presented here. The reader may now want to go over these cases again, in the perspective of the topic of the present chapter.

## THE EVALUATION REPORT

The outcome of evaluations needs to be reported. That is normally done in some document—the evaluation report—and often also orally.

The big differences in the scope and organisation of evaluations make it impossible to recommend standard formats for evaluation reports. In particular, reports from participatory exercises must be allowed to take their individual forms, reflecting the participants' perspectives and abilities. Moreover, in cases of internal formative evaluation, in particular, what is written may be very sketchy, serving the purpose of a framework for primarily oral reporting and follow-up.

Nevertheless, documentation in writing is normally a requirement. It is then essential that the report covers the matters and issues that were intended to be addressed in the evaluation, for instance, as stated in a Terms of Reference (ToR) for the study. Moreover, the presentation of the material is important—for arousing interest, for prompting people to read what is written with attention, for helping the reader understand messages as easily as possible, and to enable the reader to judge the coverage, relevance and reliability of the information provided. In most cases, a good moderator-cum-analyst, if given the primary responsibility for report writing, may make good presentations of even highly participatory evaluations.

The following may be a useful overview of the main general principles that one should seek to adhere to as much as is possible:

- clarifying well and maintaining the *focus* and *scope* of the report;
- *structuring* the report well, in terms of a clear arrangement of chapters and a logical *sequence* of arguments;
- discussing briefly and pointedly the strengths and weaknesses of the *methods* used and the quality of both primary and secondary *information*;
- *tailoring the presentation* to the needs and the analytical abilities of those who are to use the report and, in cases of different users, trying to ensure that the writing is understandable even to those who may have the lowest reading skills;
- writing relatively comprehensive but pointed *conclusions*—usually in a final chapter or section—which should contain a summary of the main findings, any additional related reflections and, whenever called for, well substantiated recommendations;



- writing only briefly on *matters of subordinate importance* to the analysis, or even skipping writing about them altogether—in order to avoid disruption of the flow of main arguments or prevent undue attention to such matters;
- placing any additional information of less importance, very detailed information, or information that may be of interest to only some readers in *annexures*—where it can be accessed as supplementary information by anybody who may want to do so;
- informing well about outside *sources of information*, while avoiding to link any sensitive or survey-based information to individuals;
- whenever appropriate, *facilitating reading* and emphasising main points through clear *tables* and *graphical illustrations* (which need not be professional layout-wise).

In broad *summary*, the above may be compressed into ensuring clarity and consistency of focus, scope and lines of argumentation; writing as simply and pointedly as possible; facilitating reading and understanding through any additional means; and enabling understanding and judgement of the report in its context.

With direct reference to ‘development cooperation projects, programs and policies’, Eggers (2000a; 2000b; 2002) states that the ToR for evaluations should reflect three overriding principles of management of development schemes—referred to as Project Cycle Management (PCM) principles. The three PCM principles are:

- the specific objective (purpose)<sup>4</sup> of the schemes must always be expressed in terms of sustainable benefits for the intended beneficiaries (called the master principle, also referred to in Chapters 1 and 4);
- all the essential criteria for successful project/programme preparation, implementation and evaluation should be considered;
- there should be a sound decision-making discipline all along the project/programme cycle.

Being underlying principles of the ToR for evaluations, these principles should, of course, also be reflected in the contents of the

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<sup>4</sup> See Chapter 4, in which we have used a slightly different terminology pertaining to objectives.



respective evaluation reports. Moreover, each of the principles finds its operational expression in what Eggers calls the three PCM instruments: (a) the 'logical framework'; (b) the 'basic format'; and (c) the 'format of phases and decisions'. In the present context, the second instrument is relevant and significant, in terms of also influencing the structuring of the evaluation reports (not just their contents). The main headings of the format are: summary; background (also addressing relevance); intervention (including economy, efficiency, effectiveness, impact and sustainability); assumptions; implementation; factors ensuring sustainability; economic and financial viability; monitoring and evaluation; and conclusions and proposals.

Eggers' perspective on PCM (being a more widely used concept) represents a well-focused and comprehensive conception of overall sound programme and project management in the development sphere. The mentioned format may be a particularly good guide for the structuring and formulation of plan documents, across a wide range of programmes and projects. The format may also be a useful checklist of matters to be addressed in comprehensive evaluation reports (normally, then, also of relatively large programmes and projects), although the structure of any evaluation report will deviate from it. In particular, aspects of efficiency, effectiveness and impact will have to build on clarification of inputs, work tasks, aspects of implementation, etc. Eggers himself also stresses that the format is a highly general and flexible one, to be modified according to needs in specific contexts.

To the extent the concerns expressed by our general evaluation categories (relevance, effectiveness, impact, efficiency, sustainability and replicability) are intended to be addressed, they should guide the structuring of the evaluation reports, sometimes even to the extent of the category names being made headings of main analytical chapters. More commonly, though, it may be more appropriate to use more specific or elaborate chapter and section headings, being more telling in the specific context.

Relating to my own experience, I want to attach brief comments on a couple of related more specific matters:

First, I have noted a tendency among 'professional' evaluators to load their reports with factual descriptions of aspects of the assessed programme or project: its history; detailed investment pattern; facilities created, and similar things. That may be appropriate if one of the main purposes of the report is to promote knowledge about the

scheme among some outside or peripherally involved people. In most cases, however, that is a secondary concern, at most. In evaluations with a formative intent, it may be of no concern at all. Still, descriptions of such facts tend to constitute large parts of the reports—even when the users of the reports are obviously more knowledgeable about them than are the evaluators. This makes the reports unnecessarily long and distracts both the evaluators and the readers from the matters of real concern. And even when outward dissemination of factual information is considered to be important, it is usually most appropriate to present only a relatively general picture in the main body of the report and include any additional details that may be warranted in annexures.

Second, there is a convention in donor-commissioned evaluations to have reports start with an ‘executive summary’. This provision is clearly rooted in the traditional donor notion of evaluation as a means of summing up ‘the truth’ about supported programmes and projects, to be communicated by analysts from the field level to the top levels of decision-making and administration. Brief summaries of facts, arguments and judgements may be an obvious need for top administrators of big organisations. All too often, however, people who would need the kind of insight that only a more comprehensive argument and discussion may provide, avail themselves of the opportunity to read only this summary.

I would suggest a two-fold solution to this dilemma. The first measure, in most instances, should be to drop the ‘executive summary’ and instead write a more comprehensive and insightful ‘conclusion’ chapter. The latter should be substantially different from the former: it should be directly problem (and, usually, solution) orientated, summing up main findings and judgements without repeating contextual and other factual information (being pressed into an executive summary to enable readers to read only that piece of writing); it should instead refer back to parts of the report where basic factual information is provided; and it should link well points that are summed up to the parts of the report where they are analysed in greater detail. Moreover, a substantial conclusion invites the writer to link substantiated findings to any further general reflections that he or she may consider appropriate and useful (being also the defining characteristic of a ‘conclusion’ compared to a ‘summary’), and it facilitates formulation of any logically deduced and well-linked recommendations. By these provisions, readers who still want to be

informed in brief, and who may therefore jump directly to the concluding chapter, would still be more comprehensively exposed to core issues, they would be more triggered to reflect on them, and they would be more induced to read more of the report as well.

The second measure I would suggest is for the personnel of the user organisation to assess the need for any compressed version of the entire report or parts of it for their top executives and, if warranted, formulate that themselves. That would be fully compatible with general role and responsibility structures in public bureaucracies, for instance.

We shall end this chapter by presenting an example of the structure of a report from a primarily formative evaluation of a development scheme. The example is presented in Box 15.4. The evaluation was done by me, and is documented in Dale, 2002a.

#### **Box 15.4**

### **STRUCTURE OF EVALUATION REPORT ON A COMMUNITY INSTITUTION-BUILDING PROGRAMME**

#### **INTRODUCTION**

- The programme's *history*, in outline
- The programme's *conceptual foundation* and the general *organisation* of it
- The focus, *coverage* and methodology of *the study* and clarification of terminology used

#### **THE MEMBERSHIP**

- Bio-data of the *members*
- The members' *households*: *persons*, housing and household assets

#### **ORGANISATIONAL STRUCTURE AND FUNCTIONING**

- The *primary groups*: features and types of activities; financial operations
- The second-tier *societies*: history, constitution and membership; activities, work procedures and organisational culture; financial status and performance

#### **SAVING AND BORROWING BY THE MEMBERS' HOUSEHOLDS**

- Types of *savings*; taking and utilisation of *loans*

(Box 15.4 contd.)

(Box 15.4 contd.)

#### ORGANISATION ANALYSIS

- Cases of successful and unsuccessful organisations
- *Changing ideas* of organisational purpose, structure and function
- *Sustainability*: towards sustainable organisation and operation

#### BENEFITS FOR THE MEMBERS

- *Benefits* generated thus far: types and magnitude of benefits; cases of no or doubtful benefits
- *Options* for enhanced benefits

#### CONCLUSION

- *Summary* of main findings
- *Suggestions*: Inputs to further decision-making
- Matters for *further study*

The analysed scheme is a community development programme of the kind presented in Boxes 15.2 and 15.3, aiming at building community-based membership organisations for managing micro-financial services and other activities for the benefit of their members.

In the report, the basics of programme ideology, history, structure and operation are described, since they are considered to be necessary pieces of information for parts of the readership of this report (clarified in the box). However, this general and factual information is presented briefly, as necessary introductory matter to the analysis of various aspects of organisational performance and benefit-generation.

In this study, all the main analytical categories of evaluation that we have emphasised were addressed, although they were given different degrees of attention. This is reflected in the report structure. The most emphasised categories were relevance, impact and sustainability. A main thrust was analysis of the first two in relation to various groups of members, delimited by different criteria (a couple of examples being access to irrigated land, employment pattern, and features of the organisations to which the studied persons belonged). The main aspects of sustainability that were addressed were continued management and operation of the people's organisations, but sustainability of income-generating activities that were developed by members (or members' households) was also becoming an issue at the time of study and was, therefore, briefly examined.

A further essential point to note is that explanation is interrelated with description in the various chapters, rather than addressed in

separate chapters or sections. This is the only sensible way of analysing complex structures and processes typical of such programmes, clearly distinguishable from analysis based on experimental and other kinds of quantitative designs. In addition, reflecting a cumulative mode of analysis, much information in the earlier chapters is used for explanation in later chapters, directly focusing on the main analytical categories of benefit-generation and sustainability.

Additionally, the reader should note a substantial issue-oriented concluding chapter (taking up almost 15 per cent of the report space), and the effort to link to follow-up studies. The latter would be needed to make systematic evaluation an integral part of long-term programme development.



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